



CITY: Pg 3

CM: 13 zero-waste gaushalas, Ridge link in the works



NATION: Pg 5

AIADMK, DMK confident of winning



FILM: Pg 12

Divyenndu promises full 'paisa vasool ride'

EC CLAIMS PEACEFUL VOTING AMID SPORADIC TENSIONS

Record 92.84% voter turnout marks end of Bengal polls; 77 EVM complaints reported

'Voting percentage in 142 seats rose by over 16 per cent compared to 2021'

SOUMITRA NANDI

KOLKATA: The West Bengal Assembly polls concluded on Wednesday with what the Election Commission described as the state's highest-ever voter turnout, touching 92.84 per cent till 7 pm.

East Burdwan led the charts with 93.37 per cent, followed by Hooghly at 91.37 per cent. The impressive turnout has set the stage for a keenly anticipated results day on May 4, with political contenders expressing confidence about their chances of victory.

There was not a single major incident of violence resulting in grievous injuries on Wednesday, the Election Commission claimed.

However, the second phase of polling witnessed 77 complaints related to alleged malfunctioning or tampering of Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs), along with accusations of excesses by Central Forces in some constituencies



People wait in queues to cast votes during the second and final phase of the West Bengal Assembly elections, at a polling station in Nadia, on Wednesday

by the TMC.

"Out of the 77 complaints associated with EVMs, prima facie, we have verified 23 cases,

the majority from Falta in South 24-Parganas. We are awaiting a detailed report from the district electoral officers (DEOs),

returning officers (ROs) and observers that will come to us after a detailed exercise as per election norms.



BENGAL POLLS

- » According to the poll body, the highest number of EVM complaints 32 came from Falta, followed by Diamond Harbour 29, Mograhat 13 and 3 from Budget Budge, all in South 24-Parganas
- » 'Out of the 77 complaints associated with EVMs, prima facie, we have verified 23 cases, the majority from Falta in South 24-Parganas'
- » 'In 2021, 24 people were killed from the period of election announcement till counting. There were 60 cases of bombing with several injuries. In 2016, 7 deaths took place'
- » 'No unwanted entry or allegations of intimidation have been reported from any polling booths that were in the fray'

The decision regarding the repoll will be held based on the feedback from the field level. We are adopting zero tolerance

and wherever we get confirmed cases of taping on EVMs or any sort of tampering or manipulation that is

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ACCUSES SP AND CONGRESS OF ANTI-DEVELOPMENT STANCE

PM Modi inaugurates 594-km Ganga Expressway

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

HARDOI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday inaugurated the 594-km access-controlled greenfield Ganga Expressway in Uttar Pradesh's HarDOI and used the occasion to launch a sharp attack on the Samajwadi Party, accusing it of pursuing dynastic and caste-based politics and opposing development.

Addressing a public meeting, Modi said the state must remain cautious of the SP and its allies including Congress. He alleged that the party "can never rise above familism and casteism" and would continue to indulge in politics that hinders development.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the inauguration of the 594-km-long Ganga Expressway, in HarDOI

Built at an estimated cost of around ₹36,230 crore, the Ganga Expressway is expected to significantly improve connectivity

between Meerut and Prayagraj, reducing travel time from the current 10 to 12 hours to about six hours.

Describing the project as both a symbol of development and cultural heritage, the Prime Minister said naming

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CLOSER LOOK

- » Project built at an estimated cost of Rs 36,230 crore under a public-private partnership model
- » Connects Meerut to Prayagraj, cutting travel time from 10-12 hours to about six hours
- » Six-lane access-controlled expressway, expandable to eight lanes, with a design speed of 120 kmph
- » Features a 3.2-km airstrip near Shahjahanpur for emergency Indian Air Force landings

'Better get smart soon': Trump criticises Iran's nuclear stance

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Efforts to advance negotiations between Donald Trump and Iran showed little progress on Wednesday, with signs that talks aimed at ending the ongoing conflict had stalled. The US president, however, claimed earlier that Tehran had signalled it was in a "State of Collapse".

In a post on his Truth Social platform, Trump criticised Iran's approach to nuclear negotiations, saying it had failed to move toward an agreement. "Iran can't get their act together. They don't know how to sign a nonnuclear deal. They better get smart soon!" he wrote. The post also included an AI-generated image depicting Trump holding a weapon amid explosions, accompanied by the caption "NO MORE MR. NICE GUY."

Tensions surrounding Iran's nuclear programme had been rising even before the conflict erupted. Trump has repeatedly vowed to prevent Tehran from developing nuclear weapons. Iran, meanwhile, maintains its programme is for peaceful purposes, despite enriching uranium to levels close to weapons-grade.

Concerns over human rights in Iran have also intensified. The United Nations human rights chief, Volker Türk, reported that at least 21 people have been

Continued on P4



Great Nicobar project one of biggest scams, gravest crimes against natural, tribal heritage

Rahul Gandhi

In today's paper

CITY

NDMC LAUNCHES HEAT PLAN 3

NATION

PREZ TO MEET MANN 5

EDIT

DRIVING ECONOMIC SHIFT 7

INTERNATIONAL

ANOTHER RUSSIAN OIL FACILITY BURNS 8

BUSINESS

RUPEE FALLS 20 PAISE TO 94.88 PER DOLLAR 10

SPORT

PARAG IN VAPING ROW 11

MCD MAYORAL POLL

BJP's Pravesh Wahi elected MCD mayor

AAP abstains, flags 'horse-trading' concerns

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi witnessed a decisive political shift on Wednesday as the Bharatiya Janata Party secured a commanding victory in the mayoral elections, with Pravesh Wahi elected Mayor and Monika Pant as Deputy Mayor. The outcome was marked by the absence of the Aam Aadmi Party from the contest for the top posts, underscoring deepening political fault lines in the Capital's civic governance.

Wahi defeated Congress candidate Zarif by a wide margin, securing 156



BJP councillor from Rohini East, Pravesh Wahi addresses a press conference after he was elected Mayor

out of 165 votes polled, with no invalid ballots recorded. A former Leader of the House representing Ward 53

(Rohini-East), his elevation signals continuity in BJP's leadership within the MCD. Pant's election as Deputy Mayor further strengthened the party's grip on key civic positions.

The AAP's decision to abstain from contesting the mayoral and deputy mayoral elections drew sharp attention. AAP's committee member Rafia Mahir said the move was aimed at preventing alleged "horse-trading" and maintaining political integrity. She argued that the BJP's numerical advantage made the outcome predictable and accused the ruling party of underperformance over

Continued on P4

CYCLONIC CIRCULATION TRIGGERS SUDDEN WEATHER SHIFT

North gets rain relief after prolonged heatwave

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A spell of light rain and thunderstorms brought partial relief from persistent heat across large parts of north India on Wednesday, with temperatures dipping in several states even as weather agencies warned of continued variability in the coming days.

According to the India Meteorological Department, shifting atmospheric conditions led to cloudy skies, scattered showers and gusty winds across Delhi, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand, offering a break from the prolonged stretch of high temperatures. In the national capital, the maximum temperature at Safdarjung settled at around 37 degrees Celsius, a noticeable drop compared to recent days when readings remained above normal.



Meteorologists attributed the sudden change to a cyclonic circulation over areas adjoining Delhi. The weather office issued an alert for the evening, forecast-

ing generally cloudy skies with light rainfall, thunderstorms, lightning and surface winds of 30 to 40 kmph, with gusts reaching up to 50 kmph.

Delhi's weather this April has been marked by sharp contrasts.

The city has recorded spells of rain alongside periods of heat, along with occasional days of cleaner air. Official data shows that the capital has received 27.9 mm of rainfall so far this month, making it

Continued on P4

TAKEAWAYS

- » IMD linked changes to cyclonic circulation near Delhi
- » IMD forecast cloudy skies, light rain, lightning and winds up to 50 kmph
- » Delhi recorded 27.9 mm rainfall, its wettest April in nearly two decades
- » Himachal Pradesh received light to moderate rain; wet spell expected until May 5
- » Haryana and Punjab temperatures stayed up to 3°C below normal; Chandigarh hit 36.5°C

AHEAD OF THE 2026 BENGAL ELECTION RESULTS

TMC questions 'Exit Poll credibility', cites past misses

CREDIBILITY OF EXIT POLLS BENGAL POLLS 2021		
CHANNELS	AITC	BJP
INDIA TODAY	143	147
A abp	158	115
CNN NEWS 18	162	115
ACTUAL RESULTS		
	215	77

*AS SHARED BY DEREK O'BRIEN



AGNIHOTRI GUPTA

KOLKATA: The debate over the reliability of exit polls has resurfaced after Derek O'Brien flagged glaring discrepancies between predictions and actual results in previous elections in Bengal.

Highlighting past data, the Trinamool Congress (TMC) has argued that exit polls often fail to capture the true electoral mood in West Bengal, raising questions about their credibility ahead of the 2026 Assembly results.

The TMC's argument draws heavily from the 2021 West Bengal Assembly elections. Several major agencies projected a tight contest between TMC and the BJP.

For instance, India Today predicted 143 seats for TMC and 147 for BJP, while ABP and CNX gave TMC between

In 2026, the 'poll of polls' suggests the BJP could secure around 149 seats, with the TMC close behind at 140

158-162 seats and BJP around 115. However, the actual results told a very different story: TMC swept the polls with 215-216 seats, while BJP managed only 77. The gap between projections and reality was not marginal but massive, exposing structural flaws in polling methodologies.

A similar pattern emerged in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections in West Bengal. Most exit polls projected the BJP-led alliance ahead, with estimates ranging between 21 and 31 seats, while TMC was predicted to secure around 11 to 21 seats.

Continued on P4

Exit polls predict BJP win in Assam, edge in Bengal; DMK to return in TN, UDF to take Kerala

NEW DELHI: Several exit polls on Wednesday predicted a thumping victory for the BJP in Assam and an edge for the party over the ruling TMC in West Bengal, while projecting a return of the DMK government in Tamil Nadu and a comeback by the Congress-led UDF in Kerala after 10 years.

However, some pollsters predicted a big win for the TMC in West Bengal and a hung House in Tamil Nadu with actor-turned politician Vijay's TVK emerging as a spoiler for the DMK.

Almost all forecast a return to power for the AINRC-led NDA govern

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COMBAT DRILL



An Indian Navy helicopter carries out the maiden salvo launch of the Naval Anti-ship Missile-Short Range (NASM-SR) off the Odisha coast

Officials in Maha no longer required to greet MLAs, MPs who are convicted or facing charges

MUMBAI: The Maharashtra government has revised its official protocol, stating that civil servants are no longer required to stand or greet legislators or Members of Parliament who have been convicted, are under investigation, or are visiting offices for election-related procedures.

The change was formalised through a Government Resolution issued on April 28, 2026, updating earlier instructions dated November 20, 2025. The previous directive had made it mandatory for officials to rise and greet elected representatives at the beginning and end of meetings, as well as upon their arrival and departure.

Under the new guidelines,

this practice will not apply in situations where lawmakers are convicted in criminal or other cases, are appearing for inquiries or hearings, or are present for election-related processes such as filing nominations or scrutiny. Officials have been instructed to treat such individuals like any ordinary citizen and to follow legal norms without offering additional courtesies.

The amendment, signed by Chief Secretary Rajesh Aggrawal, seeks to reinforce neutrality in administrative conduct. A senior official familiar with the development told The Indian Express that the revision aims to prevent any perception of bias.

"It is important for government officials

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AN UNUSUAL APRIL FOR CAPITAL IN 2026

Temp drops, clean air, rain, extreme heat

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi witnessed a striking mix of weather conditions in April this year, with spells of rain, bouts of heat and occasional days of cleaner air, making it the wettest April in over a decade, among the least polluted, and one of the coolest in recent years.

The city recorded its wettest April in 18 years, with pre-monsoon showers lashing parts of the capital, particularly in the first half of the month. So far, Delhi has received 27.9 mm of rainfall this April, compared to 38.6 mm recorded in April 2008, according to official data.

Despite phases of intense heat, the capital also logged one of its coolest Aprils in two years, with an average maximum temperature of around 37 degrees Celsius. Notably, only one heatwave day has



been recorded so far, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The rainfall, coupled with gusty winds, also helped improve air quality, making this April the cleanest in four

years, according to an analysis by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA).

The city recorded an average Air Quality Index (AQI) of 179 till April 28, with one "satisfactory", 17

HIGHLIGHTS

» City recorded its wettest April in 18 yrs, with pre-monsoon showers lashing parts of the capital, particularly in the first half of the month

» So far, Delhi has received 27.9 mm of rainfall this April, compared to 38.6 mm recorded in April 2008, according to official data. At end of the month, city saw a noticeable dip in temp

it was 180. The highest recent April pollution levels were seen in 2022, when the AQI touched 255, with most days falling in the "poor" category.

Experts attributed the improved air quality and lower temperatures to early pre-monsoon activity. "Pre-monsoon showers between March 15 and April 15 helped keep temperatures in check.

Even though temperatures rose later, the overall average remained lower," said Mahesh Palawat of Skymet Weather.

Even towards the end of the month, the city saw a noticeable dip in temperatures. On Wednesday, Safdarjung recorded a maximum of 37.1 degrees Celsius, 1.9 degrees below normal, while the minimum dropped sharply to 20.4 degrees Celsius, 3.4 degrees below normal.

Similar trends were

observed across Palam, Lodhi Road and Ridge, all recording below-normal temperatures.

Ayanagar remained the warmest location, with a maximum of 39.5 degrees Celsius, close to normal levels.

The IMD has forecast generally cloudy skies with very light to light rain, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds reaching up to 50 kmph in the coming days. The maximum temperature is expected to hover around 36 degrees Celsius, with further dips in minimum temperatures.

While skies are likely to clear briefly on May 1 and 2, another western disturbance may bring thunderstorms and rain between May 3 and 5.

Meanwhile, Delhi's air quality remained in the "moderate" category, with an AQI of 183, as per the Central Pollution Control Board.

Delhi logs 7,800 fire calls in 2026

20% spike from last year's figures

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 7,800 fire-related emergencies have been reported across the capital in the first four months of 2026, with over 2,300 (around 30 per cent) incidents in April alone, with rising summer heat exacerbating fire risks across the city.

The Delhi Fire Services (DFS) attended 7,801 fire calls till April 27, which is 1,290 more than the 6,511 cases reported during the corresponding period last year, marking a nearly 20 per cent increase, according to official data.

In April, as many as 2,375 fire-related cases were reported till the 27th, slightly lower than the 2,688 calls till April 27 last year, a decline of 313 incidents or nearly 12 per cent.

Yet, April recorded 837 more incidents than March, a rise of about 54 per cent, showing a sharp uptick as temperatures spiked.

The upward trend of fire incidents has been visible since the beginning of the year. In January, the DFS handled 1,396 calls, up from 938 last year, an increase of 458 incidents or around 49 per cent.

The spike was sharper in February, with 2,492 calls compared to 1,076 in February last year, an increase of over 130 per cent, the data shows.

Number of cases fell slightly in March, with 1,538 calls this year against 1,809 in the month last year, a drop of 271 inci-



dents or about 15 per cent.

Officials said the increase in fire incidents is largely linked to summer conditions. Rising temperatures prompt increased use of air conditioners and other electrical appliances, putting more load on wiring and transformers, while dry weather makes it easier for fires to spread.

"There is no single specific reason behind the increase in fire calls. Heat is not the only factor, but it is certainly a major one. As temperatures rise, the load on the electrical infrastructure increases significantly. Air conditioners run continuously, wiring heats up, and transformers operate under stress, which raises the chances of short circuits and fire incidents," a DFS official stated.

Fire incidents have risen sharply in Delhi, with the DFS attending around 120 calls daily in April, up from 70-80 in previous months. On some days, calls touched 200 amid intense heat, including major blazes in Palam that killed nine and Laxmi Nagar where 14 were rescued.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

AAP's Durgesh Pathak refuses to appear before Justice Kanta Sharma

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Following in the footsteps of AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal and Manish Sisodia, party leader Durgesh Pathak has also refused to participate in the proceedings in the ongoing liquor excise case being heard by Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma of the Delhi High Court. In a letter addressed to the judge, Pathak said he agrees with the concerns raised by Kejriwal -- who alleged a conflict of interest against the judge -- and added that he will not appear in person or through a legal representative before the court.

Pathak, Sisodia and Kejriwal are parties to a revision plea filed by the CBI challenging their discharge in the liquor policy case.

"The present communication pertains to the above-mentioned revision petition, which is currently sub-judice before this court," Pathak said in the letter.

He said he took the decision after going through Kejriwal's letter dated April 27, in which concerns over bias and perceived lack of impartiality were raised. "Accordingly, I too have resolved not to participate further in the present proceedings, either personally or through legal representation. The vakalatnama, if any, executed in my favour in this matter may be treated as having been duly discharged," he said.

Pathak said his letter should not be seen as a sign of disrespect towards the court and reaffirmed his faith in the Constitution and the judiciary.

"I take this opportunity to unequivocally affirm my abiding faith in the Constitution of India and in the institutional integrity of the judiciary of this nation," he said.



He requested that the letter be taken on record and that the proceedings be conducted in a manner the court considers appropriate and just.

Meanwhile, Leader of Opposition in the Delhi Assembly Atishi questioned why Justice Sharma did not recuse herself from the case after Kejriwal raised concerns, claiming that she had done so in other matters recently.

She asked what was different in the present case that a recusal was not being considered.

Meanwhile, the Delhi High Court on Wednesday said it will hear on May 4 the CBI's petition challenging the discharge of Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case. Even as the AAP leaders boycotted proceedings before Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma, the court granted them a final opportunity to file replies by Saturday. The hearing was deferred as the court awaited the complete trial court record. It also issued notice on a plea seeking vacation of an interim stay and listed the Enforcement Directorate's petition against certain trial court remarks for May 4.

During coordinated operations carried out over a fortnight in Delhi and Uttar Pradesh, police recovered 23 firearms, including several foreign-made semi-automatic pistols, along with 92 live cartridges, magazines and weapon repair equipment. Officials said the group sourced weapons from across the border, routing them into India via the Nepal

Retd engineer duped of over Rs 10 cr in 'digital arrest' scam; CBI takes over case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The CBI has registered a case in connection with the "digital arrest" of a 73-year-old retired engineer from Delhi's Rohini who was allegedly cheated to the tune of Rs 10 crore, and taken over the investigation from the special cell of Delhi Police, officials said on Wednesday.

The septuagenarian was alleged targeted by a group

The cyber-criminals coerced him to shell out money through a series of transactions

of cyber-criminals posing as employees of a multinational courier company, in October 2024. They claimed that a consentment booked using his Aadhaar card to China was returned.

Subsequently, they connected him to their associates posing as officers from Mum-

bai Police who coerced him to shell out money through a series of transactions in name of police and the Enforcement Directorate chief.

The victim, who lived with his wife in Rohini's Sector 10, allegedly transferred more than Rs 10.3 crore to the frauds.

Based on his complaint,

Delhi Police busts international arms racket, nine apprehended

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Special Cell of Delhi Police has dismantled an international arms trafficking syndicate operating across north India, arresting nine key operatives and recovering a large cache of illegal weapons and ammunition.

Acting on a tip-off, investigators uncovered a network allegedly run by fugitive Shahbaz Ansari and his uncle Rehan Ansari, with suspected cross-border links. The syndicate is believed to have supplied sophisticated firearms across Delhi-NCR and parts of Uttar Pradesh.

During coordinated operations carried out over a fortnight in Delhi and Uttar Pradesh, police recovered 23 firearms, including several foreign-made semi-automatic pistols, along with 92 live cartridges, magazines and weapon repair equipment. Officials said the group sourced weapons from across the border, routing them into India via the Nepal



corridor before distributing them to criminal networks.

The operation was led by a Special Cell team under Inspector Sunil Teotia, supervised by ACP Kailash Singh Bisht, following sustained intelligence inputs and technical surveillance. The crackdown began on April 14 with the arrest of a 22-year-old suspect in Usmanpur, from whom a pistol and ammunition were recovered. His interrogation led to further arrests across locations including Shastrī Park, Khurja, Loni and Jaunpur.

A major breakthrough came on April 20 with the arrest of a key supplier in Jaunpur, leading to the seizure of 12 semi-automatic pistols and a

substantial quantity of ammunition. Investigations revealed a structured hierarchy within the syndicate, with Shahbaz Ansari acting as the main handler and Rehan Ansari overseeing logistics, finances and communication. Other members functioned as couriers, distributors and local facilitators.

Police said the group relied on encrypted communication platforms and a decentralised network to evade law enforcement agencies. The weapons were supplied to various criminal groups, raising concerns over their potential use in serious offences. Further investigation is underway to trace the syndicate's full international links.

Three nabbed after high-speed chase; 17 boxes of illicit liquor seized: Cops

NEW DELHI: Three alleged bootleggers were arrested after a high-speed chase during which they rammed a police vehicle while attempting to escape in northwest Delhi's Keshavpuram, an official said on Wednesday.

The incident took place around 5 am when a police team on night patrol spotted a suspicious white car, he said. Assistant Sub-Inspector Mohit, Head Constables Lakshmi Kant, Sanjeev, and Deepak were patrolling the area to prevent vehicle theft and maintain law and order when they noticed the car, police said.

"When the team signalled the vehicle to stop, the occupants attempted to flee and drove recklessly, deliberately ramming into a government vehicle to evade interception," a senior police officer said.

Despite the attack, the police team pursued the car and intercepted it after a brief chase. Three persons -- identified as Neeraj, Pintu and Brijesh -- were apprehended, officials said.

A search of the car led to the recovery of 17 boxes of illicit liquor, which were later seized, police said. The accused have been taken into custody.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of Delhi Police has arrested three men for allegedly running an interstate fake visa and overseas job racket that duped hundreds of job seekers with false promises of employment abroad. The accused have been identified as Salauddin Mansuri alias Haider Khan (33) from Siwan in Bihar, Kaushar (33) from Kushinagar in Uttar Pradesh, and Mohd Shahzad (33) from Ghaziabad in Uttar Pradesh.



Delhi Police's anti-drug campaign "Nasha - Not Cool" continued to expand with support from National Service Scheme volunteers, who organised awareness activities across colleges on its sixth day

Fire breaks out in Gzb high-rise; residents rescued, no casualties

Over 17 fire tenders deployed; UP CM orders probe

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A massive fire broke out at Gaur Green Avenue society in Abhay Khand, Indirapuram, on Wednesday morning. Thick plumes of smoke were seen rising from the high-rise complex as multiple fire tenders rushed to the spot soon after the blaze was reported.

According to fire department officials, the fire affected flats between the ninth and eleventh floors of the building. While initial estimates suggest that five to six flats were directly impacted, some residents claimed that up to 10-12 units may have suffered damage. The exact extent of the loss is yet to be fully assessed.

Residents were evacuated in haste as flames spread rapidly through parts of the structure. Chief Fire Officer Rahul Kumar told that no casualties have been reported. "Some people were trapped, but they have



Blaze spreads across upper floors of tower

been safely rescued. The fire has been completely contained," he said. He added that over 17 fire tenders, along with hydraulic equipment, were deployed to control the blaze.

Officials noted that some of the affected flats were locked at the time of the incident, while others sustained partial dam-

age. A resident, Rohit, suspected that an electrical fault might have triggered the fire, although authorities have not confirmed the cause.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has directed the police commissioner and district magistrate to reach the site and ensure prompt relief measures. A detailed investigation has been initiated to ascertain the exact cause of the fire.

Landlord in cop net for tenant's murder

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old man walked into a police station in Shalimar Bagh, northwest Delhi, on Monday evening and confessed to killing his tenant, allegedly over suspicions of an illicit relationship with his wife.

The accused, identified as Virender, a resident of Indira Colony, approached police at around 4.20 pm and admitted to murdering Kanhaiya (29) inside his jhuggi. Acting on the confession, police teams rushed to the spot, where they found the victim lying on a bed with his throat slit and multiple stab wounds.

The alleged murder weapon was recovered from the scene. Police said the accused was still wearing blood-stained clothes at the time of surrender, strengthening the prima facie case against him.

Preliminary investigation suggests Virender suspected the victim, his tenant, of having an illicit relationship with his wife, which may have trig-



Body has been sent for post-mortem examination: Police

gered the attack. CCTV footage from the area corroborated his presence at the scene around the time of the crime.

A crime team, along with forensic experts and an executive magistrate, inspected the spot and collected evidence. The body has been sent for post-mortem examination.

A case has been registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and further investigation is underway to establish the full sequence of events.

TO PROVIDE CATTLE A MORE NATURAL HABITAT

CM: 13 zero-waste gaushalas, Ridge link in the works

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to blend cattle welfare with environmental sustainability, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday announced that 13 new “zero-waste” gaushalas will be set up across the Capital, alongside plans to link them with the Ridge and forest areas to provide a more natural habitat for cattle.

The announcement was made during the ‘Pran Pratishtha’ ceremony at a newly constructed Ram temple within the gaushala premises of the Delhi Pinjrapole Society in Kishanganj, in the presence of Union Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal, MP Yogender Chandel, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta and MLA Ashok Goel, among others.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister highlighted the challenges faced by existing gaushalas, stating, “Several gaushalas are currently operating in limited spaces while accommodating a large number of cattle, adversely affecting their health.” She added that the government is committed to ensuring “adequate space and a natural environment for cows” in the upcoming facilities. Until the new gaushalas are constructed and relocation is completed, she assured that veterinary services and essential support will continue at existing shelters.

Emphasising the broader vision, Gupta said, “These gaushalas will be developed on a modern model, with facilities such as biogas plants, veterinary hospitals, solar plants and zero-waste management systems.” She further informed that the government is working towards establishing at least one gaushala in every district, with suitable



HIGHLIGHTS

- » These gaushalas will be developed on a modern model, with facilities such as biogas plants, veterinary hospitals, solar plants and zero-waste management systems’
- » The service and care of cows is not merely a tradition but also a cultural and spiritual responsibility of society: CM Rekha Gupta

able locations already identified. During her visit, the Chief Minister fed green fodder to cows and underscored the cultural significance of cattle care, saying, “The service and care of cows is not merely a tradition but also a cultural and spiritual responsibility of society,” while urging collective participation in this effort. Focusing on sustainability, Gupta noted that biogas plants are being planned for scientific

disposal of cow dung. “This will not only improve sanitation but also generate energy,” she said, adding that the government aims to install six such plants over the next two years. She also announced that Rs 100 crore has been approved for the redevelopment of dairy colonies.

Highlighting the ecological aspect, Gupta said the government is working on a plan to connect gaushalas with Delhi’s Ridge and forest areas, enabling cattle to live and move in a more natural environment.

Praising gaushala operators and social workers, she described their efforts as “a sacred and divine responsibility.” She added, “Nearly Rs 24 crore for the current year has already been released ahead of schedule to ensure that service activities are not disrupted,” noting that pending grants, land lease issues and utility concerns were addressed on priority.

She expressed confidence that coordinated efforts between the government and society would significantly strengthen cattle protection in Delhi.

Delhi govt relaxes wheat procurement norms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at protecting farmers from losses due to adverse weather, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday announced major relaxations in wheat procurement norms for the ongoing Rabi Marketing Season (RMS) 2026–27.

The Chief Minister said the decision was taken after the Delhi government urged the Centre on April 21 to ease quality

standards, following widespread crop damage. “Ensuring fair value for the hard work of our annadatas is our responsibility,” Gupta said, adding that the step will help prevent distress sales at lower prices.

Under the revised norms, wheat with up to 70 per cent loss of lustre will now be accepted for procurement. The permissible limit for shrivelled and broken grains has also been increased from 6 per cent to 15 per cent. However, officials

clarified that broken and slightly broken grains together must not exceed 6 per cent to maintain quality balance.

Gupta emphasised that wheat procured under these relaxed conditions will be managed separately. “Such grain will be stored independently from regular stock, with a distinct accounting system to ensure full transparency,” she said.

She added that the procured wheat will be prioritised

for early use and will not be stored for long durations.

The Chief Minister also noted that the wheat procured under these provisions will be used strictly within Delhi to meet local food requirements. She said the Delhi government will take full responsibility for any deterioration in quality during storage.

Reiterating the government’s commitment to farmers, Gupta said the decision is a crucial step towards safe-

guarding their interests while strengthening food security in the capital. She directed officials to ensure that the procurement process is carried out in a transparent and time-bound manner so that benefits reach farmers without delay.

The Delhi government, she added, is prepared to bear any financial or operational burden arising from the relaxed norms, underlining its commitment to stand firmly with farmers during challenging times.

Boost for homoeopathy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is working to strengthen homoeopathy services and integrate AYUSH systems with mainstream healthcare, Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said on Wednesday.

According to a statement, the government marked World Homoeopathy Day 2026 with a scientific seminar at the NDMC Convention Centre on the 271st birth anniversary of Samuel Hahnemann.

The seminar, themed “Homoeopathy in the Era of Integrative Medicine: Bridging Traditions, Advancing Health”, was jointly organised by the Delhi State AYUSH Society and the Directorate of AYUSH, marking the first such collaboration between the two.

“Homoeopathy has immense potential in addressing today’s healthcare challenges, especially in stress management and chronic conditions. The Delhi Government is committed to strengthening AYUSH infrastructure and ensuring its effective integration with mainstream healthcare,” Singh said, according to the statement.

He said over 120 homoeopathic dispensaries across Delhi are providing free consultation and medicines, catering to nearly 19 lakh patients annually, reflecting growing public trust in the system.

The minister added that the government is working to open new polyclinics, address staff shortages and expand services, particularly in underserved areas.

CM: 87 GST officials assigned wards through transparent lottery system

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Asserting a “zero tolerance” policy against corruption, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday announced that 87 GST officials have been assigned wards through a lottery system.

This comes after Gupta, earlier this month, had made a surprise visit to the Trade and Taxes building and found several officers absent from duty. Following this, around 162 officials were transferred to the state GST office.

“In a first-of-its-kind initiative, the Trade and Taxes Department has introduced a lottery system (draw of lots) to assign postings to newly inducted GST officers and



inspectors,” the chief minister said. Gupta said Delhi follows a strict ‘zero tolerance’ policy against corruption, and this initiative is a strong step in that direction.

“The aim is to ensure that every appointment, posting and administrative decision is rule-based, transparent and impartial, encouraging honest officers and reinforcing public trust in

governance,” she added.

Such transparent systems not only strengthen administrative functioning but also foster confidence and satisfaction among employees, ultimately improving departmental efficiency and delivering better services to taxpayers, she said.

Gupta also said that the Delhi government is considering implementing similar transparent and technology-driven systems in other departments in the future to further strengthen good governance. She informed that all these officers had been transferred to the department under a service order dated April 23. A total of 87 GST officers and inspectors were allotted postings across various wards through this system.



Delhi hikes ECC on commercial vehicles

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has notified an increase in the Environmental Compensation Charge (ECC) on commercial vehicles entering the Capital, following directions of the Supreme Court, in a major step to curb vehicular pollution.

The revised ECC aims to act as a strong deterrent against polluting vehicles, especially diesel-run commercial traffic, and promote cleaner transport alternatives. As per the new rates, Category 2 (light duty vehicles) and Category 3 (two-axle trucks) will now pay Rs 2,000, up from Rs 1,400. Category 4 (three-axle trucks) and Category 5 (four-axle and above) will be charged Rs 4,000, increased from Rs 2,600. Environment

Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said, “This is a landmark step in Delhi’s fight against air pollution. The revised ECC is not merely a revenue measure but a strong environmental deterrent.”

A 5 per cent annual escalation in ECC has also been mandated from April each year to maintain its deterrent value and gradually shift transporter behaviour towards cleaner options. The move follows recommendations of the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), which noted that the ECC fixed in 2015 had lost effectiveness over time.

The Supreme Court also stressed that non-essential commercial vehicles should use bypass expressways instead of entering Delhi, reducing congestion and pollution.

Govt holds stakeholders’ meet on Draft EV Policy, focuses on inclusive EV growth

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Wednesday held a stakeholders’ consultation on the Draft EV Policy 2026 under Transport Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh, bringing together key players from the electric mobility ecosystem to refine the policy framework.

Leading aggregators such as Ola, Uber, Rapido and logistics platforms including Porter participated, along with companies like Zomato, Swiggy, Blinkit and Flipkart. Industry bodies and technical organisations also shared inputs.

The consultation was divided into five thematic sessions covering OEM associations, vehicle scrappers, government departments,



fleet aggregators and battery recyclers. Discussions focused on manufacturing, scrappage alignment, inter-departmental coordination, fleet electrication, and battery lifecycle management.

Stakeholders emphasised the need for expanded charging infrastructure, affordable

financing, and inclusion of last-mile mobility segments such as e-rickshaws. They also called for streamlined registration processes and targeted support for gig workers.

Addressing the gathering, Singh said Delhi’s next EV policy will deepen adoption across sectors while ensuring environmental sustainability and economic viability. “The policy will be shaped by collective stakeholder inputs to create a future-ready and inclusive EV ecosystem,” he said. Separately, at Talkatora Stadium, the minister assured e-rickshaw drivers of improved facilities, better regulation and upcoming policy support, while also announcing heatwave relief measures including drinking water and cold boxes at bus stations.

City Briefs

SEVERAL GURUGRAM SCHOOLS RECEIVE HOAX BOMB THREATS

GURUGRAM: Several Gurugram schools received another hoax bomb threat emails on Wednesday morning, prompting police to launch searches on the premises. Police said the email was sent by the ‘Khalistan National Army’, with threats issued to Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini to declare April 29 as the “40th Khalistan Declaration Day”. It also threatened to bomb the Red Fort in Delhi.

HANSRAJ COLLEGE REVOKES SUSPENSION OF STUDENTS’ UNION OFFICE BEARERS

NEW DELHI: A day after a core disciplinary committee meeting was held in Delhi University’s Hansraj College to reconsider suspension notices issued to 30 students, the committee revoked the suspension of the students’ union office bearers. The notice, uploaded on the college website on Wednesday, mentioned, “In view of the observations made by the Special Core Sub-Discipline Committee, after hearing the concerned students, and the recommendations made by the Students’ Welfare & Discipline Committee, suspension of office bearers of the Hansraj College Students’ Union is hereby terminated. Students are advised to adhere to the SOP published by Hansraj College on its website, failing which appropriate proceedings may be initiated as per the provisions.”

Transport dept withdraws old circular for bulk registration of E-rickshaws

NEW DELHI: The Delhi transport department on Wednesday withdrew its old circular that permitted companies to register multiple electric carts and electric rickshaws in their names.

“By preventing the concentration of ownership in the hands of a few companies or firms, the government aims to promote self-employment and reduce exploitation of economically weaker sections,” transport minister Pankaj Singh said. The Delhi transport department has withdrawn its April 21, 2022, circular.

He said key advantages of the decision include greater economic opportunities for owner-drivers, reduced risk of monopolistic control over the e-rickshaw sector, and enhanced support for self-reliant employment models.

‘I JOINED THE RSS WHEN I WAS 10 YEARS OLD’

Pravesh Wahi: RSS roots to Delhi Mayor’s office

NEW DELHI: Newly elected Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi, a three-term councillor with a long organisational background in the BJP and the RSS, has outlined cleanliness and waterlogging as his immediate priorities after taking charge as the city’s mayor. According to Wahi, his association with public life began early through the RSS and later, he joined the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP).

“I joined the RSS when I was 10 years old,” Wahi said, adding that he later served in the VHP till the late 1990s.

He said he formally joined the BJP in 2002. “I rose through the party ranks, holding organisational roles before entering electoral politics,” he said.

Wahi was first elected a councillor in 2007 and has since served multiple terms, including stints as chairman of the Rohini zonal committee and later the

standing committee in the erstwhile North Corporation.

“I was first elected councillor in 2007 from Rohini, then Naharpur, and served a second term from 2012 to 2017,” he said. Educated in Delhi, Wahi studied at an MCD school in Old Delhi.

“I come from a non-political family background,” he said, adding, “although one of my uncles introduced me to the RSS and its daily activities. That’s how I joined Sangh.”

During his tenure, Wahi also held key positions, including chairman of the Rohini zonal committee between 2010 and 2012 and chairman of the standing committee in the erstwhile North Corporation from 2016 to 2017.

Wahi, who belongs to a Punjabi Khatri family with roots in Rawalpindi (Pakistan), said improving sanitation across

markets, residential areas and public spaces would be his primary focus.

Door-to-door garbage collection and waste segregation are key challenges for the MCD, Wahi said, adding that private participation was being brought in to ease the burden on landfill sites.

He acknowledged that overlapping responsibilities among agencies had led to confusion in the past but said steps were being taken to address the issue.

Referring to the long-pending task of clearing garbage dumps, Wahi said, “Progress had been slow earlier, but work is now picking up pace.”

He said there was no shortage of funds from the Delhi government and stressed that coordination between different levels of governance remained key to addressing civic concerns.

NDMC launches heat plan

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council on Wednesday launched a comprehensive “Heat Wave Mitigation Action Plan” alongside a city-wide bird welfare initiative, as temperatures in the Capital continue to rise.

The Vice Chairperson of NDMC, Kuljeet Singh Chahal, inaugurated the programme at Satya Sadan and Chanakyapuri Park, where earthen water bowls were placed for birds. The initiative emphasises on environmental responsibility, aims to address the dual challenge of heat stress and ecological preservation.

Officials highlighted that although NDMC governs only a small portion of Delhi’s geographical area, it maintains nearly 55 per cent green cover, including spaces such as Nehru Park, Lodhi Garden and Sanjay Lake. These green zones support a significant bird population, making conservation efforts crucial during extreme weather.

Under the initiative, more than 1,000 earthen bowls will be installed across parks, public institutions, and residential



areas. Civic authorities have also appealed to Resident Welfare Associations and Market Traders Associations to participate by placing water for birds in their localities.

The heatwave action plan focuses on safeguarding municipal workers and schoolchildren. Field staff will begin work earlier to avoid peak afternoon heat, while provisions such as ORS, safe drinking water, and protective gear have been mandated. Outdoor work between noon and 3 p.m. will be minimised, and medical teams have been put on alert to respond to heat-related illnesses.

VICTIMS INCLUDED FROM KERALA HAD COME ON A STUDY TOUR

B'luru: Seven killed in govt hospital wall collapse, CM orders probe

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Seven people, including a child, were killed and seven others injured when the compound wall of the city's Bowring and Lady Curzon Hospital collapsed due to heavy rains here on Wednesday, police said. Officials had initially said three children were killed, but the Chief Minister's Office (CMO) later clarified that only a six-year old girl was among the deceased.

The victims included those from Kerala, and had come here as part of a study tour.



Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar visits the site of a wall collapse following heavy rain, at Bowring Hospital, in Bengaluru

When heavy rains, coupled with strong winds and a hail-storm, battered the area, vic-

tims taking shelter near a wall were trapped when it suddenly collapsed. Seven people were

killed on the spot. Police and emergency services personnel rushed to the spot with an earthmover to bring out the bodies and the injured from the debris with the help of other citizens.

Learning about the incident, Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah visited the spot along with the Greater Bengaluru Authority Chief Commissioner M Maheshwar Rao and Bengaluru Police Commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh to take stock of the situation. Siddaramaiah took the GBA

officials to task for the tragedy. Briefing reporters after the spot inspection, the chief minister said, "Seven people have died....seven people are injured. All of them are stable. They are all out of danger. I have told the doctors to provide treatment free of cost." "Rs 5 lakh solatium will be given to the kin of each deceased. Because, unfortunately, those who died are very poor people — traders, street vendors," he added. Siddaramaiah said an inquiry will be conducted to find out why the wall collapsed.

From Page 1

Record 92.84%

tantamount to vitiating the poll, repoll will be held," Bengal Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Manoj Agarwal said.

According to the poll body, the highest number of EVM complaints 32 came from Falta, followed by Diamond Harbour 29, Mograhat 13 and 3 from Budget Budge, all in South 24-Parganas.

Sporadic disturbances were reported from a few pockets, but prompt intervention by central forces and the police ensured that situations were brought under control quickly. The Trinamool Congress, however, alleged excess by central force, particularly from Bhowanipore, where TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee is pitted against Leader of the Opposition Suvedu Adhikari.

There was brief tension at Ward 73 as rival groups raised slogans of "Jai Bangla" and "Jai Shri Ram". Central forces resorted to a lathi-charge to disperse the crowd.

In Satgachia, a child was allegedly injured during a lathi-charge by Central Forces. The child's family members alleged that the minor was hit while forces were trying to control unrest.

Reacting to allegations of excess of central forces, the CEO said that the central forces are well aware of the laws and have been trained properly. "They have acted as per directions of the police and have supplemented police orders," he added.

He maintained that the central forces were handed over lathis for the first time during this election. "Sometimes in certain instances, the mob turns so unruly that they have to resort to a lathi charge," said Agarwal.

The CEO said that during these elections, there has not been a single death during the campaign period till the conclusion of the polls. Complementing the CEO's claim, state police nodal officer Anand Kumar said there has not been a single case of bombing either during the election period this year.

"In 2021, 24 people were killed from the period of election announcement till counting. There were 60 cases of bombing with several injuries. In 2016, 7 deaths took place," said Kumar.

He added that 90 persons were arrested on Wednesday in specific cases related to law and order issues, while 387 preventive arrests were made.

"Whatever sporadic incidents associated with law and order happened were outside the periphery of polling stations. No unwanted entry or allegations of intimidation have been reported from any polling booths that were in the fray," said Agarwal.

In Kolkata South and Kolkata North, where voting over 70 per cent has been a rarity in previous elections, a record voting of 87.22 per cent and 88.88 per cent, respectively. South 24-Parganas saw 91.36 per cent polling, while North 24-Parganas witnessed 91.32 and Nadia 91.29. Howrah also registered 90.36 per cent voting.

The voting percentage in 142 seats rose by over 16 per cent compared to 2021, when it stood at 76.3 per cent.

The CEO expressed his optimism that with the final calculations, the voting percentage will increase further and may well touch the poll percentage of 93 of the first phase.

The apex poll body declared that the voting percentage of 92.47 (till 7 pm) has been the highest in Bengal since independence. In the 2011 general elections, there was partici-

pation of 84.72 per cent of electors — the highest till this year's elections broke all records.

The unfortunate death of 82-year-old Purna Chandra Dolui was reported under the Udaynaryanpur Assembly seat in Howrah. After casting his vote, the octogenarian fell down near the voting compartment, reportedly due to illness. He was declared brought dead at Amta Hospital.

The poll body deployed a record 2,343 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) in the second phase, along with a huge deployment of state police, Quick Response Teams, flying squads, widespread CCTV and webcast monitoring. The results will be counted on May 4.

'Exit Poll credibility'

Yet, the final results again defied expectations- TMC secured 29 seats, while BJP was reduced to just 12. Once more, exit polls underestimated TMC's performance and overestimated the BJP prospects.

Against this backdrop, the 2026 Assembly exit polls have predicted a close fight, with many agencies placing the BJP ahead or near the majority mark. The "poll of polls" suggests the BJP could secure around 149 seats, with the TMC close behind at 140, and others taking a marginal share. Individual agency projections vary, but a consistent narrative emerges- an edge for the BJP in a tightly contested race.

However, TMC leaders argue that these projections should be treated with caution, given the historical inaccuracies. They contend that exit polls often fail to account for silent voters, regional dynamics, and last-minute shifts- factors that have repeatedly worked in TMC's favour in the past.

As the counting day approaches, the credibility of exit polls once again hangs in the balance.

Whether 2026 will follow the pattern of 2021 and 2024 or mark a departure remains to be seen. For now, the TMC's stance is clear: past evidence suggests that exit polls in Bengal are far from definitive indicators of electoral outcomes. The party is confident of winning 230 seats this time.

PM Modi

the expressway after the Ganga reflects the government's vision. "Just as the Ganga has been the lifeline of this region for centuries, this expressway will become a new lifeline for Uttar Pradesh's development in modern times," he said. He added that the new corridor would enable faster access to religious destinations such as the Sangam in Prayagraj and Kashi.

Modi said the era of delayed infrastructure projects is over, noting that earlier governments would announce projects that remained stuck in files for years.

"Now, projects are not only announced but also completed within a fixed timeline," he said, attributing this to the "double-engine government".

Highlighting the broader impact, the Prime Minister said the expressway would connect different parts of the state while bringing the opportunities of the National Capital Region closer to eastern Uttar Pradesh.

In his address, Modi also referred to ongoing and recent elections in other states, including West Bengal, Bihar and Gujarat, claiming that voters were participating without fear and that the BJP had secured strong mandates. He expressed confidence that the party would continue its winning streak

in upcoming election results.

Calling modern expressways the "lifelines of a developed India", Modi said such infrastructure projects reflect the country's rapid progress and would accelerate economic growth across regions.

The expressway connects 12 key districts of Meerut, Hapur, Bulandshahr, Amroha, Sambhal, Badaun, Shahjahanpur, Hardoi, Unnao, Rae Bareilly, Pratapgarh and Prayagraj and is expected to significantly reduce travel time while ensuring faster, safer and more convenient movement.

Developed under a public-private partnership model, the project has been constructed as a six-lane expressway with provision for expansion to eight lanes, with a design speed of 120 kmph.

One of its key features is a 3.2-km-long airstrip near Shahjahanpur for emergency landing of Air Force aircraft. The expressway is also equipped with an Intelligent Traffic Management System (ITMS), CCTV surveillance, emergency call boxes, ambulances and patrolling units to ensure safety, according to the statement.

It stated that integrated manufacturing and logistics clusters (IMLCs) are being developed along the corridor, with facilities such as warehouses, cold storage units and food processing hubs aimed at attracting investment and generating employment.

The expressway will also be connected to other major corridors, including the Purvanchal, Agra-Lucknow, Bundelkhand and Gorakhpur Link expressways, creating a vast interconnected network, the statement said.

The project is also being positioned as an economic engine. The expressway is expected to evolve into a large-scale manufacturing and logistics corridor, with investment proposals worth Rs 46,660 crore already lined up. This is likely to strengthen the government's narrative around job creation, industrial growth and rural-urban integration.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has consistently framed infrastructure as the backbone of a "new Uttar Pradesh," and the Ganga Expressway is being showcased as the flagship of that model. The corridor complements existing projects like the Purvanchal and Bundelkhand expressways, reinforcing a development-driven political pitch.

Trump criticises

executed since the war with the United States and Israel began on February 28. According to his office, nine executions were linked to widespread protests in January, 10 individuals were put to death for alleged ties to opposition groups, and two were executed on espionage charges. More than 4,000 people have also been detained on national security-related accusations since late February.

Meanwhile, the head of the International Atomic Energy Agency, Rafael Grossi, said most of Iran's highly enriched uranium is likely still stored at the Isfahan nuclear complex. The facility had been targeted in airstrikes last year and saw less severe damage during the current US-Israeli campaign.

Grossi said satellite imagery continues to provide insight into the aftermath of recent strikes.

Inspections by the UN nuclear watchdog ceased when Israel launched a 12-day war in June 2025, during which the United States bombed three Iranian nuclear sites. Grossi noted that a significant portion of enriched uranium was believed to have been stored at Isfahan at that time and remains there.

The conflict is also having global economic repercussions. European Commission President Ursula von

der Leyen warned that European Union nations risk wasting billions of euros unless energy support is carefully directed. She said the war and disruptions such as threats to the Strait of Hormuz are costing the EU nearly 500 million euros, or about 600 million US dollars, each day.

Addressing lawmakers in Strasbourg, von der Leyen said past mistakes must not be repeated, recalling that more than 350 billion euros were spent on broad, untargeted measures during the 2022 energy crisis. "Let us not make the same mistake again, and let's focus our support where it matters most," she said.

Pravesh Wahi

the past year. "We are giving them time to prove their governance and fulfil their promises," she said, while clarifying that AAP continued to participate in Standing Committee proceedings.

The House also saw the unopposed election of Standing Committee members, including Jai Bhagwan Yadav, Manish Chaddha, and Jalaj Kumar, reflecting selective cooperation amid broader political contestation.

In his first address, Wahi emphasised a governance agenda centred on sanitation, primary healthcare, and education. He announced the procurement of advanced sanitation machinery worth ₹50 crore and warned of strict action against concessionaires failing to meet cleanliness standards. Tackling legacy waste at landfill sites and upgrading civic infrastructure, he said, would remain key priorities.

Soon after assuming office, Wahi visited the historic Hanuman Temple Yamuna Bazar, where he offered prayers and sought blessings for his tenure. He also conducted an inspection of the surrounding areas, reviewing sanitation and parking arrangements. Accompanied by senior officials, he directed authorities to ensure regular cleanliness drives and streamline parking facilities to minimise inconvenience for visitors and residents.

Reiterating his vision, the Mayor said public participation would be crucial in achieving a cleaner and better-organised Delhi. Observers note that this marks the second consecutive instance of BJP dominance in the MCD's top leadership, setting the stage for a politically charged year ahead as governance outcomes come under close scrutiny.

Maha no longer

to remain impartial. Standing up for someone who is appearing for an inquiry may appear as being overly courteous, which could influence how proceedings are perceived," the official said. The updated directive marks a shift from earlier practice, drawing a distinction between formal respect and the need for impartial governance in sensitive situations. AGENCIES

the wettest April in nearly two decades, though still below the 38.6 mm recorded in April 2008. It has also been among the least polluted Aprils in recent years.

Even as temperatures eased, rising heat in preceding weeks contributed to an increase in fire incidents. More than 7,800 fire-related emergencies were reported in Delhi between January and April this year, with over 2,300 cases, roughly 30 per cent of the total, recorded in April alone.

CM: Haryana model of governance for Punjab if BJP comes to power

MPOAT BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday said Punjab would receive Haryana-style good governance if the BJP comes to power, asserting that deprived sections would be provided all facilities, including plots, houses, education, scholarships and healthcare, on the same lines of what Haryana is giving.

The Chief Minister said this while meeting a delegation of the Dhanak community from various districts of Punjab at his residence, 'Sant Kabir Kutir', on late Wednesday evening. On the request of the delegation, he also accepted an invitation to attend a function to be organ-

ised by the Deprived Scheduled Caste (DSC) community in Punjab on June 30 to mark Sant Kabir Das's birth anniversary. Madan Lal Khatak, OSD to the Chief Minister, Bharat Bhushan Bharti, Mahender Singh and other dignitaries also remained present on the occasion.

Satish Khundia, president of the Dhanak community in Punjab, apprised the Chief Minister of the issues faced by the community, stating that educated youth are not getting employment. He said that while 34 out of 117 Assembly seats and 4 out of 13 Lok Sabha seats in Punjab are associated with the DSC community, their participation in politics remains negligible. He added that while the

DSC community has made significant progress in Haryana, its condition in Punjab remains poor.

Responding to this, the Chief Minister said that he understands the pain of the community, adding that whether it was the Congress or the present Aam Aadmi Party government, neither had focused on Punjab's real development.

He said these parties had only ruled over people and never served them. He remarked that the present Chief Minister is "nothing more than a comedian" and added that Arvind Kejriwal's record in Delhi and Punjab is well known, alleging that everything had been "drained out" there.

Exit polls predict BJP win in Assam, edge in Bengal; DMK to...

Continued from Page 1

ment in Puducherry.

In Tamil Nadu, two exit polls caught everyone's eye as they predicted a hung House. Axis My India forecast 92-110 seats for the ruling DMK-led alliance, 22-23 for the AIADMK plus and 98-120 for the TVK, which is making its poll debut. Kamakhya Analytics forecast 78-95 seats for the DMK plus, 68-84 for the AIADMK plus and 67-81 for the TVK.

Several polls predicted a big win for the DMK with the People's Pulse predicting 125-145 for the DMK-led alliance, 65-80 for AIADMK-BJP and 18-24 for TVK.

While Matrizze forecast that the DMK-Congress would get 122-132, AIADMK plus 87-100 and TVK 10-12, P-Marq predicted 125-145 for DMK plus, 65-85 for the AIADMK and 16-26 for the TVK.

JVC is the only pollster that has predicted an AIADMK win, forecasting 128-147 seats for the AIADMK plus. It also forecast 75-95 for the DMK plus and 18-15 for the TVK.

Praja polls predicted 148-168 seats for the DMK plus, 61-81 for the AIADMK and 1-9 for the TVK.

Peoples Insight forecast 120-140 seats for the DMK plus, 60-70 for the AIADMK and 30-40 for the TVK.

The Tamil Nadu has a total of 234 seats with the magic mark being 118.

In West Bengal, while most exit polls predicted a BJP win, two pollsters -- People's Pulse and Janmat polls -- predicted a big win for Mamata Banerjee-led TMC. People's Pulse predicted that the TMC would get 177-187 seats, BJP 95-110, Left Front 0-1 and the Congress 1-3. The Janmat polls forecast 195-205 for the TMC and 80-90 for the BJP plus and 1-3 for the Congress.

Most polls gave the BJP an edge or a victory in West Bengal. Matrizze said it is likely to get 146-161 seats, while the TMC would get 125-140 seats.

P-Marq predicted 150-175 for the BJP and 118-138 to the TMC.

While Poll Diary forecast 142-171 seats to the BJP, 99-127 to the TMC and 3-5 of the Congress, Praja Poll predicted a big win for the BJP, forecasting 178-208 seats for it. Praja Poll said the TMC would get 85-110 seats. West Bengal has a total of 294 seats with the majority mark being 148.

In Assam, Axis My India predicted a sweep for the BJP, forecasting 88-100 seats for the BJP and its allies and 24-36 seats for the Congress and its partners.

People's Pulse predicted that the NDA would get 68-72 seats in Assam while the Congress plus would secure in the range of 22-26 seats.

Matrizze said the NDA is likely to get between 85-95 seats and the Congress and its allies 25-32.

Pollster JVC projected that the BJP plus would get

88-101 seats and the Congress and its allies 23-33 seats.

While Kamakhya Analytics predicted 85-95 seats for the BJP and its allies and 26-39 seats for the Congress and its allies, People's Insight forecast 88-96 seats for the NDA and 30-34 for the Congress in Assam.

Poll Diary gave 86-101 seats to the NDA and 15-26 for the Congress plus. The Assam assembly has 126 seats with the magic mark being 64.

In Kerala, Axis My India forecast that the UDF would get 78-90 seats, LDF 49-62 and NDA 0-3.

People's Pulse predicted that the Congress-led UDF would get 75-85 seats, the LDF 55-65 and the NDA 0-3.

Matrizze forecast 60-65 seats for the LDF, 70-75 seats for the UDF and 3-5 seats for the NDA.

While Peoples Insight predicted 58-68 seats for the LDF, 66-76 seats for the UDF and 10-14 seats for the NDA, Vote Vibe predicted 58-68 seats for the LDF, 70-80 seats for the UDF and zero for the NDA. Kerala Assembly has a total of 140 seats with the magic mark being 71.

In Puducherry, Axis My India predicted 16-20 seats for the NDA and 6-8 for the DMK-Congress. It said the TVK is likely to get 2-4 seats in the assembly.

While Kamakhya Analytics predicted 17-24 seats for the AINRC plus (NDA), 4-7 for the Congress plus and 1-2 for teh TVK, Peoples Pulse predicted 16-19 seats for the AINRC plus and 10-12 for the Congress plus.

Praja Poll forecast 19-25 for the AINRC and 6-10 for the Congress plus.

There are 30 elected seats in Puducherry.

Most exit polls have had a chequered history and have been off the mark on several occasions in the past. Some exit polls like Axis My India for West Bengal will be released on Thursday.

The counting of votes for all the five assemblies -- West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala and Assam -- will be taken up on May 4.

Polis were conducted in a single phase in Assam, Kerala, Puducherry and Tamil Nadu. West Bengal saw two-phase polling on April 23 and 29.

On April 9, Assam, Kerala and Puducherry went to polls. Tamil Nadu went to polls on April 23.

While the BJP is seeking to retain power in Assam and Puducherry, where it is in an alliance government with All India N R Congress, the Congress is looking to wrest power from its rival in both these places.

In Kerala, the Congress-led UDF is seeking to replace the LDF government that is in power, while in Tamil Nadu, the DMK-led alliance is looking to retain power by thwarting the challenge from AIADMK-BJP and the debutant party -- Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam. The TMC is looking to retain West Bengal and thwart the challenge from the BJP. AGENCIES

'NO CONFUSION AS PEOPLE HAVE ALREADY DECIDED'

After exit polls, AIADMK, DMK exude confidence of winning

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: With several exit polls on Wednesday predicting a thumping victory for the ruling party in Tamil Nadu in the just concluded Assembly elections, the DMK said it will win over 180 seats, while the AIADMK dismissed the exit polls and said the party will come to power.

Tamil Nadu has a total of 234 seats with the magic mark being 118.

Expressing confidence that the DMK will return to power, DMK spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai, in his social media page, said, "In every exit polls, we are winning and this is a conservative estimate. We will win 180 plus seats."

However, the AIADMK exuded confidence that people have already "decided" on the change of government in the April 23 Assembly polls.

"There is no confusion as



TN CM and DMK candidate from Kolathur constituency, MK Stalin, during a voter outreach

people have already decided," AIADMK Legal Wing joint secretary, R M Babu Murugavel, said.

Dismissing the exit polls, which indicated that the DMK would come to power again, he said the exit polls will be valid only if opinion is sought from at least more than one

lakh people. "We are very confident," he said, adding "everything will be known on May 4".

The BJP, which is part of the AIADMK-led front, said the NDA will come to power in Tamil Nadu.

"Only the south Indian media are giving advantage to DMK. Most of the exit polls

from north India predict that AIADMK will come to power," BJP leader S Vijayadharani said. Meanwhile, the Congress, a key ally of the DMK, said the ruling party would retain power.

Due to the various welfare measures launched by the DMK government, people's response was very good dur-

ing the poll campaign, Tamil Nadu Congress senior leader A Gopanna said while speaking.

"There is no doubt the DMK will retain power," he added. Tamil Nadu, with 84.69 per cent polling, witnessed a highest-ever voter turnout in Assembly polls since Independence.

Highlights

» DMK spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai, in his social media page, said: "In every exit polls, we are winning and this is a conservative estimate. We will win 180 plus seats"

» However, the AIADMK exuded confidence that people have already "decided" on the change of government in the April 23 Assembly polls.

Assam polls: Over 8K people engaged for counting on May 4

EC fully geared up to conduct process smoothly

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI: Around 8,500 officials will be engaged for counting of votes on May 4 for 126 Assam assembly constituencies that went to polls on April 9, the state's Chief Electoral Officer Anurag Goel said on Wednesday.

Addressing a press conference here, he said the Election Commission is fully geared up to conduct the counting process smoothly and in a transparent manner. "We will have 40 counting centres spread across the 35 districts of Assam. Most of the districts have a single centre comprising all the constituencies in their jurisdictions," Goel said.

Kokrajhar, Tinsukia and Jorhat will be having two counting centres each, while Nagaon will have three such facilities, he said. "The EC has deployed 126 counting observers, who are senior IAS officers and will come from outside the state to maintain the neutral-



ity of the process. We will also have 2,348 micro-observers, who are central government employees," Goel said.

For the main counting work, a total of 5,981 people, mostly from the state government, will be engaged as counting officials, he said.

A record 85.96 per cent of Assam's 2.51 crore electorate exercised their franchise across 126 seats on April 9. This marked the highest voter turnout in the state's history, surpassing the previous high of 84.67 per cent recorded in 2016. Regarding the security arrangements, Goel said 25 companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) have been deployed across the state

in the innermost cordon to guard the strong rooms, and they will also be stationed in the counting centres.

"In addition, we have 13 companies of state armed police stationed outside the strong rooms as the second cordon. We can say with full confidence that the strong rooms have not been compromised," he said, refuting allegations of security lapses in the EVM storage facilities by some opposition leaders.

On the counting day, 800 more unarmed police personnel will be available for the movement of EVMs from strong room locations to the counting centres.

"We will be having two additional companies of CAPF on static duty, while 93 companies of state armed police have already been deployed in the districts. We will also have the support of 85 Assault Groups (AGs) on the day of counting to deal with any untoward incident," Goel said.

Prez to meet Punjab CM on May 5 over AAP MP defections

Seeks unprecedented 'recall' of Rajya Sabha members

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Wednesday said the state government will meet Droupadi Murmu on May 5 to raise the issue of what he termed "illegal and unlawful defection" by seven Rajya Sabha MPs, including six from Punjab. He asserted that such actions amount to a betrayal of the people's mandate.

Addressing a press conference, Mann said, "We have received confirmation from Rashtrapati Bhawan. On May 5, we will meet the President to take up the issue of illegal and unlawful defection by seven Rajya Sabha MPs. These MPs have disrespected the people's mandate and deserve no mercy, as they have betrayed Punjab and Punjabis."

He added that attempts to normalise defections as a political trend reflect a disregard for the electorate. "Those justifying such actions are undermining the people's verdict and appear to be preparing to shift loyalties themselves," he said.

Reaffirming his government's position, Mann said the Punjab government enjoys full confidence both inside and outside the Vidhan Sabha, making any demand for a floor test unnecessary.

"The smooth passage of the budget and every bill—big or small—demonstrates that the



government has an absolute majority in the House," he said, adding that critics should first account for unfulfilled guarantees at the Centre before questioning his government.

On the recent railway track blast, Mann said the state government is in constant touch with the Union government and the Ministry of Home Affairs. "Investigations are underway to establish forward and backward linkages. Those responsible will not be spared," he asserted.

Addressing water-sharing concerns, Mann said Haryana has utilised its share more judiciously this year, helping avoid disputes.

He also noted that after his meeting with the Union Minister of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, grain movement from Punjab has been expedited.

"As many as 290 special trains have been deployed to transport foodgrains from the state, ensuring adequate storage space for the upcoming paddy crop," he said.

'Rajnath gave clean chit to Pak'

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Wednesday alleged that Defence Minister Rajnath Singh gave a "shameful clean chit" to Pakistan while speaking at an SCO meeting in Bishkek, and claimed that his shocking statements were "anti-national".

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh also alleged that this "new stance" in relation to Pakistan is all part of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's policy of "appeasement" of the US and "calibrated capitulation" to China.

Ramesh shared a video clip of Singh speaking in Bishkek in which he said, "We must not forget that terrorism has no nationality and no theology. No grievance, real or supposed, can become an excuse for terrorism and humanitarian loss."

In his post on X attacking Singh, Ramesh said, "Yesterday, the Defence Minister, obviously with the approval of and at the instance of the Prime Minister, gave a shameful clean chit to Pakistan while speaking in Bishkek."



Shah to attend Buddha relic exposition in Leh during Buddha Purnima visit

'Devotees from different parts of the world will offer veneration to relics of Buddha'

GUWAHATI: Union Home Minister Amit Shah will visit Leh on Thursday for a two-day visit during which he will attend the first-ever international exposition of the holy relics of Lord Buddha in India, commencing on Buddha Purnima.

In a message posted on X, Shah said he would be leaving for Leh on Thursday for a two-day visit.

"It is a moment of profound good fortune for me to be attending on the occasion of Buddha Purnima, the first ever international exposition of the holy relics of Lord Buddha, commencing on the 1st of May," he said.

Shah said in this exposition, devotees from different parts of the world will offer veneration to the relics of Lord Buddha.

The sacred Piprahwa relics of Buddha were brought to Leh in a special Indian Air Force aircraft on Wednesday by Drukpa Thuksey Rinpoche and Khenpo Thinlas Chosal of Matho Monastery.

The sacred relics were accorded a ceremonial reception on arrival, as people poured out of their homes and gathered along the roads to pay respect.

Key Points

» The sacred Piprahwa relics of Buddha were brought to Leh in a special Indian Air Force aircraft on Wednesday by Drukpa Thuksey Rinpoche and Khenpo Thinlas Chosal of Matho Monastery

» This marks the beginning of marking a rare and significant spiritual occasion in the Union Territory of Ladakh with an exposition for the public to be held in the first two weeks of May



» Piprahwa relics refer to ancient sacred remains and associated objects linked to Gautama Buddha, discovered at Piprahwa, an archaeological site in present-day Uttar Pradesh, India, near the Nepal border

This marks the beginning of marking a rare and significant spiritual occasion in the Union Territory of Ladakh with an exposition for the public to be held in the first two weeks of May.

Piprahwa relics refer to ancient sacred remains and associated objects linked to Gautama Buddha, discovered at Piprahwa, an archaeological site in present-day

Uttar Pradesh, India, near the Nepal border.

The relics have gained renewed global significance in recent years, especially after a collection of associated gems and offerings was repatriated to India in July 2025 from a British family and a private collection, ending over a century of colonial possession.

The relics have been exhibited



Rahul Gandhi during his visit to INS Boaz Gate in Campbell Bay

are equally beautiful -- both the Adivasi communities and the settlers -- but they are being robbed of what is rightfully theirs."

"The government calls what it is doing here a 'project'. What I have seen is not a project. There are millions of trees

marked for the axe. It is 160 sq km of rainforest condemned to die. It is communities that have been ignored while their homes have been snatched away. This is not development. This is destruction dressed in development's language," he said. "So, I will say it plainly, and I

Farooq criticises EC's handling of WB polls; asks are Bengalis not trusted

SRINAGAR: Are Bengalis not being trusted, asked veteran politician and three-time former chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir, Farooq Abdullah, on Wednesday while slamming the Election Commission for the deployment of a large contingent of central police forces and bureaucrats during the West Bengal polls.

Abdullah, who is the president of the ruling National Conference, condemned the rhetoric used by national leaders against West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, describing the language as "unparliamentary and not befitting this nation".

Emphasising that a strong India requires respecting its

Condemns rhetoric used by national leaders against Mamata Banerjee

citizens, he said, "If you want a strong India, then Bengalis have the right to choose their leadership without being coerced towards any other direction."

Abdullah lashed out at the approach of some quarters in the government towards state elections and regional identities, specifically questioning if the people of West Bengal "are being treated as outsiders" within their own country.

Referring to the massive deployment of central police forces and the reshuffling of bureaucrats during the election season in West Bengal, Abdullah questioned the underlying intent, saying "...the way even from Jammu and Kashmir forces have been removed in large numbers and sent, saying that they want a peaceful election... officers have been moved from states. What for? Is the Bengali not trusted? Is he (West Bengal) not part of the nation?"

Abdullah did not mince words regarding the institutional oversight of the electoral processes in West Bengal, expressing his disappointment with the poll body.

KOLKATA: Shiv Sena leader Aaditya Thackeray on Wednesday described the Election Commission as "compromised" and accused it of attempting to intimidate voters in West Bengal to favour a particular party. He also alleged that the Bharatiya Janata Party was misusing institutions, central agencies and security forces to "capture" a state through fear.

In a post on X, Thackeray urged people to "think neutrally, non-politically" about whether the situation in Bengal was justified. "Bengal's pride is at odds with the greed to win an election. Bengal's citizens have been harassed, subject to disenfranchisement in millions, in a country that was once proudly

a democracy. The compromised Election Commission has tried to scare Bengalis, holding them at gunpoint, to make a party win," he wrote.

Though he did not name any party, his remarks were widely seen as targeting the BJP.

Questioning the deployment of central forces, Thackeray wrote, "Moving central forces into Bengal in millions to try and scare people, re-deploying them from where they were posted to protect our country and ensure peace in troubled areas—why is Bengal being treated like a state that has been invaded?"

He reiterated that "nothing must be more important in India than respecting coop-

erative federalism" and criticised the manner in which the election was being conducted. "This was never the tactic that won elections and this is not democracy. The conduct of this election pretty much proves that Indian democracy is virtually finished—it is an institutional effort to capture a state through fear and hatred," he added.

In an apparent reference to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, Thackeray said the issue went beyond an individual. "This isn't about one lady... this is about Bengal, its pride and the ideals of India. This is about our country's credentials as a democracy in the world," he wrote.



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SABARIMALA REFERENCE

Cannot annihilate religion in name of reform: Apex Court

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Observing that religion cannot be “hollowed out”, the Supreme Court on Wednesday said it cannot annihilate a religion in the name of reform and the matters of belief and conscience cannot be subjected to judicial debate.

A nine-judge constitution bench hearing issues pertaining to discrimination against women across religions in the country remarked that certain things have crystallised and become an essential part of the religion over the years.

The bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, during its hearing on the tenth day, asked whether it can apply the test of equality in cases of religious freedom in complete negation of an “integral practice” of a religion.

The top court referred to constitutional aspiration on bringing about the Uniform Civil Code in the country keeping it in tune with the social reform and asked if the State fails to legislate, then can the judiciary do it.

Justice BV Nagarathna, also part of the bench, observed that different states have enacted Uniform Civil Code to regulate

Highlights

» A nine-judge constitution bench hearing issues pertaining to discrimination against women across religions

» The bench headed by CJI asked whether it can apply the test of equality in cases of religious freedom in complete negation of an ‘integral practice’ of a religion



marriage and succession rights of citizens and when the society is ready for it, Parliament will enact it.

The bench also comprising justices M M Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi was told by senior advocate Indira Jaising, appearing for two women claiming right to enter Sabarimala temple in Kerala, that every state has made temple entry laws and if one wants to claim his right, he has to go by the statute.

Justice Bagchi told Jaising that there is no such law in respect of non-Hindu religious institutions and can the court in its zeal for maintaining equality among citizens enforce

similar directions for non-Hindu institutions, or should it defer to legislative decision. He told the senior lawyer that the court would have consistently directed for a Uniform Civil Code.

Jaising, who argued for the whole day submitted that the question of a UCC has been placed in the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP) and it is a matter of policy.

“India does not have an all-India Uniform Civil Code. But we do have central statutes like the Hindu Marriage Act, the Hindu Adoption and Guardianship Act, and the Hindu Succession Act. That is a policy decision taken by the State. They are free to change it whenever they want. I am not disputing that. But if a Uniform Civil Code is enacted, then its

constitutionality may have to be examined,” she submitted.

Justice Bagchi said, “Our question is not on what form UCC is brought. The constitutional aspiration of UCC is admitted and the social reforms understood in Article 25 (2) (b) have to be linked with constitutional aspirations of DPSP that it will bring UCC. The question is if the state fails to do it, can the court bring incremental equality clauses when it comes to religious freedoms and can we apply the test of equality to completely negate an integral practice of a religion.”

During the hearing, the bench observed that it cannot annihilate religion in the name of reform and that matters of belief and conscience cannot be subjected to judicial debate.

PLEAS AGAINST HATE SPEECHES

No legislative vacuum exists warranting intervention: SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday said the existing framework of criminal law adequately addresses the issue of hate speeches and no “legislative vacuum” exists warranting intervention.

“The contention that the field of hate speech remains legislatively unoccupied, is misconceived,” a bench of justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said.

The top court delivered its verdict on a batch of petitions seeking action against those involved in hate speeches and also for mechanism to deal with such instances.

The bench said it would be open to the Centre and the competent legislative authorities to consider in their wisdom whether any further legislative or policy measures were warranted in light of the evolving societal challenges or to bring about suitable amendments as suggested by the Law Commission’s 267th report of March 2017.

“While we decline to issue directions of the nature sought, we deem it appropriate to observe that the issues relating to hate speeches and rumour-mongering bear directly upon the preservation of fraternity, dignity and Constitutional order,” Justice

Takeaways

» SC said creation of criminal offences and prescription of punishments lies squarely within legislative domain

» ‘Contention that the field of hate speech remains legislatively unoccupied, is misconceived’

Nath said while pronouncing the verdict.

The apex court said creation of criminal offences and the prescription of punishments lies squarely within the legislative domain.

It said the constitutional scheme founded upon the doctrine of separation of powers does not permit the judiciary to create new offences or expand the contours of criminal liability through judicial directions.

“The precedents of this court consistently affirm that while Constitutional courts may interpret the law and issue directions to secure the enforcement of fundamental rights, they cannot legislate or compel legislation,” the bench said.

It said the existing framework of substantive criminal law, including the provisions of the erstwhile Indian Penal

Code, and allied legislations adequately addresses acts that promote enmity, outrage religious sentiments, or disturb public tranquillity.

“The field is, therefore, not unoccupied,” the bench said.

It said the statutory framework under the erstwhile Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), now the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, provides a comprehensive and layered mechanism to set the criminal law in motion.

The bench said the duty of police to register an FIR upon disclosure of a cognisable offence is mandatory and in cases of non-registration of FIR, the CrPC or the BNSS provides efficacious remedy.

The apex court dismissed several pleas and also closed the separate contempt petitions filed against the authorities of some states for their alleged failure in complying with the court’s directions of taking action against those involved in hate speeches.

The detailed judgement is awaited.

The top court had reserved its verdict on the pleas on January 20, and observed that it would close most of the petitions related to hate speeches pending since 2021, and in which the court had asked the police to suo motu register FIRs.

Mann: 15 being deported from Australia will be received at Delhi Airport

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday said that 15 Indians being deported from Australia will arrive in Delhi, including 11 from Punjab among whom is one woman, and asserted that the Punjab government will receive them at IGI Airport in New Delhi while ensuring support for their rehabilitation and future livelihood.

CM Mann stated, “15 Indians being deported will arrive in Delhi on Wednesday, including 11 from Punjab, among them one woman. 11 people from Punjab being deported from Australia will be received at Delhi Airport by the state government.” Emphasising the need for compassion and accountability, he added, “These are all our own people who were misled by fraudulent agents and went abroad.”

Highlighting the issue of fraudulent travel agents, Mann said, “Many innocent people fall into the trap of dubious travel agents who promise them the moon and send them abroad. These people leave with high hopes but are eventually deported. The Punjab government is duty bound to



Bhagwant Mann

‘These are all our own people who were misled by fraudulent agents and went abroad’

prevent such tragedies.”

He further added that the government has been consistently working to rebuild trust among citizens so that they become active partners in the socio-economic progress of Punjab.

Reiterating the government’s commitment to providing opportunities within the state, Chief Minister Mann said, “Our government is making arrangements for employment so that no one is forced to go abroad in search of jobs.”

Nadda to inaugurate 10th National Public Health Summit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Health minister JP Nadda will inaugurate the 10th National Summit on Good and Replicable Practices and Innovations in Public Health Systems in Chandigarh on April 30.

The two-day summit, running through May 1, will bring together senior health officials, programme directors, and state administrators to present 45 selected innovations, 13 oral presentations and 32 poster presentations, drawn from submissions via the National Healthcare Innovation Portal.

The Ministry’s divisions evaluated all proposals and shortlisted winners under the oversight of the Additional Secretary and Mission Director of the National Health Mission.

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and state health minister Arti Singh Rao are expected to attend.

The Ministry will also release findings from the 17th Common Review Mission, a November 2025 exercise that deployed multidisciplinary teams across 17 states to assess public health system functioning.

NCB Chennai seizes 200 kg of Ganja, six arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: In a major crack-down on narcotics trafficking, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) Chennai Zonal Unit has seized 200 kg of ganja and arrested six individuals in a coordinated multi-state operation spanning Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu.

According to the NCB officials, this action followed careful coordination between state units. A seizure occurred after intelligence inputs guided field

teams. Results reflect joint efforts among enforcement wings. Details emerged gradually as officials confirmed each phase. Locations varied widely within the three states. Initial contact led to further discoveries over successive days.

A seizure worth Rs 1 crore occurred April 26, following the stoppage of an Eicher truck near Nallur Toll Plaza, Tamil Nadu. Cooperation with Telangana Police enabled the intervention, breaking up a structured network moving drugs across

state lines.

Officials report that six individuals taken into custody live in Tuticorin, Tamil Nadu. Among them stands Nagendran, known as Raghu, originating from Tiruppur, suspected of leading the operation.

A record marks him linked to repeated offences – two killings recorded in 2022 form part of his history. Charges under the Arms Act arose later, during 2024. Prior engagement with narcotics laws appears again, this time noted in 2025.

UP: Six killed as SUV collides with three trucks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

UNNAO: Six people were killed, and five others were injured on Wednesday after their SUV collided with three trucks here, police said.

The accident occurred around 11 am near Kiratpur village on the Sumerpur-Bhagwant Nagar road, as a family from Pathai village in the Maurawan police station area was returning home from the Chandrika Devi Temple in Buxar after performing the mundan (head-shaving) ceremony of their three-year-old child, they said.

Circle Officer (CO) of Big-hapur Madhupnath Mishra said that the SUV, approaching from Buxar, was attempt-

ing to overtake a truck, but collided head-on with another truck coming from the opposite direction.

Subsequently, a third truck approaching from behind also rammed into the SUV, causing both vehicles to plunge into a roadside ditch.

The impact was so severe that one of the trucks overturned onto the SUV, trapping the occupants inside.

With the assistance of the police and residents, relief and rescue operations were launched to bring out the people trapped inside the Bolero.

Three women died on the spot, while the SUV driver and two other passengers succumbed to their injuries in the hospital.

A NEW APPROACH TO HEALING BROKEN FAMILIES

Chh’garh: Durg district’s gender-balanced system emerges as national model

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: As India’s social fabric evolves rapidly, relationships are becoming more complex, bringing new challenges within families. Often, the silent suffering inside homes—whether it is the neglect of elderly parents or the mental stress faced by men—goes unheard. But Durg district in Chhattisgarh has shown a new way to give voice to this silence.

The gender-balanced counselling system introduced in Durg has now emerged as an inclusive model for resolving family disputes—one that is gaining attention at the national level.

The Family Counselling Centre at the Women’s Police Station in Sector-6, which was once limited largely to women’s complaints, has now transformed into a broader social platform. Today, it listens to the concerns of women, men, and senior citizens with equal sensitivity and seriousness.

Launched in accordance with the directions of the High Court, the centre gradually



expanded its scope in response to changing family dynamics and emerging forms of conflict. The introduction of gender-balanced counselling ensures that every side is heard fairly and without bias.

One of the most significant aspects of this initiative is the appointment of male counsellors. In recent years, it has become evident that men, too, face emotional, financial, and marital stress, and are increasingly approaching counselling

centres. This step has helped create a more balanced and empathetic environment.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai described the initiative as the need of the hour, emphasising that counselling-based solutions can resolve conflicts at an early stage, thereby strengthening family harmony and social stability.

According to Durg SSP Vijay Agarwal, the process of dialogue and counselling has proven effective in preventing

Key Points

» The gender-balanced counselling system introduced in Durg has now emerged as an inclusive model for resolving family disputes

» The introduction of gender-balanced counselling ensures that every side is heard fairly and without bias

reality—cases of harassment by children, pressure over property, forced relocation to old-age homes, physical abuse linked to alcohol demands, denial of food, and even eviction from homes.

So far, around 200 complaints have been registered at the centre, out of which nearly 130 cases have been successfully resolved. These figures highlight not only the success of the initiative but also the power of timely dialogue and compassionate intervention.

Durg’s ‘counselling-first’ model is considered the first of its kind in states like Chhattisgarh. While many states still rely on traditional and one-sided approaches, Durg has developed a balanced system that equally represents women, men, and senior citizens.

This dialogue-driven approach is not only resolving conflicts in time but also preventing families from breaking apart. That is why this initiative is now emerging as a strong national example—one that other states are beginning to look at for replication.

West Asia

crisis: Iranian

Foreign minister Araghchi dials Jaishankar

NEW DELHI: Iranian Foreign minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi on Wednesday dialled his Indian counterpart S Jaishankar and discussed various aspects of the West Asia crisis.

The phone conversation came two days after Araghchi held wide-ranging discussions with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Moscow.

“Received a phone call from Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi of Iran this evening,” Jaishankar said on social media.

“Had a detailed conversation about various aspects of the current situation. We agreed to remain in close touch,” he said.

The Iranian embassy in New Delhi said the two sides “discussed and exchanged views on the latest developments related to the ceasefire, bilateral relations, as well as regional and international issues”.

It is learnt that the situation arising out of the US’s blockade of the Iranian ports as well as Iran’s restrictions on movement of ships through the Strait of Hormuz figured in the conversation.

The Iranian foreign minister travelled to Moscow after visiting Oman and Pakistan as part of diplomatic efforts to end the Iran-US war.

The first round of peace talks between Iran and the US, held on April 11 and 12 in Islamabad, failed to bring end their conflict.

Last Tuesday, US President Donald Trump extended the two-week ceasefire with Iran indefinitely to give Tehran more time to prepare a unified proposal to end the war. The war began when the US and Israel jointly attacked Iran on February 28, killing Iranian supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several top commanders. The retaliation by the Islamic republic extended the war to the entire Gulf region.

MPOST

Haryana to conduct flood mock drill on May 14 in 13 vulnerable districts

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana government will conduct a state-level mock exercise on a flood disaster scenario on May 14, 2026, covering 13 flood-prone districts.

Financial Commissioner, Revenue and Disaster Management Department, Sumita Misra, informed on Wednesday that the exercise is being organised in coordination with the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) as part of the annual State/UT mock exercise calendar for 2026-27.

According to the official communication issued by the Department of Revenue and Disaster Management, the

mock exercise will be conducted in four stages to ensure comprehensive preparedness.

The first stage, Orientation and Coordination Conference, will be held on May 6, 2026, through video conferencing, involving officials and stakeholders from the State and district levels.

This will be followed by a Tabletop Exercise on May 12, where various response scenarios will be discussed and strategies tested. The third and most critical phase, the physical mock drill, will take place on May 14, involving active participation of all concerned agencies on the ground.

Misra stated that the exercise will be conducted in 13 identified flood-prone districts

— Gurugram, Ambala, Faridabad, Fatehabad, Kaithal, Karnal, Kurukshetra, Panchkula, Panipat, Palwal, Sirsa, Sonapat and Yamunanagar.

These districts have been selected due to their proximity to rivers and canals and their geographical vulnerability to flooding, making them critical for preparedness planning.

The primary objective of the exercise is to review disaster management plans and standard operating procedures at the State, district and departmental levels.

It will also focus on defining stakeholder roles under the Incident Response System (IRS) and integrating them into the overall response mechanism.

Nation Briefs

NFR: LUMDING DIVISION ACHIEVES MAJOR MILESTONE IN FOOD SAFETY STANDARDS

MALIGAON: In a major step towards ensuring safe

and hygienic food for passengers, 10 Railway stations along with the Divisional Railway Manager’s office canteen at Lumding, under the Lumding Division of Northeast



Frontier Railway, have been awarded the prestigious “Eat Right Station” certification by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI). The certification is valid for the period from March 30, 2026 to March 29, 2028, in accordance with FSSAI guidelines.

CONSTABLE KILLED AS PILING RIG COLLAPSES ON HIM IN MUMBAI

MUMBAI: A police constable was killed after a heavy piling rig toppled on him at an under-construction flyover site in Mumbai, officials said on Wednesday. The accident occurred on the northbound carriageway of the Sion-Panvel Highway in the Mankhurd area on Tuesday night when the constable, Santosh Gopal Chavan, was heading home on his motorcycle, they said. A piling rig used for drilling foundation piles collapsed and struck him at the site where flyover construction work was in progress, an official from Mankhurd police station said.

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EDITORIAL
DRIVING
ECONOMIC
SHIFT

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the 594-km Ganga Expressway, the symbolism was unmistakable—another milestone in India's accelerating infrastructure push. But beyond the optics of scale and speed lies a deeper question: can a highway fundamentally alter the economic trajectory of a state as vast and complex as Uttar Pradesh? For decades, the state's development has been uneven, with the industrialised western belt far outpacing the largely agrarian east. By linking Meerut to Prayagraj across 12 districts, the Ganga Expressway is being projected not merely as a mobility upgrade but as an instrument of economic correction. Cutting travel time from 10–12 hours to about 6–8 hours is significant, but the real ambition lies in compressing economic distance—bringing markets, labour, and capital into closer alignment. In that sense, the expressway is less about cars and more about capital flows, less about convenience and more about competitiveness.

What distinguishes the Ganga Expressway from earlier highway projects is its deliberate positioning as an integrated development corridor. The Uttar Pradesh government's plan to establish 12 Integrated Manufacturing and Logistics Clusters (IMLCs) along the route signals a shift in infrastructure thinking—from transport as an end in itself to transport as a catalyst. Globally, the most successful infrastructure projects are those that embed industrial ecosystems around them, ensuring that roads are not just used, but economically activated. With nearly 6,500 acres earmarked and investment proposals worth approximately ₹47,000 crore already on the table, the project attempts to follow that template. Its connectivity to other major expressways, the upcoming Noida International Airport, and key urban centres strengthens its potential as a logistics backbone. In a country where logistics costs remain high—often estimated at 13–14 per cent of GDP—such corridors can be transformative by reducing freight time, lowering inventory costs, and improving supply chain efficiency across sectors.

The economic ripple effects are likely to be most visible first in logistics and real estate. For industries reliant on movement—FMCG, textiles, e-commerce, and heavy goods—the expressway promises shorter routes and faster deliveries. Estimates suggest transport routes could shrink by as much as 40–50 per cent in certain cases, while logistics costs may fall by 10–15 per cent. This is particularly relevant as India's consumption growth shifts toward Tier-II and Tier-III cities, which have long suffered from inadequate connectivity. At the same time, land markets along the corridor are already witnessing heightened activity, with projections of 30–50 per cent appreciation in some pockets over the next few years. While such gains may signal investor confidence, they also raise a familiar concern: infrastructure-led real estate booms often benefit early investors disproportionately. Unless accompanied by policies that ensure local participation, job creation, and affordable housing, corridor-led growth risks becoming exclusionary rather than inclusive.

Perhaps the most compelling promise of the Ganga Expressway lies in its potential to bridge Uttar Pradesh's internal economic divide. Western UP, aided by proximity to Delhi and a robust industrial base, has historically attracted more investment, while eastern districts have remained dependent on agriculture with limited industrial presence. By creating a seamless, high-speed link between these regions, the expressway could enable a more balanced distribution of economic activity. However, connectivity alone is not a guarantee of convergence. It must be supported by targeted interventions—sector-specific incentives, skill development initiatives, and robust institutional frameworks that encourage industries to expand into less-developed districts. Without these complementary measures, the expressway risks reinforcing existing imbalances, with growth clustering around already-developed nodes rather than spreading evenly across the corridor.

There is also a broader strategic and environmental dimension that must be acknowledged. The inclusion of a 3.5-km airstrip capable of handling emergency fighter aircraft landings underscores the dual-use nature of modern infrastructure, adding a layer of national security relevance. At the same time, large-scale projects of this nature inevitably raise concerns around land acquisition, ecological disruption, and displacement. As India scales up its infrastructure ambitions, the balance between development and sustainability becomes increasingly critical. Ultimately, the Ganga Expressway represents more than a highway—it is a test of whether India can execute integrated, corridor-led growth at scale. Its success will not be measured merely by traffic volumes or reduced travel time, but by the ecosystems it builds: industries that generate employment, logistics networks that enhance efficiency, and regions that move closer to parity. If even a part of its ambitious vision materialises, the expressway may indeed redraw Uttar Pradesh's growth map—not just connecting cities, but connecting opportunity itself.

NEXUS
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS
AN AUTHOR AND
A FORMER
CIVIL SERVANT

Through tree
plantation,
campus
greening, water
conservation,
waste reduction,
awareness
campaigns
and community
partnerships, the
initiative pushed
schools beyond
token events

Classrooms to Climate Action

CCAC shows how schools can move climate education beyond awareness, turning students into active custodians of sustainable habits, community action and long-term responsibility

The journey to Panchgani, Maharashtra, was hectic for me as I had just returned from Indore to Delhi. Travelling again to Pune and then taking a three-hour drive to Panchgani was tough. However, it was well worth the trouble because what I witnessed amidst the quiet but inspiring environment at Initiatives of Change (IoC) was truly amazing. What if climate action didn't begin in boardrooms or policy circles but inside classrooms? That is the question at the heart of the Classrooms to Climate Action Crusaders (CCAC) initiative, a pan-India program that is quietly redefining how schools engage with one of the most urgent challenges of our time.

The first cohort, running from July 2025 to April 2026, brought together 78 schools from across the country. Out of these, 50 schools carried their work through to the final stages, each one experimenting with what it means to move from awareness to action.

Organised by SrishtiZens, a pan-India network of eco clubs, Kerala Public School Trust, Jamshedpur and Rotary Club of Jamshedpur, in partnership with TERRE Policy Centre, Pune—bringing together education, community leadership, and sustainability expertise into one collaborative ecosystem.

But CCAC was never designed to be just another school competition.

Beyond Activities. Toward Ownership

At its core, CCAC challenges a familiar pattern: students learning about climate change without ever engaging with it in real, tangible ways.

Instead of limiting schools to one-off events, the initiative required sustained action. Schools worked on a mix of compulsory efforts, such as tree plantation, greening campuses, and water conservation, alongside optional initiatives like awareness campaigns, waste reduction, and community impact projects.

A defining feature of the program was collaboration. Schools were inspired to partner with organisations, NGOs, and even other schools, for each and every activity and points were allotted for it, expanding their perspective beyond campus boundaries.

What emerged was a shift. For many participants, what started



The first CCAC cohort proves that students can become powerful agents of environmental change

as a task evolved into something far more meaningful. Students began to take ownership. Teachers observed changes not just in knowledge, but in attitude, responsibility, and everyday behaviour.

This aligns with a deeper truth highlighted by environmentalist James Gustave Speth, who argued that the biggest environmental challenges are not purely scientific, but cultural and behavioural. CCAC directly engages with this reality by working at the level where habits and values are formed.

Recognising Meaningful Impact

At Asia Plateau Panchgani, surrounded by a landscape that quietly reflects the very ecosystems this initiative seeks to protect, the final gathering carried a different kind of energy. This was not just about results. It was about witnessing what sustained effort, collaboration, and intent can look like when schools take ownership.

The schools that emerged as leaders demonstrated not just participation, but depth and consistency in their efforts.

- **First Prize (₹1,00,000):** SBOA Public Senior Secondary School, Cochin, Kerala
 - **Second Prize:** Bhavan's Munshi Vidyashram, Tripunithura, Kerala
 - **Third Prize:** SBOA Matric Higher Secondary School, Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu
 - **Fourth Place:** JH Tarapore School, Jamshedpur, Jharkhand
- The trophies were instituted after the late Chairman, Mr APR Nair's name. While these schools stood out, the

larger success of CCAC lies in the collective shift it sparked. Across participating schools, environmental action moved from being an isolated activity to a shared purpose.

Lessons from the First Cohort

The journey of the first cohort offers both validation and direction.

On one hand, it proved that schools are ready. They can build green teams, initiate environmental efforts, and collaborate meaningfully when given the right structure. On the other hand, it also revealed the next level of challenge.

There is a need to go deeper. To move beyond surface-level activities and create measurable, long-term impact. Strengthening students' understanding of environmental issues, encouraging consistent reflection, and building stronger partnerships with external organisations will be critical going forward.

The Next Phase: Scaling Impact

The vision for CCAC 2026–27 is not incremental. It is exponential.

The next cohort aims to expand participation significantly, with each school acting as a catalyst to bring others into the fold. This creates a multiplier effect, where climate action is no longer confined to individual institutions but spreads across communities.

Stronger partnerships and collaborations will continue to play a central role. With organisations like SrishtiZens and its collaborators deepening their engagement, the initiative is positioned to build a more robust ecosystem that supports schools with resources, mentorship, and

real-world opportunities.

In addition, new recognition categories are being planned to celebrate diverse forms of contribution—ranging from innovation and collaboration to sustained impact.

Most importantly, the focus is shifting toward continuity. The goal is to ensure that climate action becomes embedded in the culture of schools, rather than remaining a time-bound program.

A Shift That Matters

Climate change is often discussed in terms of policies, technologies, and global agreements. But real change depends on something more fundamental: how people think, act, and take responsibility in their everyday lives. Aim big, but start small. Every step in the right direction matters.

Schools are one of the few spaces where this shift can begin at scale.

CCAC taps into that potential. It doesn't just inform students about the climate crisis, but positions them as active contributors to the solution.

And that shift from learning about change to becoming agents of change is where the real impact lies.

What was being attempted through this initiative was transformational. The model presented at Panchgani is a wonderful example of Nexus of Good. It can easily be scaled and replicated through public-private partnership. It is hoped that more and more schools will join the movement during the next few years.

Views expressed are personal

CIVIC
PULSE



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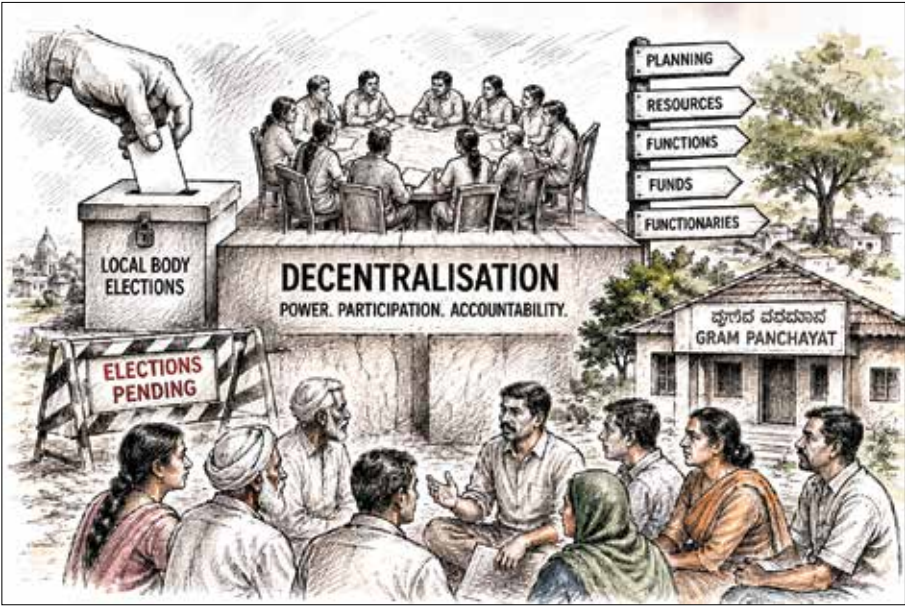
Decentralisation
cannot be driven
by committees
alone—it
requires elected
local institutions
that anchor
participation,
accountability
and continuity

Power to the People?

Karnataka's renewed interest in grassroots governance raises a core question—can decentralisation succeed when institutions meant to anchor it remain unelected and inactive?

Based on the announcement made by the Chief Minister of Karnataka in the Legislative Assembly that Karnataka is going for a big push in Decentralization, as it has been done in Kerala after the enactment of the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution of India, a committee has been set up to take steps to operationalise the Decentralisation efforts by building a mass movement through the People's Plan Campaign. This being the intention, the logical question is why Karnataka is not conducting elections to Local Bodies, as it is in the manifesto of the Indian National Congress that the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution of India be implemented in letter and spirit. In the whole of India, Kerala is the only state conducting elections to local governments on time. All other states are reluctant to conduct elections for local governments. The committee has initiated a preliminary discussion with experienced persons in Decentralisation and with the officials who are going to be the torch bearers of this initiative, at Mysuru State Institute of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj from April 8-10. A person who has spent 30 years in the same domain with a deep sense of commitment and part of the people's plan campaign in Kerala narrated the whole experience of Kerala and made a plea that Karnataka can take certain aspects from Kerala and carve out a framework suitable for this state.

It is to be remembered that Karnataka is a pioneer in Decentralisation in the 80s under the leadership of Ramakrishna Hegde, which inspired Rajiv Gandhi to formalise a local government system in the whole of India on a sustainable basis. Kerala was the last state to enact con-



Karnataka's decentralisation effort risks faltering without restoring elected local institutions that sustain participation, accountability and continuity

formity legislation to the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution of India. But it becomes a leading state in empowering Local Government. Hence, all over the country, experts are drawn from Kerala to empower the Local Governance system and women's Self Help Groups. In such a way, Kerala has been positioned to empower the citizens. Karnataka need not seek any experience from any other state as it has its own history of empowering people, which is more progressive than the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution of India," observed by none other than the person who drafted the Panchayati Raj Bill in Karnataka under Ramakrishna Hegde and the 73rd Amendment bill to the Constitution of India under PV Narasimha Rao, former Prime Minister and Rural Development Minister. When the whole discourse was on one major observation, every-

one was making the point that if the Rural Development and Panchayati Raj Minister evinces interest in this exercise, Karnataka will show the way to other states in such a way that people's movement could be built up in Karnataka, as the state still maintains a culture of harmony, which is not prevalent in many other states. One critical issue raised by many experts is that in the absence of Local Bodies, who will take responsibility at the ground for all such initiatives to mobilise people and sustain the momentum till the preparation of the participatory people's plan.

There are issues in the process of implementing the announcement of the Chief Minister, as there is a gap between the Karnataka Panchayati Raj and Gram Swaraj Act and the present-day practices of Local Governance in Karnataka. A series of steps is needed at the state level to

remove the obstacles in implementing the state Act in letter and spirit. Further, the bureaucracy has to be oriented to a new culture of working with elected representatives of the people at the grassroots.

There is yet another point which is also being discussed. Whenever a new initiative is taken at the state government level, the party in power looks at what political mileage it could get out of the new initiative. Nowhere has it been proved that by empowering people, the party would get substantial support from the people who get substantial benefits from the Local Government.

Yet there is an opportunity for the political parties to move closely with people and identify themselves with people, and thereby, the alienation of the public from the Government and the political parties can be arrested. At present, everywhere we find people's

alienation and political apathy, which are being tackled by the Government and the political parties through freebies and direct transfer of cash for each and every political activity. While engaging the ordinary people in the campaign, people are engaged in developmental activities, and thereby new development narratives could be generated, from which political narratives could be evolved if the political activists have integrity and earnestness. It is huge political mileage the party could get out of this exercise. A new development consciousness could be created through the continuous engagement of the people in the campaign.

Against this background, the whole issue was deliberated. Two things are imminent for any serious political action. First, if there is a political will on the part of the state leadership, it will be carried out effectively, efficiently, and enthusiastically. In the absence of political will, creating a public will is the only way. If the leadership has a political will, certainly Karnataka will lead the Decentralisation movement in this country. But a blueprint for action has been prepared and is ready for action. It all depends on the Minister for Rural Development and Panchayati Raj to follow it up.

If he has a will, a support structure is ready to build a movement from below to develop a people's politics. One has to wait and see whether the new opportunity is being used or not. It is to be remembered that in the 2024 election Manifesto of the Indian National Congress, it has been reiterated that Congress will take steps to implement the letter and spirit of the 73rd Amendment to the Constitution of India.

Views expressed are personal

HEGSETH FACES LAWMAKERS FOR FIRST TIME SINCE IRAN WAR STARTED

Iran war has cost estimated \$25 bn so far, Pentagon official tells Cong

WASHINGTON: Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth said congressional Democrats are “the biggest adversary we face” as he parried questioning from lawmakers Wednesday for the first time since US President Donald Trump launched the war against Iran. And the Pentagon’s chief financial officer released a detail Democrats have been demanding, saying the war has cost an estimated USD25 billion and counting.

Hegseth told the House Armed Services Committee that boosting next year’s Pentagon budget to an unprecedented USD1.5 trillion will “maintain the world’s most powerful and capable military.” Meanwhile talks on ending the war have stalled. Trump posted an image on social media showing himself carrying a weapon in a war zone, saying “NO MORE MR. NICE GUY!” Trump ordered three



US Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth

aircraft carriers into the Middle East — a number not seen since 2003. When asked why the US military withdrew resources from Asia after identifying China as a top threat, the president’s top military advisor told lawmakers that Trump has to make “tradeoffs” when deploying troops. “I’m confident that the president always carefully considers these readiness tradeoffs and I’m sure he has done so in

this case based on the military options that we’ve presented with the associated risks and advice,” Caine said. Rep. Joe Courtney, a Democrat, fired back by noting that the administration’s own National Defense Strategy released shortly before Trump launched the war said Iran was “weaker and more vulnerable than it has been in decades.” Putting that many troops to confront them, at the expense

Highlights

- » Meanwhile talks on ending the war with Iran have stalled
- » Hegseth engages in tense exchange over Iran’s nuclear programme
- » ‘Iran is weaker and more vulnerable than it has been in decades’

of other threats “does not, in my opinion, common sense,” Courtney said. Hegseth told Democratic Rep. Adam Smith that Iran’s nuclear facilities were obliterated in a 2025 attack by the US, prompting Smith to question the Trump administration’s reasoning for starting the Iran war. “We had to start this war, you just said 60 days ago, because the nuclear weapon was an imminent

threat,” Smith said. “Now you’re saying that it was completely obliterated?” Hegseth responded by saying that Iran “had not given up their nuclear ambitions” and still had thousands of missiles. Smith said the war “left us at exactly the same place we were before.” The committee is taking a brief recess to vote, which is expected to take about 20-25 minutes. During a hearing of the House Armed Services Committee, Jules Hurst III, the acting undersecretary of war for finances, said most of the expense has been on munitions, but the military has also spent money on running the operations and equipment replacement. “We will formulate a supplemental through the White House that will come to Congress once we have a full assessment of the cost of the conflict,” Hurst added. AGENCIES

Wildfires still threat in Georgia, warns officials



firefighters responding to the Pineland Road Fire in southeast Georgia

SAVANNAH: Officials battling two large wildfires that have destroyed dozens of homes in southern Georgia warned Tuesday that firefighters are bracing for a prolonged battle even after weekend rains gave a big boost to containment efforts.

“A little bit of rain is going to help us, but it’s not going to get us out of this situation,” Georgia Gov. Brian Kemp told a news conference after touring the fire areas Tuesday. “We’re going to be in this for a while.”

A fire that has burned roughly 35 square miles (90 square kilometers) and destroyed more than 80 homes in rural Brantley County was 32 per cent contained, the command team overseeing the fire response said Tuesday. That’s up from just 6 per cent containment reported Monday. Rains on Sunday slowed the fire enough to give crews an opening to widen containment lines along the perimeter and to snuff out some smoldering pockets, said Johnny Sabo, director of the Georgia Forestry

Key Points

- » The fire has burned roughly 35 square miles
- » Rains on Sunday slowed the fire enough to give crews an opening to widen containment lines

A LARGER WILDFIRE IN SPARSELY POPULATED CLINCH AND ECHOLS COUNTIES HAS CHARRED MORE THAN 50 SQUARE MILES

Commission. “As that number increases, our confidence at holding it in that footprint increases,” Sabo told reporters. He added: “We have a long way to go. I just want to stress that.” A larger wildfire in sparsely populated Clinch and Echols counties has charred more than 50 square miles (130 square kilometres) at the Georgia-Florida line. AGENCIES

Beijing clamps down on drones: Sales banned citywide from May 1

BANGKOK: Beijing is banning all drones within city limits starting May 1.

The Chinese capital’s city government passed a series of ordinances in late March banning drone sales and flights, although users have long been blocked from flying drones within the city.

A search on Taobao, one of China’s top online shopping platforms, showed that users with a Beijing delivery address could not check out with a drone in their cart.

An employee at a Beijing store of consumer electronics brand DJI told state-backed media outlet Jiemian that they have been told to get rid of any drones in stock by Thursday.

The new regulations say that exceptions will be made for universities, research institutions, or public safety use, but that users would have to get permission from the police. Individuals in violation face a possible fine of 500 yuan (USD 73) and could have their machines confiscated.

Security restrictions in Beijing are often tighter than in other parts of the country

Drone users in China already have to register an account on a government portal with their real name and identity before they are allowed to fly the machines.

Chinese companies dominate the global consumer drone market, prompting security concerns in countries including the US, where the Federal Communications Commission has banned new models of foreign drones.

Security restrictions in Beijing are often tighter than in other parts of the country. Previously, China has restricted drivers of Teslas from parking their vehicles in certain government compounds, including at an airport, owing to espionage concerns over cameras installed in the car. AGENCIES

Sri Lanka’s ex president to face court indictment

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka’s former president Ranil Wickremesinghe and his secretary Saman Ekanayake will face indictments for misappropriation of state funds worth 16.6 million Lankan Rupees (USD 52,000), a local court was told on Wednesday.

They are accused of using state funds for Wickremesinghe’s travel to a British university in 2023 for his wife’s graduation.

Wickremesinghe, who served as president from 2022 to 2024, argued it was an official invitation from the University of Wolverhampton, and he attended it while on transit during his return to Sri Lanka following official engagements in other countries. The Colombo Fort Magistrate’s Court on Wednesday ordered the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) to submit a progress report on the investigation into the case. The court also instructed the CID to present the relevant progress report on July 8. AGENCIES

Sudan’s war leaves Khartoum with unexploded mines, other weapons

KHARTOUM: Khaled Abdulgader noticed children using an unusual object as a football and tried to stop them.

He grabbed it, and it exploded in his hand. He lost two fingers, and shrapnel sliced into his chest.

In a hospital for a checkup after last year’s blast, he tried to stay positive.

“I feel like, Thank God it was just my hands,” Abdul-

gader said. He is among hundreds of people who have been injured or killed by unexploded ordnance in Sudan’s three years of war. That includes mines as well as weapons such as bombs, shells, grenades or rockets that failed to detonate, tens of thousands of items in all.

The government and aid groups say it’s a problem particularly in and around Khartoum, where residents, many

Nearly 60 people were injured or killed in Khartoum state last year

unfamiliar with the threat, have started to return after the Sudanese military recaptured the capital last year. Nearly 60 people were injured or killed in Khartoum state last year, over

half of them children, and 23 were injured or killed in the first three months of this year, 21 of them children, according to the United Nations.

Decades of conflict in Sudan have left unexploded ordnance scattered across the country, with a combined area of about 7,700 football fields contaminated.

More than half of that is the result of the war that erupted

in 2023 between Sudan’s army and the Rapid Support Forces paramilitary group, with new areas such as Khartoum state affected.

Both the Sudanese army and the RSF have been accused of laying mines, according to aid groups, during the war as they fought for control of the capital.

“The presence of land mines and other explosive ordnance is

of great concern to everybody,” said Juma Abuanja, the team leader for Jasmara, a Sudanese demining group. He said it will take years to clear.

Demining is a slow, careful process with staff covering 10 to 15 square metres a day. Khartoum city is still a ghost town, strewn with remnants of fighting. Charred, abandoned buildings are pocked with bullet holes. AGENCIES

Musk gets apology from California regulators as SpaceX suit settled



SpaceX CEO Elon Musk

The commission also agreed it wouldn’t require a coastal development permit pertaining to SpaceX’s launch program in state

LOS ANGELES: California regulators apologized to SpaceX CEO Elon Musk this week as they settled a lawsuit that claimed a state agency showed political bias against the rocket company and its chief executive. As part of the settlement, the California Coastal Commission acknowledged its members made “improper” statements about Musk’s political beliefs at a 2024 hearing on SpaceX’s Falcon 9 launch program. “The commission agrees that it may not consider irrelevant factors in performing its function and specifically agrees that it will not take into account the perceived political beliefs, political speech or labor practices of SpaceX or its officers in considering any regulatory action concerning SpaceX,” the commission said in federal court documents filed Tuesday. SpaceX had sued the commission over its opposition to expanding the launch schedule for Falcon 9 rockets from the Vandenberg Space Force Base on the Southern Californ-

ia coast near Santa Barbara. The company’s lawsuit accused the coastal commission of engaging in political discrimination by refusing to sign off on a U.S. Air Force proposal to boost the number of launches at the busy base owned by the federal government. The lawsuit alleged the commissioners voted against SpaceX because of their dislike of Musk’s outspoken political views, violating constitutional rights to free speech and due process.

According to the settlement, the case will be permanently dismissed while both parties agree that the deal doesn’t constitute an admission “of any liability or unlawful conduct.”

The commission also agreed it wouldn’t require a coastal development permit pertaining to SpaceX’s launch program in the state.

Representatives for SpaceX didn’t immediately respond to a request for comment on the settlement. The coastal commission acknowledged in a statement Wednesday that it had apologized for “irrelevant” statements made by its members. The commission said it continues to have serious concerns about the impacts to coastal resources from increased rocket launches at Vandenberg. AGENCIES

President Trump to feature on limited edition US passports

WASHINGTON: The State Department is all set to unveil a limited-edition US passport with pictures of President Donald Trump and the Founding Fathers to commemorate the 250th anniversary of American independence in July.

The special passports will be available only to those who show up in person at the Washington Passport Agency and not anywhere else across the country.

The Department of State shared images of the limited edition passports on its social media accounts.

One page of the passport carries Trump’s image surrounded by the text of the Declaration of Independence and the American flag along with the president’s signature in gold.

Another page features the famous painting of the founding fathers at the signing of the Declaration of Independence.

The passports, which are

One page of the passport carries Trump’s image surrounded by the text of the Declaration of Independence

set to be released this summer, are part of the Trump administration’s broader “America250” celebration, which also includes a Grand Prix race on the National Mall in August and a UFC fight on the White House South Lawn in June.

“As the United States celebrates America’s 250th anniversary in July, @StateDept is preparing to release a limited number of specially designed US Passports to commemorate this historic occasion,” State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott said in a post on X. AGENCIES

Defying protocol, Trump relays details of private conversation with King Charles III

King’s comments seemed clearly within the bounds of existing UK govt policy

LONDON: In the world of diplomatic faux pas, it could have been a lot worse.

At Tuesday’s state dinner honouring King Charles III and Queen Camilla, US President Donald Trump said that during a private meeting earlier in the day the British monarch had agreed with him that Iran should never be allowed to have nuclear weapons.

“We’re doing a little Middle East work right now ... and we’re doing very well,” Trump told the audience. “We have militarily defeated that particular opponent, and we’re never going to let that opponent ever — Charles agrees with me, even more than I do — we’re never going to let that opponent have a nuclear weapon.”

While many Britons would agree with the president’s sentiment, the comment triggered mild consternation among pundits in the UK. In Britain, you see, this just isn’t done. By convention, people aren’t supposed to relay private conversations with the monarch. That is partly because the king has to remain above the



Britain’s King Charles III toasts with US President Donald Trump during a State Dinner in the East Room of the White House State Dinner in Washington AP/PTI

political fray, but also because the sovereign doesn’t have the ability to wade into a public debate and correct the record if he’s misquoted.

“Generally, as a matter of protocol, I think I would expect discussions between heads of state to be sort of behind the scenes, in those closed meetings, for those to be sort of kept private,” said Craig Prescott, an expert on constitutional law and the monarchy at Royal Holloway, University of Lon-

don. “And, you know, this was something that the UK government wanted to avoid.”

There had been a fair amount of jitters before the king’s trip to the United States, which comes amid Trump’s very public frustration with UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer over his failure to support US actions in the Iran war.

Like all royal visits, this is a carefully choreographed diplomatic event carried out at the request of the UK govern-

Takeaways

- » There had been a fair amount of jitters before the king’s trip to the United States
- » President Trump said that during a private meeting earlier in the day the British monarch had agreed with him that Iran should never be allowed to have nuclear weapons

ment, which hopes that warm relations between the king and Trump, who seems to love all things royal, can help repair the rift.

But Trump is an unconventional leader who has a penchant for breaking protocol, and there were concerns about just what he might say or do. At least in this case, the king’s comments seemed clearly within the bounds of existing UK government policy. AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAKISTAN’S PUNJAB SETS 18 YEARS AS MINIMUM LEGAL MARRIAGE AGE

LAHORE: Pakistan’s Punjab government has changed the 97-year-old law by setting 18 years as the minimum legal age for marriage for girls and declaring underage marriage a non-bailable offence. Previously, the minimum legal age for marriage in Punjab, a province of 130 million people, was 16 years for girls under the Punjab Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929. The Maryam Nawaz government of Punjab introduced the “Child Marriage Restraint Bill 2026” in the Punjab Assembly, which was adopted this week. According to the new law, marriage below the age of 18 for both males and females is a non-bailable and cognisable offence. Adults marrying a female child (under 18) will face up to three years of rigorous imprisonment and a fine of up to PKR 500,000.

LEBANON DETAINS EX-PALESTINIAN ENVOY AT AIRPORT ON GRAFT CHARGES

BEIRUT: Lebanese authorities detained the former Palestinian ambassador to Lebanon on corruption charges shortly after he arrived in the country, officials said Wednesday. The officials said Ashraf Dabbour was arrested upon arrival at Beirut’s Rafik Hariri International Airport late Tuesday. The two judicial and two security officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak to the media. Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas relieved Dabbour of his post as Palestinian ambassador to Lebanon last year.

Adani Power March qtr net profit soars 64% to ₹4,271 cr

It had reported a net profit of Rs 2,599.23 crore in the year-ago quarter, the company said in an exchange filing

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Adani Power on Wednesday reported over 64 per cent growth in consolidated net profit to Rs 4,271.40 crore during the quarter ended March 31, mainly driven by higher revenues and lower tax expenses.

It had reported a net profit of Rs 2,599.23 crore in the year-ago quarter, the company said in an exchange filing.

The company's total income rose to Rs 15,989.09 crore in the fourth quarter from Rs 14,535.60 crore in the same period of the preceding 2024-25 financial year.

For the full FY26, the company's net profit rose to Rs 12,971.08 crore from Rs 12,749.61 crore in FY25.

In a separate statement, Adani Power said it recorded a higher profit after tax for Q4 and FY26 on the back of lower tax expenses.

Continuing operating revenues for the quarter were up by 2.93 per cent at Rs 14,559.97 crore compared to Rs 14,145.31 crore for Q4 FY25 due to high plant uptime being maintained, favourable foreign exchange movement, and greater operating capacity, despite lower merchant prices and lower prices of



The company's total income rose to Rs 15,989.09 crore in Q4 FY26 from Rs 14,535.60 crore in Q4 2024-25 fiscal

imported coal.

SB Khyalia, CEO of Adani Power, said, "As the world goes through another energy price shock, the security and sovereignty of India's energy supply assume critical importance. Our abundant natural resources, including coal, will power our growth and development for a long time. As India progresses quickly to achieve its renewable energy targets, thermal power is rising to the challenge of stabilising the grid and meeting peak demand".

As of March 31, 2026, the cumulative work for Mahan

Key Points

» For FY26, Adani Power's net profit rose to Rs 12,971.08 cr from Rs 12,749.61 cr in FY25

» In a separate statement, Adani Power said it recorded a higher profit after tax for Q4 and FY26 on the back of lower tax expenses

» Operating revenues for Q4 FY26 rose 2.93% to Rs 14,559.97 crore against Rs 14,145.31 crore for Q4 FY25

Phase II 1,600 MW USCTPP (ultra super critical thermal power plant) has reached 86 per cent, Raipur Phase-II 1,600 MW USCTPP 54 per cent, and Raigarh Phase-II 1,600 MW USCTPP 47 per cent.

Further, the 1,320 MW Phase-II expansion of APL's wholly-owned subsidiary Korba Power Ltd is also set to be completed in FY 2026-27.

The company aims to add 23.7 GW thermal power capacity by 2032.

During the quarter, Adani Power has received a Letter of Award (LoA) from Maharash-

tra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL) for the supply of 1,600 MW power for 25 years from a new (USCTPP) to be developed on Design, Build, Finance, Own and Operate (DBFOO) model by sourcing fuel from the allocated coal linkage arranged by the utility under the SHAKTI Policy.

The company said its subsidiary Moxie Power Generation Ltd (MPGL) signed a 558 MW PPA with Tamil Nadu DISCOM for a period of five years, to be supplied from the Tuticorin (Mutiar) power plant.

With this, the operating capacity of MPGL has been tied up fully, while APL's aggregate operating capacity has been tied up to the extent of 95 per cent under long and medium-term PPAs.

Adani Power (APL), a part of the Adani portfolio, is the largest private thermal power producer in India. The company has an installed thermal power capacity of 18,110 MW spread across twelve power plants in Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand, and Tamil Nadu, apart from a 40 MW solar power plant in Gujarat.

Vedanta's March quarter profit zooms 89% to ₹9,352 cr on higher metal prices, weak rupee

In the year-ago period, the Anil Agarwal-led mining conglomerate posted a consolidated PAT (profit after tax) of Rs 4,961 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Mining conglomerate Vedanta Ltd on Wednesday reported an 89 per cent rise in its consolidated profit after tax at Rs 9,352 crore in the quarter ended March 2026, citing higher sales volume amid rising global metal prices as well as the weakening rupee's exchange rate.

In the year-ago period, the Anil Agarwal-led company posted a consolidated PAT of Rs 4,961 crore.

The revenue from operations during the latest fourth quarter also rose by 29 per cent to Rs 51,524 crore from Rs 39,789 crore a year ago.

"4QFY26 consolidated revenue at Rs 51,524 crore, up 29 per cent YoY & 12 per cent QoQ driven by higher LME, volumes, premium, and forex gain," Vedanta said in a statement.

The total expenses of the company during the reporting quarter rose to Rs 19,119 crore from Rs 13,702 crore recorded in the year-ago period, the filing said.

Vedanta Executive Director Arun Misra said that FY26 was a year of strong execution for Vedanta, with record operational performance across the portfolio. "We delivered 2.9 million tonnes (MT) of alumina, 2.46 MT of aluminium, 1.1 MT of mined metal at Zinc India... reflecting improved operating



Revenue from operations rose by 29% to Rs 51,524 crore in Q4 FY26 from Rs 39,789 crore in Q4 FY25

efficiency alongside the ramp up of new capacities," he said.

During the year, he said, the company deployed Rs 14,918 crore of growth capex, commissioning key projects, including the new BALCO smelter, downstream expansions at Jharsuguda, the Debari roaster at Zinc India, and 1.3 GW of power capacity. "Our continued focus on operational excellence resulted in lowest costs in last five years at aluminium and zinc business," he said.

The company's gross debt as on March 31, 2026, stood at Rs 81,740 crore, while the net debt stood at Rs 53,254 crore.

"The quarter marks a defining point for Vedanta, with the delivery of our strongest-ever financial performance record-

Highlights

» Firms' total expenses rose to Rs 19,119 cr in Q4 FY26 from Rs 13,702 cr in Q4 FY25

» Vedanta's gross debt as on March 31, 2026, stood at Rs 81,740 cr, while net debt stood at Rs 53,254 cr

» It delivered 2.9 MT of alumina, 2.46 million tonnes of aluminium, 1.1 million tonnes of mined metal at Zinc India

ing all-time highs in revenue, EBITDA, and PAT for both the quarter and the full year and a clear positioning for the next phase of growth with demerger effective from 1st of May '26," Vedanta CFO Ajay Goel said.

Vedanta had earlier said that its board has approved May 1, 2026, as the effective date for the demerger of its aluminium, merchant power, oil and gas and iron ore verticals into separate listed entities.

In a filing to BSE, the company had said, "The board of directors of the company at its meeting held on April 20, 2026, as part of the ongoing reorganisation process, has inter alia, approved to make the scheme effective on May 1, 2026."

The company also added

that in consultation with other entities involved, the board has fixed May 1 as the record date for determining the shareholders eligible to receive consideration pursuant to the scheme.

Vedanta, in a statement, had said that the demerger will help in simplifying Vedanta's corporate structure with sector-focussed independent businesses and provide opportunities to global investors, including sovereign wealth funds, retail investors and strategic investors, with direct investment opportunities in dedicated pure-play companies linked to India's remarkable growth story through Vedanta's world-class assets.

It will also provide a platform for individual units to pursue strategic agendas more freely and better align with customers, investment cycles and end markets, it had added.

As part of the demerger, Vedanta plans to separately list four entities — Vedanta Aluminium Metal Limited (VAML), Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd (TSPL), Malco Energy Ltd (MEL), and Vedanta Iron and Steel Limited (VISL).

Vedanta Ltd is the world's leading producer of metals, oil & gas, critical minerals, power and technology. The company supplies essential materials that power the global energy transition, emerging technologies and the green economy of the future.

Indian Bank Q4 profit rises 5% to ₹3,103 crore

NEW DELHI: State-owned Indian Bank on Wednesday reported a 5 per cent rise in net profit to Rs 3,103 crore for the March quarter of FY26, supported by improved asset quality and lower bad loan provisions.

The lender had posted a net profit of Rs 2,956 crore in the year-ago period.

Total income for the quarter increased to Rs 19,980 crore from Rs 18,599 crore, while interest income grew to Rs 17,480 crore from Rs 15,856 crore. Net Interest Income (NII) rose to Rs 7,109 crore, up from Rs 6,389 crore a year earlier.

Asset quality strengthened, with gross NPAs declining to 1.98 per cent from 3.09 per cent a year ago, and net NPAs easing to 0.15 per cent from 0.19 per cent.

Provisions for bad loans fell sharply to Rs 748 crore from Rs 1,100 crore. However, quarterly recoveries dipped to Rs 1,499 crore from Rs 1,782 crore.

For FY27, the bank has board approval to raise up to Rs 5,000 crore through various routes, including QIP, if required.

It has also proposed a dividend of Rs 18.25 per share for FY26.

For the full FY26, net profit rose 11 per cent to Rs 12,156 crore, while total income increased to Rs 77,441 crore. Net Interest Income stood at Rs 26,915 crore, with net interest margin at 3.23 per cent. AGENCIES

Govt weighs financing plan to boost private e-bus, e-truck adoption

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Heavy Industries held a high-level meeting on Wednesday to deliberate on financing mechanisms required to accelerate the adoption of electric buses (e-buses) and electric trucks (e-trucks) in the private sector.

During the meeting, chaired by Kamran Rizvi, Secretary, Ministry of Heavy Industries, critical interventions for EV financing to address challenges in the adoption of e-buses and e-trucks by private sector stakeholders were discussed.

"The objectives of the meeting were to understand the financing challenges related to e-Bus and e-Truck adoption, assess the current status of financing for these vehicles, explore potential solutions to

address existing barriers, and identify the Government support required," the Ministry of Heavy Industries said in a post on X. The meeting saw wide participation from key stakeholders across the financial and industrial ecosystem, including the Department of Financial Services, Govt of India & World Bank.

Major public and private sector banks participated, along with NBFCs and apex institutions, including SIDBI, NIIIF, bus operators, truck operators, OEMs, and other key stakeholders, along with industry bodies such as the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers, All India Motor Transport Congress and Bus Operators Confederation of India. PTI

Reserve Bank launches three key surveys for monetary policy inputs

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank on Wednesday announced the commencement of three key surveys, including on inflation expectations, to collect inputs for its monetary policy.

The RBI said it has launched the May 2026 round of the 'inflation expectations survey of households' to capture subjective assessments on price movements and inflation, based on their individual consumption baskets, across 19 cities.

"The survey seeks qualitative responses from households on price changes (general prices as well as prices of specific product groups) in the three months ahead as well as in the one-year ahead period and quantitative responses on current, three



months ahead and one year ahead inflation rates," it said.

The central bank also announced the launch of the May 2026 rounds of the rural consumer confidence survey and urban consumer confidence survey.

The RBI said the urban consumer confidence survey is conducted regularly in 19 cities.

The 19 cities covered in the inflation expectations survey and urban consumer confidence

survey are Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Bhopal, Bhubaneswar, Chandigarh, Chennai, Delhi, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Jaipur, Jammu, Kolkata, Lucknow, Mumbai, Nagpur, Patna, Raipur, Ranchi and Thiruvananthapuram.

The rural consumer confidence survey collects current perceptions and one-year-ahead expectations of households on the general economic situation, employment scenario, overall price situation, own income and spending from the households residing in the rural and semi-urban areas across 31 states/UTs. The results of the surveys provide useful inputs for monetary policy, the central bank said. PTI

Vedanta entities to trade on stock exchanges by mid-June post-demerger, says CEO

'The shareholders holding one share of Vedanta as on April 29 will receive four additional shares of the resulting companies'

will entail the creation of five independent sector-specific pure play companies, allowing each company to chart out its own growth trajectory and attract investors.

The company, he said, has set May 1 as the record date for listing approval. The shares of the resulting companies are expected to list and commence trading by mid-June," she said.

Vedanta Ltd is the Indian arm of Vedanta Resources. Vedanta CEO Ajay Goel said the company's board has earlier approved Vedanta demerger effective from May 1, and this

"We are targeting listing and commencement of trading of these shares by the first quarter of FY27," he said. The demerger has been structured with precision on capital structure, aligning debt with the earning strength and growth stage of each resulting company, he said.

Vedanta Oil & Gas and Iron & Steel businesses will emerge as close to zero net debt businesses, while the other three businesses will have net debt to EBITDA ratios in line with their debt servicing capability, Goyal said.

Vedanta had earlier said that the demerger will help in simplifying Vedanta's corporate structure with sector focussed independent businesses and provide opportunities to global investors, including sovereign wealth funds, retail investors

and strategic investors, with direct investment opportunities in dedicated pure-play companies linked to India's remarkable growth story through Vedanta's world class assets.

It will also provide a platform for individual units to pursue strategic agendas more freely and better align with customers, investment cycles and end markets, it added.

As part of the demerger, Vedanta plans to separately list four entities: Vedanta Aluminium Metal Limited (VAML), Talwandi Sabo Power Ltd (TSPL), Malco Energy Ltd (MEL) and Vedanta Iron and Steel Limited (VISL). According to the exchange filing, under the composite scheme of arrangement, shareholders of Vedanta will receive equity shares in four businesses in a 1:1 ratio. PTI

Bank credit growth slows to 15% in first half of April: RBI data shows

MUMBAI: Bank credit growth slowed to 15 per cent in the fortnight ended April 15, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Wednesday.

According to the latest data, the pace of lending growth slowed down to 14.88 per cent year-on-year (YoY) in the fortnight ended April 15, as compared to 15.96 per cent recorded in the preceding fortnight.

During the reporting period, overall credit contracted by 2.06 per cent or Rs 4.51 lakh crore.

Bank credit stood at Rs 214 lakh crore in the fortnight ended April 15, as compared to Rs 218 lakh crore during the preceding 15-day period ended March 31. The total credit stood at Rs 186 lakh crore in the fort-

night ended April 18 last year, the RBI data showed.

During the fortnight ended March 31, bank credit grew at the fastest pace in the last two fiscal years, as banks rushed to meet their balance sheet targets ahead of the financial year-end, resulting in a sharp increase in both loans and deposits.

Bank credit growth has remained in double digits for more than seven consecutive months, reflecting sustained momentum in lending activity. The acceleration in credit expansion gathered pace following the government's move to rationalise the GST structure in September last year.

The continued double-digit growth indicates a revival in

credit demand from both retail borrowers and corporates in recent months, underscoring improving economic activity and stronger financing needs across sectors.

Meanwhile, deposits of banks grew 12.12 per cent year-on-year in the fortnight ended April 15. In absolute terms, deposits stood at Rs 261.88 lakh crore during the 15-day period ended April 15 this year, compared to Rs 233.56 lakh crore in the fortnight ended April 18, 2025. Investments by banks in state and central government securities jumped to Rs 70.64 lakh crore in the reporting period, as compared to Rs 68.49 lakh crore recorded a year ago. PTI

IOB Q4 profit rises 45.51% to ₹1,556.15 crore

MUMBAI: State-owned Indian Overseas Bank (IOB) on Wednesday reported a 45.51 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 1,556.15 crore in Q4 FY26, driven by growth in core interest income and improved asset quality.

The bank had posted a profit of Rs 1,091.94 crore a year ago. On a sequential basis, net profit jumped by 9.04 per cent.

MD & CEO Ajay Kumar Srivastava said higher credit growth, CASA expansion and non-interest income, including PSLC sales and fee-based income, supported performance. Net interest income rose 11.11 per cent to Rs 3,470 crore from Rs 3,123 crore a year ago.

Domestic net interest margin narrowed to 3.35 per cent from 3.42 per cent in Q3 & 3.77 per cent a year earlier, reflecting transmission of a 1.25 per cent repo rate cut by the RBI.

Advances grew 24.16 per cent to Rs 3.10 lakh crore, while deposits rose 18.03 per cent to Rs 3.68 lakh crore. CASA deposits increased 10.85 per cent to Rs 1.51 lakh crore, with the domestic CASA ratio at 41.46 per cent.

Asset quality improved, with gross NPAs declining to 1.42 per cent from 2.14 per cent a year ago. The bank created a floating provision of about Rs 400 crore to address risks from West Asia crisis. IOB targets 12-13 per cent credit growth & 13-14 per cent deposit growth in FY27, along with Rs 3,600 crore in recoveries and upgrades. AGENCIES

West Asia conflict raises inflation risks, India's domestic strength offers cushion: FinMin

Prolonged uncertainty, particularly around energy and fertiliser supplies, could test the resilience of India's macroeconomic stability, the report said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The ongoing conflict in West Asia poses a significant supply-side shock with rising risks to inflation, trade and financial flows, though India's strong domestic demand, policy buffers, resilient financial system and continued public investment are expected to provide a measure of insulation to the economy, the Finance Ministry said in a report.

Prolonged uncertainty, particularly around energy and fertiliser supplies, could test the resilience of India's macroeconomic stability, the Monthly

Economic Review for April released by the finance ministry said on Wednesday.

On top of this, the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO) is expected to keep India's South-west monsoon below normal, it said, adding that most rainfall districts are expected to receive below-normal rainfall this season.

Therefore, it said, risks are tilted to the upside for inflation, fiscal and external deficits and to the downside for economic growth. However, it said, while striving to sustain economic growth, policy is expected to safeguard medium-term fiscal

and external stability.

Observing that India enters FY27 at the intersection of domestic resilience and external turbulence, the report said, encouraging a 7-7.4 per cent forecast for the upcoming financial year, only to be clouded by an altered macro-outlook in the wake of the war in West Asia.

The Indian economy is estimated to grow at 7.6 per cent, the strongest in recent years.

Noting that a 'supply shock' is apparent in the economy, it said that an accompanying demand compression is a serious concern, given high prices, rising inflation, and a reduced

CLOSER LOOK

» The Indian economy is estimated to grow at 7.6 per cent, the strongest in recent years

» 'Inflation may become cost-push as businesses pass on their increased input costs to protect profit margins'

» A wide spectrum of downstream industries relies directly on the petroleum sector, and it is likely that input cost pressures will be felt widely across the economy

pace of economic activity.

Inflation may become cost-push as businesses/producers pass on their increased input costs to protect their profit margins, it said. A wide spectrum of downstream industries relies

directly on the petroleum sector, and it is likely that input cost pressures will be felt widely across the economy, it added.

To temper cost pressures in critical sectors like agriculture, it said, the government has

taken various measures such as increased allocation of natural gas to the fertiliser production, waiver of customs duty and around 12 per cent increase in nutrient-based subsidy for the upcoming kharif season.

Beyond the production structures, it said, the conflict has seriously dented investors' confidence, disproportionately affecting Emerging Markets and Developing Economies (EMDEs), including India.

The consequent weakening of the rupee is another pressure point for domestic inflation, as that could raise import prices, it said.

The report said that repairing the damage to the oil and gas production/supply infrastructure in the Gulf region may take several months.

If such a gradual recovery is not supported by a good kharif output (a weather shock/below normal monsoon as predicted by the IMD – possible El Niño conditions), it is likely that the price shock felt at the headline inflation might spill over to the core measure through the cost-push channel, it said.

Yet it remains to be seen whether the spill-over effect will be strong/widespread or weak/limited, as it depends on a

range of factors such as the size of the shock, variability in the pass-through duration across different markets/commodities, price flexibility/ rigidity in sectoral markets, energy intensity of different sectors, etc, it said.

The crisis in West Asia is not expected to adversely affect financial stability, as key indicators for capital adequacy, liquidity, and asset quality in both SCBs and NBFCs remain strong, it said.

Further, it said, the RBI will continue its proactive approach to ensure adequate liquidity to meet the economy's productive needs.

Oil marketing cos selling petrol at loss of ₹14/litre, diesel at ₹18

Besides losses on fuel, elevated energy prices are likely to leave firms with an under recovery of ₹80,000 crore on LPG in the current fiscal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Oil marketing companies are selling petrol and diesel at a loss of Rs 14 per litre and Rs 18 per litre, respectively, as elevated crude prices outpace capped retail fuel rates, squeezing marketing margins.

Besides losses on petrol and diesel, the elevated energy prices post West Asia crisis are likely to leave companies with an under recovery of Rs 80,000 crore on cooking gas LPG in the current fiscal, while fertiliser subsidy is projected to rise to Rs 2.05 to 2.25 lakh crore.

Rating agency Icrs said supply disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz - handling around 20 per cent of global oil and LNG trade - have tightened availability of fuels, fertilisers and chemicals, pushing up prices and increasing cost pressures across downstream industries.

Crude prices before the West Asia crisis broke out two months back were around \$70-72 a barrel.

"The stable pump prices for auto fuels amid elevated crude oil prices are impacting the profitability of the oil marketing companies (OMCs)," said Prashant Vasisht, Senior Vice President and Co-Group



Crude prices before the West Asia crisis broke out two months back were around \$70-72 a barrel

Head, Icrs.

"At crude prices of \$120-125 per barrel, marketing margins on petrol and diesel are estimated to be negative Rs 14 a litre and Rs 18 per litre, respectively," Icrs estimates LPG under-recoveries could reach Rs 80,000 crore in FY2027, if current trends persist, while the fertiliser subsidy burden is projected to rise to Rs 2.05-2.25 lakh crore, above the budgeted Rs 1.71 lakh crore.

Elevated raw material and energy costs are expected to weigh on profitability across oil marketing, fertilisers, chemicals and city gas distribution sectors, with limited ability to fully pass on higher costs to end consumers.

"Overall, Icrs's outlook on the crude oil refining segment remains stable...while the outlook on the fuel retailing, fertiliser, basic chemicals and petrochemical sectors remains

Highlights

» Fertiliser subsidy burden is projected to rise to Rs 2.05-2.25 lakh crore, above the budgeted Rs 1.71 lakh crore

» Urea pool prices have risen to about \$19 per million British thermal unit in April 2026 from \$13 before the crisis

» While profitability in PNG for households remains relatively stable, CNG margins are expected to weaken as cost increases are only partially passed on

per million British thermal unit in April 2026 from \$13 before the crisis.

"Significant raw material price inflation coupled with inadequate subsidy revision is set to moderate the profitability of the P&K fertiliser players," Vasisht said, adding that weather risks could further limit farmers' ability to absorb price hikes.

Chemical and polymer prices have surged amid disrupted trade flows and higher fuel costs, prompting stockpiling by manufacturers and consumers. However, Icrs expects demand to normalise once inventory buildup subsides, particularly in segments exposed to global oversupply.

City gas distributors face margin pressure from rising gas prices and currency depreciation. While profitability in piped natural gas (PNG) for households remains relatively stable due to priority gas allocation, compressed natural gas (CNG) margins are expected to weaken as cost increases are only partially passed on.

Icrs said elevated energy and input costs will likely compress margins across multiple sectors, leading to weaker credit profiles in some cases.

Markets rebound nearly 1% amid value buying in FMCG, auto stocks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark Sensex rebounded nearly 610 points and broader Nifty settled above 24,100 on Wednesday following value buying in FMCG, auto and telecom shares amid earnings optimism and a rally in Asian markets.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 609.45 points, or 0.79 per cent, to settle at 77,496.36. During the day, it surged to 1,095.6 points, or 1.42 per cent, to a high of 77,982.51.

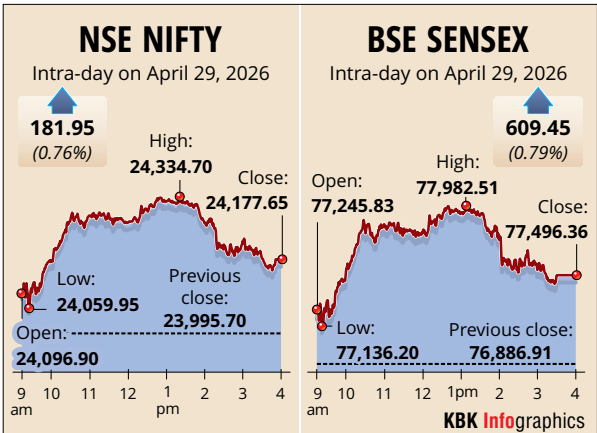
The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 181.95 points or 0.76 per cent to end at 24,177.65.

Among Sensex firms, ITC, Tech Mahindra, Maruti, Reliance Industries, Bharti Airtel and Mahindra & Mahindra were among the biggest gainers.

In contrast, InterGlobe Aviation, NTPC, Bajaj Finserv and ICICI Bank were among the laggards.

Maruti climbed 2.82 per cent after the country's largest carmaker reported a record annual consolidated net profit of Rs 14,679.5 crore in FY26, a year-on-year growth of 1.24 per cent, riding on its best-ever annual sales of over 24.22 lakh units, propelled by GST rate reduction.

"The core driver of today's strength remained earnings. Strong results from key companies reinforced confidence in underlying domestic demand and balance sheet resilience. This fundamental support, combined with easing geopolitical concerns, helped mar-



In broader markets BSE SmallCap Select index climbed 0.75%, while MidCap Select index declined 0.49%

kets shift focus away from macro stress toward corporate performance," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

Hopes of potential de-escalation in geopolitical tensions helped stabilise crude oil expectations, which is critical for India's macro outlook, he said.

Broader markets also rallied as the BSE SmallCap Select index climbed 0.75 per cent, while MidCap Select index declined 0.49 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, FMCG jumped the most

by 1.57 per cent, followed by Realty (1.42 per cent), Telecommunication (1.28 per cent), Energy (1.14 per cent), Auto (1.02 per cent), Mid-small Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.83 per cent) and IT (0.81 per cent). Utilities dropped 1.22 per cent, Power (1.05 per cent), Consumer Durables (0.43 per cent), Hospitals (0.42 per cent), PSU Bank (0.42 per cent) and Bankex (0.07 per cent).

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 2.85 per cent to \$114.4 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 2,103.74 crore on Tuesday, while Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs) bought stocks worth Rs 1,712.01 crore, according to exchange data.

On Tuesday, the Sensex declined 416.72 points, or 0.54 per cent, to settle at 76,886.91. The Nifty dropped 97 points, or 0.40 per cent, to end at 23,995.70.

Rupee falls 20 paise to 94.88 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated 20 paise to close at its all-time low of 94.88 against the US dollar on Wednesday, pressured by rising Brent crude oil prices, hovering around USD 115 per barrel, and continued foreign capital outflows.

Forex traders said the elevated crude oil price is likely to sharply impact India's import costs, while the ongoing West Asia crisis and concerns over potential wider conflict are fuelling investor anxiety.

Also, analysts said that investors were awaiting cues from the upcoming US Federal Reserve policy decision.

Moreover, heavy foreign institutional investor (FII) selling so far this year further dented investor sentiment.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.79 against the US dollar, then lost ground and touched an intraday low of 94.86 against the US dollar.

It finally settled for the day at 94.88, registering a fall of 20 paise over its previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee depreciated by 53 paise to close at 94.68 against the US dollar.

The rupee's all-time low closing level of 94.85 versus the US dollar was recorded on March 27 this year.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was up 0.08 per cent at 98.72.

Govt plans emission rule to tweaks to widen scope for higher ethanol blends

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has proposed amendments to vehicle emission rules to widen the scope for higher ethanol blends and alternative fuels, paving the way for flex-fuel and pure biofuel vehicles across all vehicle categories.

The draft changes to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 aim to provide for wider use of fuels, such as E85 (a blend of 85 per cent ethanol with petrol) and E100 (which would allow vehicles to run on nearly pure ethanol), as well as B100 biodiesel and hydrogen-CNG combinations.

India has already achieved 20 per cent blending of ethanol with petrol to create a cleaner-burning fuel, reducing reliance on imported crude oil and cutting carbon emissions. In an April 27 gazette notification, the



ministry said the changes would be taken up after a 30-day public consultation period, during which stakeholders can submit objections or suggestions.

Among key proposals, the draft raises the vehicle weight limit from 3,000 kg to 3,500 kg, bringing regulation in sync with global standards for light commercial vehicles. This means more vans, pickups, and small trucks will now fall under the same emission testing rules.

It recognises fuels with higher blends of renewable bio-fuels - E20 (20 per cent ethanol

blended petrol), E85 (85 per cent ethanol), E100 (100 per cent ethanol) and B100 (100 per cent biodiesel).

Until now, the rules mostly spoke about E10 and E20. This amendment opens the regulatory door for flex-fuel vehicles and pure biofuel vehicles across all vehicle categories - two-wheelers, three-wheelers, passenger cars, and heavy vehicles.

The notification also updates fuel definitions and standards, including replacing references to "Hydrogen+CN" with "Hydrogen+CNG". It also corrects specific emission intensity metric measuring the mass of pollutant (in milligrams) emitted per unit of energy produced to "mg/kWh" from earlier "Mg/kWh". The World-Harmonised not-to-exceed (WNTe) emission limit has been corrected from "60" to "600".

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: India's domestic aviation sector maintained stable performance in March 2026, with low cancellation rates and steady passenger growth, according to the latest traffic report based on data from scheduled airlines.

The report shows that the overall flight cancellation rate stood at just 0.50 per cent, indicating operational stability across carriers. However, cancellations were primarily attributed to technical issues (38.4 percent), followed by operational reasons (27.2 per cent) and weather-related factors (19.1 percent).

Despite shifts across carriers, IndiGo stayed ahead in March, claiming above 63 per cent of the market. Behind



it came the Air India Group, securing roughly 26 per cent. Growth marked Akasa Air's performance, capturing just over 5 per cent. Smaller slices went to others, including SpiceJet and Alliance Air, persisting within limited reach.

During the month, there were 7,398 passenger complaints - this comes out to roughly 5.13 for every 10,000 travellers. Baggage troubles accounted for 47.1 per cent of these reports; flight disruptions made up 20.3 per cent. Refund concerns stood at 19 per

cent, placing third in frequency. Nearly all cases - about 99.8 per cent - were settled by airlines. Progress in handling feedback appears evident through such resolution rates.

Despite differences across carriers, punctuality rates shifted noticeably. Nearly 88.7 per cent of IndiGo flights arrived on schedule - the strongest result seen. Close behind stood Akasa Air and those under Air India Group. In contrast, only about 43 per cent of SpiceJet's operations kept time. When examining large terminals, Chennai led in timely arrivals. Punctuality dipped somewhat in both Mumbai and Guwahati.

Even with few cancellations, delays continue to pose challenges; roughly 0.92 per cent of flights experience waits exceed-

ing two hours. Most holdups stem from what is labelled "reactionary" causes - these make up 66 per cent of all delays - showing impacts carried forward from prior issues.

Among the findings was a note about airline expenses exceeding Rs 319 crore for aiding passengers during disruptions, including situations involving flight cancellations or refusal of boarding. Though delays were common, support measures still took up significant spending across carriers.

Still, numbers show an industry holding steady while getting better at what it does. Yet disruptions remain a factor that affects operations. Even so, performance gains are visible across key areas. However, passenger experience often falls short of expected standards.

Healthy rise in exports in April so far: Goyal

NEW DELHI: The country's exports have shown a healthy increase during the first three weeks of April so far despite challenges due to the ongoing West Asia crisis, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Wednesday.

"There is an increase in exports during the first three weeks of April as compared to the same period of last April...Despite the war in West Asia, there is tremendous enthusiasm among domestic exporters," Goyal told reporters here.

The trade data for April will be released by the commerce ministry on May 15. Exports posted the steepest fall in five months, declining by 7.44 per cent in March to \$38.92 billion due to trade uncertainty and geopolitical tensions, with

shipments to West Asia contracting by more than 50 per cent in the month, according to official data released on Wednesday.

On exports to West Asia, he said the consignments are going through different routes because the Strait of Hormuz is "still a challenge". The ongoing crisis has severely impacted the movement of cargo ships through the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow passage between Iran and Oman/UAE. It is the major route for shipping lines to carry consignments from India to the Middle East region.

When asked about the progress in negotiations for a trade pact with the US, the minister said, "We had very good discussions, I think about a week ago. Our team is back,

and we continue to engage."

An Indian official team returned from Washington this month after holding three-day talks with US authorities on finalising the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement.

Both sides discussed several areas, such as market access, non-tariff measures, technical barriers to trade, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, economic security alignment and digital trade.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for an interim trade pact regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. The framework requires recalibration in view of changes in the US tariff landscape.

Goyal also said that the

government has finalised a number of trade pacts with countries, including the UAE, UK, EU, EFTA (European Free Trade Association), Australia, Mauritius & Oman. "Another 12 (FTAs) are on the anvil," he said.

India is negotiating trade agreements with Chile, Peru, Israel, the Gulf Cooperation Council, Canada, South Africa and its neighbouring regions; Brazil and its neighbouring countries; and Russia and the Eurasian region.

On the country's FDI inflows, Goyal said it "would probably cross about \$87-88 billion, maybe \$90 billion" in 2025-26. Total FDI inflows, which include reinvested earnings, stood at \$73.31 billion in April-December 2025-26.

India's gold demand rises 10% to 151 tonnes during Jan-March

'Investment-led buying gained momentum, rising by 54% to 82 tonnes, offsetting weakness in jewellery demand'

MUMBAI: India's gold demand witnessed a 10 per cent on-year rise to 151 tonnes during the January-March quarter of this year, driven by a sharp surge in investment demand amid a significant jump in prices of the yellow metal, the World Gold Council said in a report on Wednesday.

According to the World Gold Council (WGC) report, there has been a more pronounced structural shift in the country's gold demand, with investment-led buying gaining momentum, which rose by 54 per cent across bars and coins and ETFs to 82 tonnes,

offsetting weakness in jewellery demand.

Jewellery demand faced notable headwinds during the quarter, declining 19 per cent year-on-year to 66 tonnes, as elevated prices and affordability constraints continued to weigh on consumption, particularly in price-sensitive segments.

For the full year, demand for gold could stand between 650-750 tonnes, compared to 712 tonnes last year, as rising gold prices in recent months have outstripped consumer budgets.

The country's total gold demand during the first quar-

CLOSER LOOK

» Jewellery demand faced notable headwinds during the quarter, declining 19 per cent year-on-year to 66 tonnes

» For the full year, demand for gold could stand between 650-750 tonnes, compared to 712 tonnes last year

» In value terms, demand nearly doubled, surging 99% year-on-year in the March quarter of 2026 to a record Rs 2,27,500 crore (USD 25 billion), the report said

ter of 2025 stood at 137 tonnes, according to the WGC's Q1 2026 Gold Demand Trends report.

In value terms, demand nearly doubled, surging 99 per cent year-on-year in the March

record-high prices and evolving consumer preferences.

"Total gold demand for the quarter stood at 151 tonnes, marking a 10 per cent increase compared to Q1 2025. In value terms, demand nearly doubled to Rs 99,900 crores, up 99 per cent year-on-year, underscoring the impact of the sharp rise in gold prices," WGC Regional CEO, India, Sachin Jain said.

Domestic gold price (MCX spot gold price) rose 81 per cent year-over-year during the first quarter of 2026, reaching a record quarterly average of Rs 1,51,108 per 10 grams compared to Rs 83,375 during the

same period last year.

Bar and coin demand rose sharply, increasing 34 per cent year-on-year to 62 tonnes -- the highest first-quarter level since 2013. Value demand surged 142 per cent to Rs 94,100 crore, a departure from a market where jewellery has traditionally dominated.

"Looking ahead, while elevated prices may act as a near-term headwind for jewellery demand, the summer wedding season and regional festivals are expected to provide support, building on the momentum seen during Akshaya Tritiya," Jain said.

RCF AT INCOMEX 2026



Rail Coach Factory (RCF), Kapurthala participated in INCOMEX 2026 organised by the Karnataka Chamber of Commerce & Industry in Hubballi, Karnataka from April 25 to April 29, 2026. Various coach manufacturing units of Indian Railways took part in the exhibition & showcased their latest developments and technological capabilities. The stall displayed miniature coach models, translifts, films based on coach manufacturing, and promotional material related to rail coach production. The exhibition proved to be an important platform for RCF to showcase its developments at the national level.

MPOST

Sunrisers put up Klassen act

Head, Klaasen power SRH to fourth-highest run-chase in IPL

BENGALURU: Travis Head (76) and Heinrich Klaasen (65 not out) outmuscled Ryan Rickelton's record 123 not out for Mumbai Indians as Sunrisers Hyderabad romped home to a six-wicket in their Indian Premier League contest, here on Wednesday.

After Rickelton's highest individual score for MI and also their fastest-ever ton in IPL history took the hosts to a formidable 243/5, SRH rode on a combined batting show to win with eight balls to spare.

MI had also registered their highest score batting first, but SRH recorded the fourth-highest successful run chase in IPL history on a docile wicket which provided absolutely no competition between the bat and the ball.

Chasing 244, SRH made 249/4 in 18.4 overs.

While Head provided early fireworks racing to 30-ball 76 with eight sixes and four fours, Klaasen produced an equally brutal knock to finish with 65 not out off 30 balls with seven fours and four sixes. For MI, a string of missed opportunities early on proved costly in their sixth defeat in eight matches.

While he was in his usual element, Head's knock was also littered with lifelines provided by MI. The first ball of the third



SRH's Heinrich Klassen got to his fifty in the 16th over

BCCI

over from Trent Boult (1/41) swung away from Head and he threw his hands at it, slicing in the air towards deep point. Naman Dhir did well to get to the ball but it burst through his hands to land beyond the ropes. In the fifth over, Head went deep in the crease to cut one in the air and despite timing his jump right, the ball brushed Dhir's fingers.

Dhir was in action again at the boundary ropes over point when he collected the ball in his hands but ended up on the

ropes with it, as Head completed a 20-ball half-century.

A pivotal moment had, meanwhile, arrived in the third over's second ball when one that shaped away from Head off Boult, was collected by Rickelton and none in the MI camp realised there was an edge off the bat. Head and Abhishek went about their job nonchalantly while smacking almost every bowler around the park.

Wicketless once again, Jasprit Bumrah (0/54) was hit for 14 in his first over, Boult for 18

after 11 in his first, and Will Jacks was clobbered for 19 runs in his first as SRH raced to 62 in four overs.

The onslaught continued beyond the powerplay when MI brought in Ashwani Kumar (2-0-41-0), as SRH openers collected 23 runs off the left-arm seamer to continue with the carnage. SRH responded to MI's 93-run opening stand which took seven overs with 129 runs in only 8.4, with Head being the more dominant than Abhishek.

AGENCIES

No tactical tweaks for Titans

AHMEDABAD: Gujarat Titans' top order has faced some flak over not showing enough intent to attack like some of the other teams in IPL but assistant coach Parthiv Patel has dismissed any chances of a change in team's philosophy.

Ahead of the return leg home game against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Parthiv was reminded how GT despite an opening stand of 128 in less than 13 overs managed only 205 at Chinnaswamy Stadium and then lost the match with more than an over to spare. "I don't think we need to make any tactical changes as such. I think we are very comfortable the way we are playing, the way we are approaching the game. There is obviously a lot of talk about playing another brand of cricket. But I think we are playing the way we want to," he said.

AGENCIES

AHMEDABAD: Searching for some much needed consistency, Gujarat Titans face a stern test against a red-hot Royal Challengers Bengaluru in their Indian Premier League match here on Thursday.

At the halfway stage of the tournament, Gujarat Titans find themselves stuck in mid-table with four wins and as many losses from eight games.

In contrast, defending champions RCB have been in imperious form, registering six victories in eight matches.

RCB's new ball duo of Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood has wreaked havoc in tandem. While Bhuvneshwar has turned back the clock with his swing masterclass, Hazlewood has troubled the batters with Test match lengths targeting the outside edge.

Add to that the challenge of facing Krundal Pandya and his barrage of variations in the middle overs. GT have been labelled as top heavy with Sai Sudharsan, captain Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler again scoring the bulk of the runs. Washington Sundar has proved himself in the middle order while finishers like Shahrukh Khan and Rahul Tewatia have not set the stage on fire yet.

Jason Holder has been



Royal Challengers Bengaluru's Josh Hazlewood during a practice session PTI

RCB are favourites to win the game but there is always room for improvement

accommodated in the middle-order to lend more potency.

Both sides met only a week ago at the Chinnaswamy with RCB comfortably chasing down 206 with seven balls to spare. GT have also not been able to dominate at home, having lost two of their three games at Motera.

RCB are favourites to win the game but there is always room for improvement. Jacob Bethell, who played the last two

games due to injury to fellow Englishman Phil Salt, was not able to make an impact.

The highly rated star would be itching to make a statement on Thursday night while batting alongside Virat Kohli. Bethell displayed his special talent during the preceding T20 World Cup and it is only a matter of time. RCB totally annihilated Delhi Capitals in their previous game and that will only add to their confidence. "It's very important to follow your routines because you know it's still a long way to go, but I think we are just taking one game at a time. And the positive is that different players coming up and doing it for the team, I think that's a good sign for us," said Patidar.

AGENCIES

IN EYE OF THE STORM

Not so Royal: Parag lands in vaping row

NEW DELHI: Rajasthan Royals captain Riyan Parag has courted controversy after TV cameras caught him "vaping" in the dressing room during his team's Indian Premier League game against Punjab Kings in Mullanpur.

The Indian government had banned e-cigarettes back in 2019, prohibiting their production, sale and distribution. As per the law, the offender faces imprisonment up to one year and/or a Rs one lakh fine for a first time offence.

Parag, who has not had the best of times with the bat this IPL, was seen inhaling an e-cigarette, also known as vaping, in the dressing room during the live broadcast of their game against Punjab Kings on Tuesday night. The act caught on camera triggered immediate reaction on social media. Parag made a 16-ball 29 in his team's successful chase of 223.

IPL and BCCI officials involved in the conduct of the IPL termed it as a careless act in the age of social media and prying TV cameras.

"A lot of players consume e-cigarettes but they don't do it in the dressing room. It is too risky and careless to be doing that with so many cameras around. With Parag caught vaping so openly, the BCCI might be forced to act," said a well-placed IPL source.

No Rajasthan Royals team official was available for a comment. This is not the first controversy to hit the Royals this season. Earlier this month, team manager Romi Bhinder was fined Rs one lakh for



Riyan Parag's form too has been a subject of criticism PTI

It is difficult to defend something like this. An elite athlete caught smoking like this is not setting a good example for the public — A source

breaching PMOA protocol after being found using his phone in the dugout.

Another IPL source said the issue of players' privacy in the dressing room was raised at the Captains Meeting in Mumbai ahead of IPL 2026. Some of the captains had raised an objection to cameras panning to the dressing room during the live broadcast.

"It was not specifically related to the use of e-cigarettes in the dressing room," AGENCIES

India pipped 3-2 despite Ayush, Prannoy wins in Thomas Cup

HORSENS: India went down 2-3 to China in their final Group A tie of the Thomas Cup Finals, despite fighting comeback wins from Ayush Shetty and HS Prannoy here on Wednesday.

The 2022 champions India, who have already sealed their quarterfinal spot, were on the back foot after Lakshya Sen and the doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty lost close encounters to concede a 0-2 lead.

Under pressure, Ayush delivered, recovering from a game down to beat Weng Hong Yang 17-21, 21-13, 21-15 in the second singles and reduce the margin. It came down to the second doubles match but the pair of Hariharan Amsakuran and MR Arjun couldn't



Ayush Shetty won in three games BWF

BWF

get across He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu, losing 17-21 13-21 as China took a 3-1 lead. Prannoy then rallied from a game down to beat Lu Guang Zu 20-22, 21-19, 21-11 in the third singles to reduce the mar-

gin of the defeat. Lakshya had beaten world No. 7 Li Shi Feng en route a runner-up finish at the All England Championships last month but he could not replicate that form and lost 19-21 21-8 12.

AGENCIES

UCL: Goals galore as PSG take slim lead to Bayern

PARIS: Titleholders Paris Saint-Germain trailed early, led by three goals and ultimately held on for a pulsating 5-4 win over Bayern Munich in the highest-scoring semifinal match in Champions League history.

And there's still next week's second leg to come. PSG built a 5-2 lead early in the second half thanks to two goals each from flying winger Khvicha Kvaratskhelia and Ousmane Dembélé at Parc des Princes.

"We deserved to win, we deserved to lose, we deserved to draw," PSG coach Luis Enrique said.

"It was an exceptional match. I have never experienced a match of such intensity as a coach. I have never seen a



Bayern Munich Luis Diaz scores his side's fourth goal AP

AP

rhythm like that, it was incredible, you have to congratulate all the players."

Down by three goals, Bayern fought back brilliantly. Defender Dayot Upamecano's header midway through the

second half from Joshua Kimmich's free kick gave Bayern hope and Luis Diaz's stinging strike made it a one-goal deficit heading into next Wednesday's return leg in Munich. "I think something special can

happen at home, there will be 75,000 people, it will be a hell of an atmosphere," Bayern coach Vincent Kompany said. "The Allianz Arena is a mythical area where Bayern has enjoyed much success."

AGENCIES

This year's World Cup games could be sizzling

LOS ANGELES: As global temperatures rise, extreme heat could threaten athletes, fans, workers and officials during this year's World Cup games.

Sixteen cities across the United States, Mexico and Canada will be hosting the 2026 World Cup in June and July. On average, July is the hottest month of the year for the contiguous US, according to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, and it's only gotten warmer since record-keeping began in 1895. Wet bulb globe temperatures, which factor humidity, wind speed, sun angle and more, could exceed 90 F (32 C) in the afternoons in the Texas cities of Dallas and Houston and Monterrey, Mexico, research shows.

"Almost all of the host locations, 14 out of 16 of them, experience levels of extreme heat, which could be potentially dangerous to players, match officials and possibly spectators," said Donal Mullan, a senior lecturer at Queen's University Belfast who lead a paper last year examining the heat risks of this year's host cities. Some stadiums have the advantage of being fully covered, reducing the risks.

Exposure to heat, amplified during exertion, can lead to nausea, dehydration, headaches, stroke and, in extreme cases, death. Worries from some that millions of people could be exposed during the tournament were amplified in March, when record-breaking temperatures hit large swaths of the U.S. And with global temperatures rising because of pollution from burning oil, gas and coal, scientists have warned that staging soccer tournaments in the summer is getting more dangerous.

AGENCIES

North Eastern Railway

Open E-Tender Notice

On behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager/Engineering, North Eastern Railway, Lucknow, invites online tender for the following work, detail of which is as given below: E-Tender No.: NER-LJN-2026-78: Name of Work: NER-LJN-Division- (1) At LJN: Provision of Ballastless track at Line No. 6 & 5 at Lucknow Junction station. (2) At GTNR: Provision of Ballastless track at Line No. 1 at Gomti Nagar station. (BLT-ISF for speed up to 50 KMPH). Estimated cost(Rs.): 168246785.80. Earnest Money(Rs.): 3364900.00. Completion Period: 18 Months. 1. The tender, for the above tender number NER-LJN-2026-78 can be uploaded up to 15:00 hrs. on 21.05.2026 and this tender will be opened after 15:00 hrs. on the same day. 2. All the information related minimum qualification, complete details of terms and conditions of the above tender is available on North Eastern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. Tenderer should read the corrigendum (if any) available on the website related to this tender information before uploading the tender form and be sure to take into consideration as well. No. W/362/NER/LJN/2026/78/W-5 Dt. 28.04.2026

Div. Railway Manager(Engg.) N.E. Railway, Lucknow CP/RO-W-57

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NORTHERN RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

Name of Work with its location	Provision of CB alongwith associated equipments at DBHL/SP.
Approx. Cost of work	₹1,33,83,645.99/-
E-Tender Bid Online Submission Period	05.05.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 19.05.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	19.05.2026 (15.00 hrs.)
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in
E-Tender No.:	04-TRD-NDLS-2026-27
Dated	28.04.2026

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OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER TRANSMISSION LINE MAINTENANCE DIVISION II SRINAGAR PAMPORE.

Subject: Extension of e-NIT No. TLMD-II/ 01 of 2026-27; dt: 09.04.2026. No: TLMD II/253-55 dt:29.04.2026.

(Extension-I)

Due to the poor response to the tender & in view of requests received from prospective bidders, the fresh dates for e-filling of e-NIT No.TLMD-II/ 01 of 2026-27; dt: 09.04.2026 for the work "Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of 02 No. 50 MVA, 132/33KV Three Phase Power Transformers (Buffer) at 132/33KV GSS Pampore & Amargarh of JKPTCL Kashmir" are hereby extended as detailed below:-

Last Date of online filling of e-bids	13.05.2026 up to 02:00 pm
Date of opening of e-bids	14.05.2026 at 02:00 pm

DIP No:DIPK-NB-313/26

Sd/= Executive Engineer TLMD II Pampore

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!

IMPORTANT INFORMATION

RUN OF MORE SUMMER SPECIAL TRAINS-2026

In order to clear extra rush of passengers during the upcoming Summer Season, Railways have decided to run the following additional Summer Special Trains as per details given below:

03435/03436 Malda Town-Anand Vihar(T.)- Malda Town Special (Weekly)				18 Trips
Train No. 03435	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 03436
---	---	09:30	Malda Town	22:30
13:40	---	---	Anand Vihar(T.)	14:50

Days of run : 03435 Ex. Malda Town from 04.05.2026 to 29.06.2026 (Monday) and 03436 Ex. Anand Vihar(T.) from 05.05.2026 to 30.06.2026 (Tuesday).

Composition: 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General Stoppages: New Farakka Jn., Barharwa Jn., Sahibganj Jn., Pirpainti, Kahalgaon, Bhagalpur, Sultanganj, Jamalpur Jn., Abhaipur, Kiul Jn., Sheikpura, Warisali Ganj, Nawadah, Tilaiya Jn., Gaya Jn., Anugraha Narayan Road, Dehri On Sone, Sasaram, Bhabua Road, Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn., Prayagraj, Govindpur & Tundla Jn. Stations.

01079/01080 Chhatrapati Shivaji(T.)-Gorakhpur Chhatrapati Shivaji(T.) Special (Daily)				124 Trips
Train No. 01079	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 01080
---	---	22:30	Chhatrapati Shivaji(T.)	00:40
04:10	04:15	---	Lucknow	19:50
10:00	---	---	Gorakhpur	14:30

Days of run : 01079 Ex. Chhatrapati Shivaji(T.) from 15.05.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Daily) and 01080 Ex. Gorakhpur from 17.05.2026 to 17.07.2026 (Daily).

Composition: 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General Stoppages: Dadar, Thane, Kalyan Jn., Igatpuri, Nashik Road, Manmad Jn., Jalgaon Jn., Bhusaval Jn., Khandwa, Itarsi Jn., Bhopal, Bina Jn., Virangana Laxmibai Jhansi, Orai, Kanpur Central, Gonda Jn., Basti & Khatlabad Stations.

01415/01416 Pune-Gorakhpur-Hadapsar Special (Daily)				124 Trips
Train No. 01415	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 01416
---	---	06:50	Pune	---
---	---	---	Hadapsar	03:15
10:00	10:05	---	Lucknow	22:30
16:00	---	---	Gorakhpur	17:30

Days of run : 01415 Ex. Pune from 15.05.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Daily) and 01416 Ex. Gorakhpur from 16.05.2026 to 16.07.2026 (Daily).

Composition: 2 Tier AC, 3 Tier AC, Sleeper & General Stoppages: Daund Chord Line, Ahmednagar, Kopergaon, Manmad Jn., Bhusaval Jn., Khandwa, Itarsi Jn., Rani Kamalapati, Bina, Virangana Laxmibai Jhansi, Orai, Kanpur Central, Gonda Jn. & Basti Stations.

04503/04504 Kalka-Shimla-Kalka Special (Daily)				154 Trips
Train No. 04503	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04504
---	---	12:30	Kalka	01:15
18:20	---	---	Shimla	20:20

Days of run : 04503 Ex. Kalka and 04504 Ex. Shimla from 30.04.2026 to 15.07.2026 (Daily).

Composition: Chair Car & General Stoppages: Dharampur Himachal, Barog, Solan & Taradevi Stations

04216/04215 Sultanpur Jn.-Sabarmati-Sultanpur Jn. Special (Weekly)				18 Trips
Train No. 04216	ARR.	DEP.	STATIONS	Train No. 04215
---	---	04:00	Sultanpur Jn.	17:00
07:20	---	---	Sabarmati	08:50

Days of run : 04216 Ex. Sultanpur Jn. from 17.05.2026 to 12.07.2026 (Sunday) and 04215 Ex. Sabarmati from 18.05.2026 to 13.07.2026 (Monday).

Composition: 3 Tier AC Economy & General Stoppages: Lucknow Jn., Kanpur Central Jn., Etawah Jn., Agra Cantt., Bharatpur Jn., Bandikui Jn., Jaipur Jn., Kishangarh, Ajmer Jn., Beawar, Marwar Jn., Rani, Falna, Sumerpur-Jawai Bandh, Pindwara, Abu Road, Palanpur Jn. & Mahesana Jn. Stations.

For any kind of information and detailed time-table etc., passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or may visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

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'It's gonna be big, very big,' says the actor, who plays the role of Munna Bhaiya



MIRZAPUR: THE FILM

Divyenndu promises full 'PAISA VASOOL RIDE'

Mirzapur: The Film' is easily among the most anticipated projects of the year and the excitement has only intensified with Divyenndu Sharma returning as Munna Bhaiya. With fans closely tracking every update, the actor shared a glimpse of what's in store and it sounds massive.

Speaking to 'News18', Divyenndu didn't hold back on his excitement. "It's gonna be big, very big. So much fun shooting that one; it's going to be full 'paisa vasool'. It is something people are waiting for. Let me not oversell it or reveal things, varna log bohut zyada karte hain, but whatever we have done is glorious," he said, hinting at a high-octane cinematic experience.

While the return of Munna Bhaiya has fans thrilled, Divyenndu admitted that stepping into intense roles comes with its own pressures. The actor, who is also gearing up for his upcoming action thriller 'Glory', opened



Divyenndu admitted that stepping into intense roles comes with its own pressures

up about navigating audience expectations. "It becomes both exciting and challenging," he shared, adding, "My character in 'Glory' is the one I have done the most intense prep for." Despite the massive popularity of Munna Bhaiya, Divyenndu

is consciously trying to detach from the shadow of the character. According to him, even appreciation can become a burden if it starts influencing choices. "As an artist, I absolutely distance myself even from the love and appreciation of people because that can be problematic. I don't want that pressure on my shoulders that it needs to be better than this character or that character. I have to move on from there," he explained.

The film brings back the iconic 'Mirzapur' universe, led by Pan-kaj Tripathi as Kaleen Bhaiya and Ali Fazal as Guddu Pandit, alongside Divyenndu's much-awaited comeback as Munna Bhaiya. The ensemble also features Jiten-dra Kumar, Ravi Kis-dugal, Shweta Tripathi, Shriya Pilgaonkar and others.

AGENCIES

PVR INOX to release David Dhawan's hits

The film festival is curated to honour his legacy

For almost a decade, filmmaker David Dhawan redefined the mainstream Hindi cinema with hit comedies such as 'Raja Babu', 'Aankhen' and 'Partner'. Now, some of his biggest hits are set to be re-released by PVR INOX to celebrate the filmmaker's legacy.



An FTII graduate, he has had a career spanning over 40 years, marked by a distinctive filmmaking style

The film festival has been curated to honour his legacy ahead of the release of his latest film, 'Hai Jawani Toh Ishq Hona Hai'. Dhawan, with Govinda and Salman Khan, was the creative force behind some of the most iconic entertainers of the 1990s.

An FTII graduate, he has had a career spanning over 40 years marked by a distinctive filmmaking style that blended comedy and family dramas. "At PVR INOX, we strongly believe in the enduring power of the theatrical experience and in celebrating filmmakers whose

work has shaped India's collective moviegoing culture. It is an honour for us to host a festival dedicated to David Dhawan's remarkable legacy. This festival is a rare opportunity for newer audiences to rediscover some of his iconic films in the format they were originally created for," Niharika Bijli, Lead Strategist, PVR INOX Ltd, said.

Dhawan said, "I have always believed in making films that entertain people and help them forget the struggles of their daily lives. My idea has always been simple: make people laugh, feel good about life, even if just for those three hours and walk out of the theatre with a smile. To see PVR INOX curate a festival around my work and bring these films back to the big screen is heartwarming. These films were made with a lot of love, energy and instinct." PFI

Prime Video unveils premiere date and glimpse of 'Sterling Point'

The cast includes Ella Rubin, Amélie Elisabeth Hoferle, Jacob Whiteduck-Lavoie & others

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' announced the premiere date and shared a glimpse of the new drama series, 'Sterling Point' from Megan Park ('My Old Ass'). The series will debut all eight episodes globally on August 5.

'Sterling Point' is a heartfelt, coming-of-age drama led by 17-year-old Annie Jacobson (Ella Rubin). Raised in New York City with her twin brother (Keen Ruffalo) and loving adoptive father



(Jay Duplass), Annie's life takes a turn when she inherits her mysterious grandfather's island in Canada. There, she finds new friends, budding romances and untold family

secrets. The cast also includes Amélie Elisabeth Hoferle, Jacob Whiteduck-Lavoie, Daniel Quinn-Toye, Bo Bragason, Jeffrey Dean Morgan, Nikko Angelo Hinayo,

Mabel Strachan, Elle-Majja Tallifeathers and Missi Pyle.

'Sterling Point' is created by Megan Park and produced by Amazon 'MGM Studios', 'Fake Empire'

It is a heartfelt, coming-of-age drama led by 17-year-old Annie Jacobson

and 'LuckyChap'. Park serves as a director, co-showrunner and executive producer alongside Josh Schwartz and Stephanie Savage, under their 'Fake Empire' banner and Dani Gorin and Tom Ackerley under 'LuckyChap'.

BTS teams up with Maggie Kang for new docuseries

Popular South Korean band BTS has teamed up with Maggie Kang, the director of Netflix's 'KPop Demon Hunters', in their short documentary series 'Keep Swimming with BTS'.

The documentary series brings to life the message of 'moving forward' introduced in the lead single 'Swim' from their new album 'Arirang', translating its theme of navigating the waves of life at one's own pace and without resistance into a real-world story.

In contrast to a culture that often prioritises visible success, the campaign shifts focus to the value of everyday consistency and the unseen effort behind progress. Rather than celebrating only moments of success, it underscores the quiet perseverance built through repetition and dedication.

On April 27, Kang appeared in the series, where she spoke about her Oscar win, the making of 'KPop Demon Hunters', her identity as a Korean and the driving force behind creating the film. "I still can't really believe it, even now that it won an Oscar. I genuinely wanted to depict Korean culture through animation. After watching this film, I felt that sense of Korean pride meant so much to me."

On her Korean identity, she remarked, "Even though I've lived



Titled 'Keep Swimming with BTS', the short documentary series brings to life the message of 'moving forward'

abroad longer, it's strange. Every time I come to Korea, the moment the plane touches down, I feel like, 'I'm home'. Being Korean has always felt like my number one identity."

The series, which began on April 7, brings together Korean

figures from across disciplines who have made a global impact, each reflecting on their own 'Keep Swimming' moments, including cinema auteur Park Chan-wook, fashion designer Nora Noh, Olympic gold medalist snowboarder Choi Gaon and Venerable Sun-jae, with more participants to be revealed on BTS' official social media channels.

On April 25-26, BTS kicked off their 'BTS World Tour Arirang in North America' with the first two of three sold-out shows at Raymond James Stadium in Tampa, Florida, marking their grand return to North America. PFI

Preity Zinta slams intrusive paparazzi culture

She is a 'private person' and finds the intrusive paparazzi culture scary



Preity Zinta says she is a 'private person' and finds the intrusive paparazzi culture scary. Zinta recently conducted an AMA session on her 'X' handle, where she answered questions from her fans and followers. One user went on to ask the actor what she would choose between fame, privacy and peace of mind and if she had to sacrifice any of them.

Replying to the question, Zinta shared a lengthy note and said that despite wanting to interact with her

fans, there have to be certain boundaries. "Nothing is a sacrifice. I have learnt to accept things the way they are and manage expectations. Now life is a big balancing act for me because I'm a very private person. I do love interacting with my fans and not disappointing anyone by giving them pictures, but at the same time, one has to set boundaries with people and the media," she wrote.

The actress noted she doesn't like it when photographers try to capture pictures of her children without permission. "I don't like it when people or media try to take photographs of my children (that's non-negotiable) and take pictures of me without asking cuz when anyone asks, I always say yes unless I'm in a rush to catch a plane or when I'm in a temple. I also don't like paparazzi following me around and jumping at me out of nowhere. Sometimes it's scary. I know a lot of the current crop of actors invite the paparazzi to come and photograph them," she said. PFI



Zinta will next feature alongside Sunny Deol in 'Lahore 1947'

Sony BBC Earth to air special on David Attenborough's 'Life on Earth'

First broadcast in 1979, it was watched by over 500 million viewers worldwide

Sony BBC Earth' will air a one-hour special marking the 100th birthday of legendary natural historian and presenter Sir David Attenborough on May 8, offering viewers a behind-the-scenes look at the making of 'Life on Earth', the landmark wildlife series that redefined natural history filmmaking.

"Making Life on Earth: Attenborough's Greatest Adventure" will premiere on May 8 at 1 PM and 9 PM, coinciding with Attenborough's centenary. The special features include exclusive interviews with Attenborough and members of the original crew, revisiting the

The landmark wildlife series that redefined natural history filmmaking

making of a series that took filmmakers across some of the world's most challenging terrains - from political unrest in Comoros and Rwanda to threats in Iraq.

First broadcast in 1979, 'Life on Earth' was watched by over 500 million viewers worldwide and is widely regarded as a defining moment in factual storytelling.

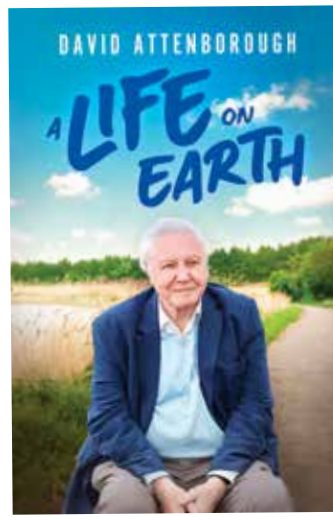
Attenborough's encounter with gorillas in the mountains of Rwanda during the series is frequently cited as one of the greatest moments in television history.

In the special, Attenborough reflects on the series' significance. "There was one series that changed everything - 'Life on Earth'. It was the most ambitious wildlife expedition ever undertaken, the first truly global natural history series filmed entirely in colour. What we set out to do was tell the greatest story to the world. That was a turning point in my life," he says.

The premiere will mark the

culmination of Sony BBC Earth's '100 Days Tribute', a curated programming initiative featuring some of Attenborough's most iconic works across decades.

'Making Life on Earth: Attenborough's Greatest Adventure' is executive produced by Mike Davis, with Victoria Bobin as producer-director. Over the years, 'Sony BBC Earth' has aired several of Attenborough's acclaimed productions for Indian audiences, including 'Planet Earth I and II', 'Blue Planet II', 'Frozen Planet', 'The Hunt', 'Dynasties' and 'Life'. PFI





STATE BANK OF INDIA,
CRAMC New Delhi (65299), NBCB Building, 2nd Floor,
Bhishma Pitamah Marg, Lodhi Road, New Delhi-110003.

(RULE - 8(1) POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
Whereas, the undersigned being the **Authorized Officer of the State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi** under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets & Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13(12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued a Demand Notice Dated **20.02.2026** calling upon the Legal Heirs of Late Shri Aravind Kumar i.e. Mrs. Chanda Devi W/o Late Shri Aravind Kumar, Ms. Shagun D/o Late Shri Aravind Kumar and Mr. Ansh Kumar (UNG of Mrs. Chanda Devi) S/o Late Shri Aravind Kumar, to repay the amount mentioned in the said Demand Notice being **Rs.55,63,895/- (Rupees Fifty Five Lakh Sixty Three Thousand Eight Hundred Ninety Five Only)** as on **20.02.2026** along with further interest at contractual rate w.e.f. 08.06.2025 and costs and other legally recoverable dues in terms of the loan agreements executed by the said Borrower from time to time in favour of the Bank within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.
The Borrower /Legal Heirs /Legal Heirs of the Borrower/Guarantors having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given by the Authorised Officer to the Borrower/Legal Heirs/Legal Heirs of the Borrower/Guarantors in particular and the public in general that the undersigned has taken **Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under **section 13(4)** of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on this **28th Day of April of the Year 2026**.
The Borrower /Legal Heirs /Legal Heirs of the Borrower/Guarantors in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of **State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi** for an amount of **Rs.56,46,678/- (Rupees Fifty Six Lakh Forty Six Thousand Six Hundred Seventy Eight Only)** as on 27.04.2026 along with further interest at contractual rate w.e.f. 08.06.2025 and costs and other legally recoverable dues in terms of the loan agreements executed by the said Borrower from time to time in favour of the Bank.
The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.
Description of the Secured Property against which the notice is issued:
Unit /Flat No.C-501, 5th Floor, Tower-C, Block-3, Rajnagar Residency, Rajnagar Extn. Saddik Nagar, Ghaziabad (U.P.)-201005, 4 BHK + 3 Toilet + Servant, Super Area 202.526 Sq.Mtrs.
Property owned by Mr. Aravind Kumar & Mrs. Chanda Devi
Place: NEW DELHI **Sd/- Authorised Officer,**
Date: 28/04/2026 **State Bank of India, CRAMC, New Delhi**

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr. Pc/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Surkhasha Sanhita
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person Namley **Devinder Bhatia** R/o H. No.41A-1, Shri Ram Road, Railway Colony near Civil Lines Metro Station, Civil Lines, Delhi. have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **Case No.6499/2020. u/s 138 NI Act.** has been registered at **P.S. Pahar Ganj, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Devinder Bhatia** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Devinder Bhatia** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Devinder Bhatia** of under **Case No. 6499/2020. u/s 138 NI Act.** has been, registered at **PS. Pahar Ganj, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.06.2026**
By Order
Ms Urvi Gupta.

DP/5564/CD/2026 **JMFC-01,NI Act, Room No.201,**
(Court notice) **CBA-II,Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi**

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE (Through e-tendering)
Tender No. 558-Sig-16-M-TENDER-1480 Dated: 28.04.2026

Name of work with its location	Provision of Fuse Auto Changeover System at Auto-Huts/Relay-Huts/Stations and Provision of data entry devices for Signaling Maintenance Management System (SMMS) over Delhi Division.
App. Cost of the work (₹)	Rs. 4,19,37,691.88/-
Bid Security (₹)	Rs. 8,38,800.00/-
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3rd Floor, Annex-1, DRM office, New Delhi-110055.
Date & Time for uploading the tender/closing of the tender	Tender uploading 28.04.2026 / closing date & time- 22.05.2026 upto 15.00 hrs.
Website particular & notice board location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at S&T branch, 3rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055. 1432/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



UJVN LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax: 0135- 2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

प.सं. 359 **e-Tender Notice** दिनांक: 29.04.2026
Office of the Executive Engineer (Galogi SHP), UJVN Ltd., Ganga Bhawan, Yamuna Colony, Dehradun, invites online tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Notice Inviting Tender No: 02/EE(Galogi SHP)/2026-27: Procurement of electrical items for Yamuna colony maintenance work.
Estimated cost: Rs. 9,92,788.00 (GST extra)
Date of availability of bid document on website: 29.04.2026
Last date for submission of tender: 23.05.2026 up to 16:00 hrs.
Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in>.
Executive Engineer (Galogi SHP)
"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1. Name of Work	Provision of additional 3rd floor with modern facilities in running room at Anand Vihar terminal in the section of SSE/W/ANVT under ADEN/NDLS
2. Approx. Cost of work	Rs. 1,84,59,348.42/- (Rupees One Crore Eighty Four Lakh Fifty Nine Thousand Three Hundred Forty Eight and Forty Two Paise Only)
3. Earnest Money to be Deposited	Rs 3.69,200.00/- (Rupees Three Lakh Sixty Nine Thousand Two Hundred Only)
4. Cost of tender document	Rs. 0.00/-
5. Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender.	20.05.2026 @ 15:00 Hrs.
6. Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen.	www.ireps.gov.in

• The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. • For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. • No manual offers are acceptable. • Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. No. 128-2026/W280/e Tender Notice/NT/08/2026-27/IN-3 Dated:-28.04.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 1438/26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Mubarak Hassan@Bille S/o** Khurshed Ali R/o Jhuggi No. N38/B53, CD Park, Jahangirpuri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 536/2022 U/s 25/54/59 Arms. Act PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi,** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mubarak Hassan@Bille** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mubarak Hassan@Bille** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mubarak Hassan@Bille** accused of ted (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 536/2022 U/s 25/54/59 Arms. Act PS: Jahangirpuri, Delhi,** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **02.06.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
DP/5493/NW/2026 **JMFC-07, Room No. 06 1st Floor**
(Court Matter) **Rohini Courts, Delhi**



Punjab State Power Corporation Limited
(Regd. Office: PSEB, Head Office, The Mall, Patiala-147001)
Corporate Identity Number:U40109PB2010SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in
Mobile No. 96461-55525

E-Tender Enquiry No.7801/P-3/EMP-13308 Dated:28.04.26
Dy.Chief Engineer / Headquarter (Procurement Cell-3) GGSSTP, Roopnagar invites E-Tender ID No. 2026_POWER_167174_1 for Procurement of M.S. Pipe of size 200 NB and 250 NB installed at dry fly ash handling system GGSSTP, Rupnagar. For detailed NIT & Tender Specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 29.04.2026 / 03.00 PM onwards.
Note :- Corrigendum & addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>
RTP-47/26 **PR-Adv. No :- 1079/12/2026-27/11028**

Government of Jammu & Kashmir
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER MECHANICAL & HOSPITALS DIVISION SRINAGAR
Telefax:- 0194-2496089,
Gist of e-tender
e-NIT No: M&HDS/TS /2026-27/04/e-tendering, (SHORT TERM)

For and on behalf of the Lt. Governor, J&K UT e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from registered/reputed/experienced firms with J&K State Govt., CPWD, Railways and other State/Central Governments for the below mentioned work: -

Name of Work	Est. Cost (Rs. in Lacs)	Cost of T./Doc. (In rupees)	Time of completion (in days)	AA Ac-corded Vide No:	TS No	Earnest Money	Position of Funds
1. Providing and Fitting of new oxygen Points at designated Emergency VVIP room at administrative Block of Govt. SMHS Hospital, Srinagar	0.83650	100	05	07 MCS of 2025 Dt: 23.04.2026	M&HDS/TS/01 Of 04/26	5% of the estimated cost	Available with intending

1. Downloading of Bids:- The NIT consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen from the departmental website www.uktenders.gov.in from 29.04.2026 (18.00 hrs) and can be downloaded from 29.04.2026 (18.00 hrs) to 05.05.2026 (13.00hrs) in two (02) covers.
2. Uploading: The bidders shall deposit their bids in electronic format on the above web site 29.04.2026 (18.00 hrs) to 05.05.2026 (13.00hrs) in two (02) covers.
3. Opening of Bids :- The bids received upto due date and time shall be opened on 05.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs
DIP No:DIPK-885/26
No: M&HDS/TS/507-11 Dated:29.04.2026
Sd/- Executive Engineer, MAHD, Srinagar



यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्रथम तल, कॉम्प्लेक्स कॉन्प्लेक्स, ओमेगा-1 (पी-2), ग्रेटर नोएडा
Toll Free No. 18001808296 वेबसाइट : www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

पत्रांक : आई ई.ए. /GM(P) / 2026 / 499 दिनांक: 27.04.2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना
निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केन्द्र सरकार / राज्य सरकार / केन्द्र शासित / अर्द्धशासित / सार्वजनिक उपक्रमों के कार्यों का कम से कम चार वर्ष का अनुभव रखने वाले ठेकेदारों / फर्मों से ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। ई-प्रोक्वायरमेंटसोप्लूशन द्वारा निविदाएं द्विस्तरीय पद्धति से खोली जायेगी।
कार्यालय आदेश संख्या: आई ई.ए./GM(P) / 2026 / 498 दिनांक 27.04.2026 के अनुपालन में यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण की कार्यों में संविदाकार द्वारा यदि न्यूनतम दरदाता (L1) द्वारा स्वीकृत बीओक्यू (BOQ) लागत से 10% तक कम दरे कोट की जाती हैं, तो कोई अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी जमा नहीं करनी होगी। लेकिन यदि न्यूनतम दरदाता द्वारा स्वीकृत बीओक्यू लागत से 10% से अधिक कम दरे कोट की जाती हैं, तो 10% से अधिक जितने भी प्रतिशत कम दरे कोट की जाएंगी, प्रत्येक 1% पर 1% की दर से अतिरिक्त सुरक्षा / परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी जमा करानी होगी।
उक्त अतिरिक्त परफॉर्मेंस सिक्योरिटी अनुबंध के निषादन (एग्रीमेंट करने) के समय ठेकेदार द्वारा जमा कराई जाएगी तथा परफॉर्मेंस गारंटी एफंडीआर/ सौंडीआर/ बैंक गारंटी/ पनअपसंसो के रूप में न्यूनतम संविदाकार द्वारा अनुबंध गठन से पूर्व देनी होगी, जो कार्य के अंतिम बीजक होने के बाद वापिस होगी।

क्रम सं०	कार्य का नाम / वर्क सर्किल	अनुमानित लागत
1	Construction of Boundary Wall of Library Campus at Village-Parsol, YEA-WC-06	रु० 11.64 लाख
2	C/o 12Mtr wide road infurnt of GH-10 in Sec-22D, YEA WC-02	रु० 30.80 लाख
3	Providing & Fixing of Solar Pump Construction of one room pumping out of water pond to gull and interlocking tiles work in Village-Sabota Mustafabad, YEA-WC-06	रु० 33.29 लाख
4	Providing & Fixing Plastic Dustbin in Villages-Zone-05, YEA-WC-06	रु० 25.07 लाख

जिन्हें दिनांक 04.05.2026 से 14.05.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन दिनांक 15.05.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।

क्रम सं०	कार्य का नाम / वर्क सर्किल	अनुमानित लागत
5	Miscellaneous Necessary Civil Maintenance work of Village-Achheja, Parsol, Dhanori, Mutaina, Sakka, Alipura, Gadana, Wailana, Ampur Bangar & Mohammadpur Gurjar in Zone-2 in YEIDA WC-06	रु० 16.21 लाख
6	Providing Tractor with Trolley and JCB for One Year in Jewar Bangar Gaushala, YEA (2026-27). WC-06	रु० 08.91 लाख
7	Supply & Stacking of Bhusa for Two Year Chanchali Gaushala, YEA.WC-06	रु० 65.70 लाख
8	Providing & Fixing Solar Pump Construction of one room pumping out of water pond to gull and interlocking tiles work in Village-Khwaipur, YEA. WC-06	रु० 18.98 लाख
9	Construction of Approach Road & Chainlink Fencing for Shamshan Sthal in Village-Suhedi Mahiuddinpur, YEA WC-06	रु० 15.15 लाख
10	Procurement and installation of animal cremator in faleda banger gaushala campus, YEA WC-06	रु० 103.25 लाख
11	Remaining Interlocking tiles work including construction of drain in Village-Doongarpur Reelka, YEA WC-06	रु० 24.86 लाख
12	Plantation of trees & shrubs in 50 mtr wide green belt & 30 mtr wide road central verge and 24 mtr road both side patri Sector - 22E with two year maintenance, yeida WC-H	रु० 72.88 लाख

जिन्हें दिनांक 05.05.2026 से 14.05.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालीफिकेशन दिनांक 15.05.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 बजे खोली जायेगी।
निविदा प्रपत्र उत्तर प्रदेश इलेक्ट्रॉनिक्स कारपोरेशन की वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर देखे जा सकते हैं।
इच्छुक ठेकेदारों से अनुरोध है कि वे नियमित रूप से उक्त वेबसाइटों को देखते रहे क्योंकि निविदाओं के सम्बन्ध में कोई बदलाव अथवा अतिरिक्त सूचना वेबसाइट पर ही उपलब्ध करायी जायेगी।
महाप्रबन्धक (परियोजना)
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग / हाउसिंग / कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के ग्रामिक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।

CHHATTISGARH STATE POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY LTD.
No.02-08/NNY/2025-26/Tr. No.-3015 & 3016/376 /Raipur Dt- 23.04.2026
NOTICE FOR E-TENDER
1. As per MD CSPDCL U.O. Note No. 1252 dt. 15.09.2025, short Term online bids are invited through CSPDCL tendering system (SAP SRM) from Eligible Electrical Contractors registered in the O/o CE (PROJECT), CSPDCL, Gudhiyari, Raipur for following works. Registration of electrical contractors is opened & will be allowed for this tender till one day prior to date of opening of the tender. 2. The registration of contractor will remain open. For details and further notifications keep visiting <http://www.cspdcl.co.in> ->project department->ebidding portal. 3. Bidders may visit the site www.cspdcl.co.in/project_office/contractors_section to know the qualifying criteria for registration of contractors to be eligible for participating in the tender. **Bid information must be submitted in the prescribed format only. No deviation shall be permitted.**

Sr. No.	Tender No / Rfx no.	Name of work	Tender amount (excl. GST) (in Lacs.)	Eligible class for bidding	Time & Due date of submission
1	Tr.no - 3015 RFX- 8100051059	Electrification of vill.- KANDLAPARTI under Bhopalpatnam D/C of O&M Dn. CSPDCL Bijapur under NIYAD NELLANAR YOJNA (SIN).	₹ 1,19,40,070.00	Class I,II,III & IIIA	12.00 noon 04.05.2026
2	Tr.no - 3016 RFX- 8100051060	Electrification of vill.- PEDDAKORMA under Bijapur Rural D/C of O&M Dn. CSPDCL Bijapur under NIYAD NELLANAR YOJNA (SIN).	₹ 86,97,802.00	Class I,II,III & IIIA	12.00 noon 04.05.2026

CHIEF ENGINEER (PROJECT) CSPDCL: RAIPUR
"Electricity saved is electricity Generated" samvad 47669/1

Govt. of Jharkhand
Energy Department
Jharkhand Renewable Energy Development Agency (JREDA)
3rd Floor, S.L.D.C. Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi-834002.
Ph.: 0651-2491161, Fax: 0651-2491165,
E-mail: info@jreda.com; Website: www.jreda.com

BID ADDENDUM NOTICE
JREDA has published e-Procurement Notice on 24.04.2026 under Solar Hot Water System (ETC/FPC Based) Scheme, Prospective in light of above JREDA has decided to make the addendum of Pre-bid Meeting. Date and Time of Pre-bid Meeting are as follows:-

01	09/JREDA /SPV/SHW S/26-27	Request for Proposal (RFP) for selection of Agencies for Supply, Installation and Commissioning of Solar Hot Water System (SHWS) including 5 year CMC in the state of Jharkhand.	11.05.2026 (Monday) at 1.00 PM	378397
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Sd/- Director, JREDA, Ranchi
PR 378751 Energy(26-27):D

Govt. of Jharkhand
Energy Department
Jharkhand Renewable Energy Development Agency (JREDA)
3rd Floor, S.L.D.C. Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi-834002.
Ph.: 0651-2491161, Fax: 0651-2491165, E-mail: info@jreda.com;
Website: www.jreda.com

BID ADDENDUM NOTICE
JREDA has published e-Procurement Notice on 21.04.2026 under LED Mast Light Scheme, Prospective in light of above JREDA has decided to make the addendum of Pre-bid Meeting. Date and Time of Pre-bid Meeting are as follows:-

01	05/JREDA/SHMLS/ RC/26-27	Rate Contract for Design, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning including 5 years Comprehensive Maintenance Contract (CMC) of 60 W LED based solar High Mast Lighting systems (SHMLS) including Remote Monitoring System (RMS) & Global Positioning System (GPS) with Lithium Ferro Phosphate Battery on Turnkey basis across the state of Jharkhand.	08.05.2026 (Friday) at 2.00 PM	378211
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Sd/- Director, JREDA, Ranchi
PR.NO.378740 Energy(26-27):D

Govt. of Jharkhand, Energy Department
Jharkhand Renewable Energy Development Agency (JREDA)
3rd Floor, S.L.D.C. Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi-834002.
Ph.: 0651-2491161, Fax: 0651-2491165, E-mail: info@jreda.com; Website: www.jreda.com

BID ADDENDUM NOTICE
JREDA has published e-Procurement Notice on 21.04.2026 under Repairing, Maintenance of all old installed Solar Power Plant whose CMC Period expired Scheme, Prospective in light of above JREDA has decided to make the addendum of Pre-bid Meeting. Date and Time of Pre-bid Meeting are as follows:-

01	08/JREDA/GC RT/C MCO/ 26-27	Rate Contract for Selection of Agencies for CMC of installed Grid Connected Rooftop Solar Power Plants for 05 (Five) Years including replacement of PCUs and Batteries and other components as and where required basis at Various Districts in the State	11.05.2026 (Monday) at 3.00 PM	378223
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Sd/- Director, JREDA, Ranchi
PR 378743 Energy(26-27)#D

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Office of the Executive Engineer Public Works Division Latour
E-mail latour.ce@mahapwd.com Telephone 02382 / 200868Fax 02382 / 200147

Notice No. B-1 LTR- 05 For 2026-27 E-Tender
Online tenders for following Sanctioned works are invited by Executive Engineer Public Works Division Latour from the contractors registered with Government of Maharashtra in appropriated class. Tender Documents can be downloaded from web site of <http://mahatenders.gov.in> Right to accept or reject tenders is reserved with Executive Engineer Public Works Division Latour.
The Blank Tender forms can be download from date 30.04.2026 to 08.05.2026 upto 11:00 hrs. Download tender will be submitted online on or before date 08.05.2026 upto 11:00 hrs. open after date 09.05.2026 at 11:30. Pre-Bid Meeting Query Submitted Date 05.05.2026 at 11.00 am. The prebid for work is on 05.05.2026 at C.E.Public Works Region Office, Nanded please at 15.00 pm.

Note -
1. Details of Tender Documents Will be available on website <http://mahapwd.com> <http://mahatenders.gov.in>
2. For details contact - 24 x 7 Help Desk Toll Free No. 1800 3070 2232 Mobile No.+917878107985/86+917878007972 / 73 Email: proc.maharashtra@gmail.com cmppp-support@nic.in
3. Right is reserved to reject any or all tenders without any reason thereof.
4. We are not responsible for any problem crop up during the Online E-tender process.

Executive Engineer Public Work Division, Latour
Dgipr/2026-27/491



Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited
(IMPAIRED ASSETS PORTFOLIO MANAGEMENT DEPARTMENT (APMD))
Zonal Office (Delhi) Plot No.132-134 Sector 44, Gurgaon (Haryana) India
GSTIN: 06AAACT6167G1ZB (T) 0124-4715800
Email: iapmd.del@jkbank.com W: www.jkbank.com

Ref No. JKB/IARB/DEL/2026 **Dated: 20.04.2026**
To: M/s Shree Parsvnath Papers Prop: Paras Jain address S/O V K Jain, FF, 2181, Gali Hanuman Prasad, Masjid Khajoor, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-110006. (Borrower & Mortgager)
Also At: Unit Address: 127/6, FF Ward No. IX, Gali Batashan, Barshabulla Chowk, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-110006.
Mrs. Ranjana Jain W/o Sh. Paras Jain R/o 2181, Gali Hanuman Prasad, Masjid Khajoor, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-110006
Subject: Notice for Redemption of the property in terms of right vested with Borrower under Section 13(8) of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("SARFAESI Act, 2002")
Dear Sir/Madam,
As you are aware that the Authorized officer of the Bank had issued a demand notice on 11th November, 2022 under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter called the Act), against secured interest mentioned therein, which has been offered as security by you towards your/borrower's loan facility/ies.
Subsequently, the Authorized Officer took possession of the secured asset in the nature of Immovable properties on 17th February, 2024 under Section 13(4) of Act.
"Equitable mortgage of Shop No. 127/6 on first floor, part of property bearing municipal No. 127, ward No. IX, situated at Gali Batashan, Barshabulla Chowk, Chawri Bazar, Delhi-110006, with common entrance from property no. 118, Main Chowk Barshabulla Chowk, Chawri Bazar measuring plinth area about 6.90 Sq. Mtrs out of 76.23 Sq Mtrs with proportionate rights in land underneath excluding roof rights, title, interests, claims, easements, privileges and appurtenances, etc.
Whereas you have failed to satisfy your/borrower's liabilities to the Bank even after receipt of notice under Section 13(2) and 13(4) of the Act. Therefore, the Bank in exercise of its rights granted under the Act and Rules made thereunder, intends to initiate process of sale for recovery of the amount due.
You are hereby called upon to discharge in full your liabilities amounting to **Rs 39,99,010.20 (Rupees Thirty nine Lakh Ninety nine Thousand ten and Paise Twenty only)** as on 31-03-2026 with future interest thereon, costs and other charges (incurred /to be incurred) within 30 days from the date of this notice, failing which, the Bank shall proceed to realize the outstanding by sale of the mortgaged property.
May note that your right to redeem the mortgaged property shall extinguish on the date the Bank issues notice of sale as per Act and Rules made thereunder.
Yours faithfully,
Authorised Officer

Registered office Corporate Headquarters M.A.Road Srinagar 190001 Kashmir, India T +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 F +91 (0)194 248 1928 CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048 E info@jkbank.com W www.jkbank.net



AROUND THE WORLD

» IIT Madras to organize first-ever technology summit in Delhi

» Shiv Nadar Foundation and Said Business School, University of Oxford, launch India's Best Teachers' Awards

» Thapar Institute advances AI research with Imperial College London

» HomiBhabha State University concludes AI hackathon in Mumbai



BUZZER ROUND

Q) WHICH PLACE IS KNOWN AS THE 'DENMARK OF INDIA'?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our April 23 edition question: Tokyo

Correct answers were sent by: Subhasish Bhattacharya, Ravik Ghosh, Namita Majhi



NEWS & VIEWS

The Supreme Court of India on Wednesday reaffirmed that admitting students under the Right to Education Act is a national priority. It ruled that all neighbourhood schools, including private unaided ones, must promptly accept students allocated by the state.

The IIT Roorkee Department of Design recently organised a workshop on design interventions in wood and plastic products. The session centred on promoting product diversification, encouraging sustainable practices, and exploring innovative design approaches in the sector.

ENGINEERING, MANUFACTURING SEE LOW WOMEN PARTICIPATION

Up to 25% women in tech not prepared for high-skill roles

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India's technology and engineering workforce is expanding, yet a significant gender gap persists in specialised IT and tech roles. Women account for 35–38% of overall IT professionals, but there remains a 20–25% shortfall in job-ready women for niche technical skills. This is a key finding by TeamLease Degree Apprenticeship and GAN Global, which highlights that rising female workforce participation has not translated into stronger representation in high-skill technical roles.

Employable numbers are projected to reach 2.01 million by 2027, while demand could rise to 3.82 million roles, pushing the talent shortfall beyond 1.8 million.

Skill gap remain high across emerging technologies, with women facing challenges in several high-growth areas. These include advanced coding, cloud computing, artificial intelligence, and cybersecurity, as well as technical fields like manufacturing automation, EV maintenance, and telecom infrastructure.



structure. This gap highlights the need for more focused upskilling and training to improve participation in these roles.

Core engineering and manu-

facturing sectors continue to report both low participation from women and high skill gaps.

Apprenticeships are emerging as a strong pathway to employability

and a direct solution to bridge skill gaps. By combining earning, structured training, and workplace exposure, they are enabling women to transition into jobs, especially in Tier

NUMBER GAME

The report highlights a sharp drop-off in women's participation across education to employment:

» Women make up 43% of STEM graduates

» Their share declines to 30% in engineering programmes

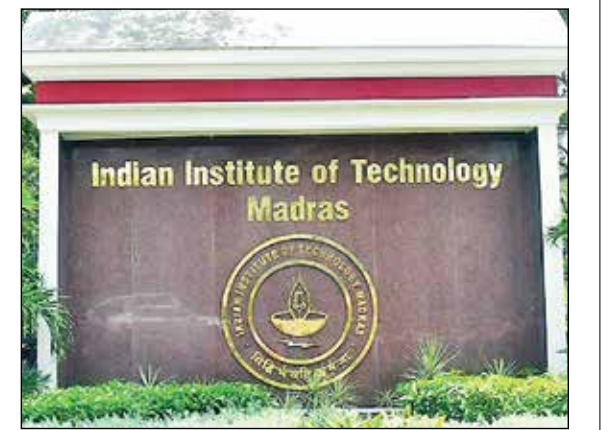
» Falls below 20% in core engineering disciplines such as mechanical, electrical, and civil

In the workforce:

» Women represent 14% to 16% of niche technical roles, including Java, Python, Cloud, Cybersecurity, and AI/ML.

» Employability in these roles remains low at around 22%

IIT Madras incubates 112 deep-tech startups



OUR CORRESPONDENT

The newly incubated startups span a wide range of critical deep tech sectors, including manufacturing, robotics, automotive, batteries, defence, aerospace, AI and ML

IIT Madras has achieved a key milestone in deep-tech entrepreneurship, incubating over 100 startups for the second consecutive year under its 'StartupShatam' mission. Through its nodal incubator, IITM Incubation Cell (IITMIC), the institute incubated 112 startups in 2025–26, building on last year's historic milestone. In parallel, IIT Madras continued its strong innovation momentum, filing 431 patents during the year, reinforcing its leadership in translating research into real-world impact.

In its 13th year, incubation at IITMIC crossed the 500-startup mark, reaching a total portfolio of 567 startups. The portfolio is collectively valued at over Rs 74,100 crore based on latest funding rounds, and includes two unicorns and multiple mergers/acquisitions.

The newly incubated startups span a wide range of critical deep tech sectors, including manufacturing, robotics, automotive, batteries, defence, aerospace, AI, machine learning, quantum technologies, analytics, fintech, healthtech, agritech, biotech, climate technolo-

gies, IoT, and cyber-physical systems.

IIT Madras highlighted strong activity in frontier areas such as AI/ML, quantum technologies, semiconductors, 5G/6G, robotics, advanced manufacturing, sustainable energy systems, photonics, blockchain, AR/VR, biomedical imaging, and advanced materials.

"FY25 was a landmark year with 103 startups incubated, setting a new benchmark for the IIT-Madras ecosystem. FY26 has been a year of consolidation, with over 1,200 applications received from across India and 112 startups incubated while maintaining a strong focus on quality and deep-tech orientation," said Dr Tamaswati Ghosh, CEO, IITM Incubation Cell.

Here's why students flock to Germany for higher education

Study opportunities paired with post-study work options boost appeal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Germany remains one of the top choices for international students pursuing higher education, especially at the bachelor's level. It is the most preferred non-English-speaking destination, hosting around 405,000 international students with over 50,000 of whom are from India, making them the largest interna-

tional student group in German universities.

To study in Germany, students generally need a visa and a residence permit, depending on their nationality and the length of stay. However, students from countries such as Australia, Canada, Great Britain, Israel, Japan, New Zealand, South Korea, and the United States can enter without a visa, as long as they do not take up employment after completing their studies. Students from EU or EEA countries only need a valid passport or ID card. Applicants from other countries must apply for a student visa through the German embassy or consulate in their home country. After arriving in Germany, this visa can be converted into a resi-

GLOBALLY HIT

» Germany hosts around 405,000 international students, with Indians forming the largest group

» Most students need a visa and residence permit, though some countries are exempt

» Students can work up to 140 full days yearly and get an 18-month job-seeking permit after graduation

» Entry depends on recognised school qualifications, and each university

sets its own criteria

» Wide choice of English and German programmes, plus scholarships from bodies like DAAD and universities

dence permit for study purposes. It is important to note that a tourist visa cannot be changed into a student visa later.

International students are allowed to work up to 140 full days

Admission to German universities depends on whether a student's school-leaving certificate is recognised and meets the required standards for higher education. Eligibility may be for subject-specific or general admission, depending on the qualification.

Germany offers programmes in both German and English, with around 300 courses available in English and approximately 2,000 in German. Language requirements vary depending on the programme and eligibility criteria. There are also numerous funding opportunities available. Some universities even provide tuition deferral options, allowing students to pay fees after securing full-time employment in Germany.





BEYOND CAMPUS

Students at the Satyajit Ray Film & Television Institute experienced an interactive week-long sound design workshop with Bishwadeep Chatterjee, a three-time National Award-winning sound designer known for films like Madras Cafe, Bajirao Mastani, and Uri: The Surgical Strike. Heshared insights of experience in films like 3 Idiots, Piku, Padmaavat, and his recent Dhurandhar. For the 21st batch of students of SRFIT, this was a deep look into the art of cinematic sound.

BLACKBOARD

IIT Rourkela researchers have secured a patent for a system capable of rapidly detecting and measuring adulteration in spices and other food products. Addressing the global food safety challenge, the developed technology combines Fourier Transform Infrared (FTIR) spectroscopy with advanced machine learning models to deliver accurate results.

IIT Hyderabad celebrated Foundation Day where 218 students, staff, and faculty members were felicitated for their contributions towards the growth and success of the institute. This initiative, started in 2020, is a gesture to recognize the dedication, hard work, and commitment of those who continue to make IIT Hyderabad a wonderful place to learn, work, and innovate.



IITKharagpur has honoured its distinguished alumnus Subir Chowdhury with the Life Fellow Award 2024, recognising his outstanding contributions to global leadership in operational excellence and quality management. A graduate of IIT Kharagpur with a BTech in Aeronautical Engineering, Chowdhury has been instrumental in advancing the global quality movement.



Trending

COURSES

DESIGN THINKING & INNOVATION WITH AI FROM IIM KOZHIKODE

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The design thinking and innovation with AI programme by IIM Kozhikode is a transformative learning experience tailored for professionals seeking to lead innovation in a digitally driven world. This 25-week professional certificate programme blends the principles of design thinking, AI integration, and strategic innovation to help participants solve complex business challenges with empathy and data-backed creativity.

Whether you're a product strategist, UX/UI designer, AI consultant, or a business

KNOW THE DETAILS

» Recorded video lectures delivered by renowned faculty

» Hands-on learning with capstone project and case studies

» Office hours and discussion boards

» Participants who complete the programme successfully with 70% of score in evaluation will get certificates

» A participant with less than 70% of score in the overall evaluation will not be awarded any certificate

» Programme to start on June 30, 2026

» Application deadline: April 30 at 11:59 pm

leader, this programme equips you with the tools to ideate, prototype, and implement solutions that drive measurable impact while learning

directly from the renowned faculty at IIM Kozhikode, who bring a blend of academic rigour and real-world insights to every session.